Just A Teenage Dirtbag, Baby

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25866499.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - High School, Scorpia gets angry, Abusive Parent, Catra is a delinquent, Adora is rugby captain, Validation, Acceptance, Falling In Love, Conflict, Drama, Fluff, First Date, First Kiss, Music, Band Club AU, Hurt/Comfort, School Drama, mentions of abuse, mentions of injury, Bullying, Catra is a magicat, everyone else is human, Purring, Scent Marking, kneading, playful hunting

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by ThisWriterD

Summary

Catra is president of the band club and known as the school delinquent. She's rude, intimidating and not worth it (according to everyone else). Adora is the new rugby captain, and she's immediately interested in the girl with the dark glare. Bow and Glimmer warn her away, but that just stokes the fire.

Despite all the warnings, Adora can't help herself. She finds out Catra's band club is facing disbandment because they need a third member, but when Catra rejects her offer to join, she realizes she has to put a bit more effort into showing Catra that she isn't just the hot jock everyone thinks she is, and she wants to find out if Catra really is so bad.

Notes

I've had this written up for a while, and I just need that validation yo. I hope you all enjoy!

Chapter 1

God, Catra really wondered how the fuck Scorpia had convinced her to go to their school's stupid rugby match on a Friday afternoon. She could have been at home shredding out a new song, but no, she was sitting there on the rusty pavilion, packed in with a bunch of sweaty, screaming teenagers. It made her nose twitch in disgust.

Catra could just get up and leave, but Scorpia kept looking her way every time she caught the ball or got up from a tackle, and she really didn't have the heart to disappoint her. Just imagining Scorpia's bright smile dropping off into a disappointed frown made Catra's chest clench and that just made her uncomfortable. And angry. Catra, caring about someone? As if.

But she was there, and she was watching the game, though with complete disinterest. The clouds were heavy above them as well, and Catra could smell rain in the air—made her fur feel clammy. Luckily the pavilion had a roof, but the field certainly didn't. Would they just continue to play? Even if it rained?

Her questions were answered when it started to drizzle and the girls just kept chasing after that damn ball. Scorpia was the biggest girl on the field with her insane height and packs of muscle. She was also, unfortunately, very clumsy. The team usually used her when they needed her to feign or distract, since she was like a beacon with all those inches.

Catra knew that if Scorpia wasn't quite so weird she would have been insanely popular. There were a couple of girls that fangirled over her, but they had disappeared over the last year, especially after Scorpia joined Catra's club and started hanging out with her.

Catra drew her legs up to her chest, tail curling around her ankles and rested her chin on her knees. She had her headphones on and some music blasting, because she couldn't handle the screaming

around her, but her music didn't relax her like it usually did. Her sensitive hearing meant that she could still hear the noise around her.

Catra felt out of her element. She could feel curious eyes on her, and she knew what the other kids were saying. They were wondering why *she* was there. They could all kiss her ass for all she cared, even though she actually did care. It was whatever.

When Catra's focus returned to the field, she easily found Scorpia running across the field with the ball cradled to her chest like an infant. Catra couldn't just hear it, but she could *feel* the screams of encouragement around her. Scorpia was running fucking fast, heading right for the other side where she was clearly aiming to get that try. She even managed to jump and avoid a tackle, but she made the mistake of immediately celebrating and didn't see the player to her right.

Scorpia went down hard, face right in the mud. Everyone converged as Scorpia fought to shield the ball, and then she handed it off and it was thrown back into play. Catra straightened to get a better view, her claws now digging into the fabric of her uniform skirt.

"Go Adora!" someone screamed loudly right beside her. "Run like your life depends on it!"

Catra's tail whipped in annoyance, fluffed up, and she turned to glare at the dude, but he didn't even know she existed. She recognized him as Bow, the captain of the swim team *and* president of the archery club. His dads were famous academics or something, so he was something of a celebrity himself. Catra just thought he was annoying. Who came to a rugby game in the dreary weather, with a fucking crop top on?

Next to Bow was his girlfriend, Glimmer. She seemed intensely bored of the whole thing, which Catra could at least relate to, but other than that, Catra didn't like her. Glimmer's mother was on the

board of directors for their school and had a huge say in what happened, which meant that Glimmer had a lot of power.

Catra hated people with power like that. She also just hated Glimmer in general, for very specific reasons.

Disgusted, she adjusted her headphones and upped the volume, seriously considered leaving right then and there, Scorpia be damned. But she glanced back at the field, and that's when she noticed her.

Player 9, blonde hair in a ponytail that was swishing wildly, a body like a powerhouse, darting across the field. She jumped and dodged and twirled, successfully evading every tackle attempt and scored that try without effort. From the corner of her eye, Catra saw Bow and Glimmer standing up and jumping around, hugging, so it was easy to guess that player 9 was Adora.

Adora . The new kid. Catra had heard about her since she'd transferred a few weeks ago, but she hadn't seen her until then.

After Adora's miraculous try, she scored a kick and closed the game off with a monumental win. When the whistle blew to signal the end of the game, the entire team converged on her and lifted her up into the air. Scorpia was beaming so brightly that Catra wondered if her facial muscles would freeze like that.

Bow and Glimmer immediately rushed off the pavilion and others started to filter out as well, clearing the space enough that Catra could breathe again. She felt cold and clammy, even with fur literally all over her body. There was a dampness in the air now, and it made Catra uncomfortable. She *hated* having damp fur.

Catra could smell Scorpia's scene before her eyes flicked downwards to see her approaching. Her one ear swivelled in Scorpia's direction before she even shouted.

"Catra! Hey , Catra!"

Scorpia stopped at the low fencing they used to surround the field, fingers closing around the cold metal. Steeling herself, Catra let her headphones hang around her neck and took the pavilion two steps at a time until she landed gracefully on the ground, tail swishing. She was barefoot, which had been a fight in itself. Catra hated shoes. She hated how off balance they made her feel, how difficult it was to move as easily in them. At first, she had been forced to wear them, until she started shredding every pair of shoes shoved onto her feet. After that, everyone agreed to just let her be. It sucked, most times, being the only magicat.

"Hey Muscle Head," she greeted with a smirk. "Had fun getting thrown ass over end?"

Scorpia was still flushed from head to toe. She was really pale, and she tended to go red whenever she felt any sort of intense emotion. It was also cold, Catra supposed. Scorpia's short ashen hair was slicked back and partially sticking to the edges of her face, and she had smears of mud on her skin and clothes.

"Catra!" Scorpia yelled. "Did you see me? I had the ball! I nearly got a try! Oh my gosh, that was so intense and also very scary . I thought I would have a heart attack when I got tackled."

Catra leaned against the fence and slid her hands into her skirt pockets. "Y ou celebrated too soon, dummy."

"I know ," Scorpia sighed. "But Adora' s a really cool captain," Catra' s ear twitched, "so I dont think shell be *too* hard on me. Coach, though." Catra could hear the wince in her voice.

The drizzle was starting to pick up, and Catra could hear the heavy droplets as they pelted against her fur. She didnt want to get wet, especially not out there on the field, at *school* .

"Y ou were pretty cool out there," Catra said, pushing of f from the fence, "even though you ate dirt. Literally . But you didnt hear that from me, got it?"

Scorpia snickered. "Scouts honour . Wont tell a soul that you complimented me." Her smile was warm and genuine. "Or that you came out to support me. I really appreciate it, Catra."

Catra's eyes widened. She didnt expect so much affection on Scorpia's face, and that made her very uncomfortable. She didnt really know how to respond or even react, and she was just about to say something rude to just, say *something* but then a throat cleared behind Scorpia and she startled, moving to show the person standing behind her. Catra's nose was hit with a scent she had only focused on vaguely until now. There was an earthy tinge to it, like cut grass and dirt, and there was of course the sweat, and then just a scent that was just...

Adora.

"Oh, hey!" Scorpia exclaimed, blushing brightly . "I didnt see you there, Captain! Im so sorry ."

Adora gave her a big smile and shook her head. "Naw , I snuck up on you, Scorpia. My bad."

"No, I should have heard you! Totally my fault."

Adora wound an arm around her shoulders. "That was awesome work out there today. You got excited a little early , but youve improved a lot. Im really proud of you."

Catra narrowed her eyes as Scorpia's widened. "You really think so?"

Adora nodded vigorously. "Oh, totally . Youre big, but you can use that to your advantage. Nextime youll get that try . I believe in you."

Scorpia was clearly flustered from the compliment, and she was saved~~which~~ maybe wasnt the best word, actually~~by~~ another girl shouting for her by the edge of the pavilion. At the sight of her

blonde, curly hair and the flowers woven into them, Scorpia nearly dissolved into a gay puddle on the floor.

"Oh geez, she made it!" Scorpia exclaimed. "I'm so sorry guys, I need to go and talk to her. Do you need anything else, Captain?"

Adora shook her head. "No, we're good. I just wanted to say I'm proud of your hard work." She smirked. "Go get your girl."

If it was even possible, Scorpia blushed brighter. She gave them a dorky little salute, then she hopped the fence and jogged over to Perfuma, the girl she had been crushing on hardcore for *years* .

Catra felt awkward, and like she should have just left the moment Adora cleared her throat. Now they were both just standing there, staring at Scorpia as she blushed and blabbered and Perfuma laughed in delight.

"So, I haven't seen you here before," Adora spoke suddenly .

Catra glanced up at Adora's face. For an embarrassingly long second, the breath got caught in her throat. Seeing Adora on the field was entirely different to right up close. Catra tended to avoid direct eye contact unless she wanted to intimidate someone, so she hadn't looked at Adora when she approached. But now she was looking directly into the most beautiful blue eyes she had ever seen. Adora's face was like, unfairly attractive.

Holy shit, she's really hot , she thought to herself, understandably flustered. She was all angled features and soft lips and seriously, how could her jawline be that sexy? Catra was almost angry about it.

"Hello?" Adora gave her a weird look and Catra realized she must have been saying something.

"What?" she blurted out a little rudely .

Adora frowned. "I was just introducing myself. I'm basically still new here and I haven't seen you around. I'm Adora."

"Yeah, I know," Catra bit out.

She was getting what she liked to call Stupid Gay Brain, which meant that her knee-jerk reaction to interacting with a girl so hot that being near her was probably illegal was to be rude as hell, something Catra excelled at.

Adora didn't seem insulted. In fact, she seemed surprised. "You know?"

Catra stared at her. "Adora Gray. You're like, the Jesus of this school. Of course I know who you are. Everyone here knows who you are."

Adora blinked. "Really?"

God, was she stupid too?

"You seriously don't see how this school fawns over you?"

The cutest little line formed between Adora's brows. "What? No, everyone is just really nice!"

"No, Adora. The people at this school are idiots and they love to worship anyone that's hot and cool enough."

Catra realized her mistake when Adora started to smirk. Stupid as she might be, she was apparently not *that* dumb.

"Oh, so you're saying I qualify as hot and cool enough?"

Catra's face warmed, but luckily Adora couldn't see her blushing through her fur. "What? No! I just—you know what, why am I even talking to you?"

She let her eyes roam over Adora one last time, to the hair falling out of her ponytail and sticking to her face, to the smudges of dirt and the way her shirt clung to her *very* toned body and god, her shoulders…

Catra lifted her nose, glared and then stormed off. She heard Adora call for her, but she didn't bother to turn back around to hear what she had to say. Why had Adora even wasted time talking to her?

A dark, painful thought entered Catra's mind and made her pause at the school gate. Before she'd grown a backbone, she'd been bullied a lot. It was a fun pastime for the popular kids to pretend to be nice to her just so that they could figure out the best ways to hurt her and then mock her for daring to trust in them.

Adora was probably like all of them. She ran with Glimmer and Bow and their crew. Practically looked like she'd grown right from the popularity tree.

Seriously, Scorpia owed her for wasting her entire damn day. Her mood was ruined, her thick hair was soaked through and she was hungry.

Catra went home agitated and anxious, but she couldn't get Adora's stupid hot face out of her mind. She needed to sink her claws into something. Goddammit.

"Whoa," Adora breathed, staring after Catra's back as she purposefully walked away. She had strong shoulders, like she did enough to be strong but not to bulk up, and Adora wondered what workout routine she did.

She was also insanely hot.

"I told you," Glimmer said with a self-righteous sniff. Adora hadn't heard them approach. "Stone cold. Rude."

“We tried to warn you,” Bow told her with an apologetic grin.

Adora kept staring after Catra until she couldn't see her anymore. “Yeah, I believe you guys now.”

On Adora's first day, she'd seen Catra in the hallway when they were switching classes. For gay reasons, she was instantly interested so of course the first thing she did was ask her new friends about her. They told her two things: Catra was trouble. Stay away from Catra. But Adora liked to form her own opinions on people.

She never had the chance to approach Catra herself, and when she heard Scorpia talking about her aloof buddy ~~ev~~eventually name dropping Catra ~~sh~~she convinced Scorpia to invite her to the game, telling her that having someone she cared about there to watch would improve her focus. Adora was totally talking out of her ass, but Scorpia was so trusting and wholesome, and clearly, she was pushy enough to get Catra to actually come to watch the game.

When Adora approached them, she'd been nervous. She didn't understand why. Catra already seemed dangerous and tricky, and Adora felt like she could very easily drown if she got too close to her. Good thing she was a good swimmer.

Of course, Bow and Glimmer had tried to convince her not to even try. Apparently, they had tried a few years ago ~~to~~ include her , help her, but she was just nasty to them and they gave up.

Adora wasn't a quitter though.

“She's feisty,” Adora told them. “I like it.”

Bow groaned. “Please tell me you're not—”

“Adora, you can't!” Glimmer cut in. “She's a complete delinquent. She gets detention like, every week. She's only still in this school because her mother has something over mine. I'm sure she's blackmailing her.”

Adora felt her brows climb. "Whoa, that's a serious accusation."

"You haven't met Sharon Weaver," Bow told her, grimacing. "Total dictator. No wonder Catra is the way she is."

"Exactly why I think I want to be her friend. She seems pretty cool."

"Uh, no," Glimmer said. "You'll just end up getting insulted in very creative ways. Seriously, don't even try. She's not worth it."

Not worth it. Those words stabbed Adora right in the heart in a way that made her anxieties rush up at her. She didn't want Glimmer to know that what she had said was triggering, so she just forced herself to smile casually.

"I can handle myself."

Glimmer stared at her, unimpressed. Finally she threw her hands up into the air. "Don't cry to me when she puts shit in your bag."

Adora was filthy, soaked through and caked in mud. She was tired of this argument and she could smell her own sweat, too. She just wanted to go home and relax in some hot water.

"Alright guys, let's go before I kill us all with my fumes."

"Yeah, you do stink a little," Bow agreed. "Sorry."

Adora just laughed at him.

Once she was home, she hurried into a bath and submerged until her lips touched the water. Afterwards she dressed, cleaned her room and settled at her desk to work on her homework. There was a test coming up too, but she really didn't feel like studying for it.

A knock sounded on the door as Adora was leaning too far back on her chair, balancing a pen between her nose and lip. The pen clattered to the floor, she nearly went with it, and her door creaked open with a chuckle beyond.

"I told you to stop riding that damn chair."

Adora broke into a big grin. "Hey, Mara! You're home early."

Mara went to sit down on her bed so Adora turned around in her seat so that she could see her.

"I tried to get off earlier so that I could watch your game, but we had that tournament for the little ones and I didn't want to rush them."

Adora waved her hand. "Hey, I totally understand. You can't let them miss kicking some ass, right? I won the game, as expected."

Mara's smile was soft. "I'm so proud of you, Adora. Seriously. You've really grown into such a mature woman. You're nearly nineteen, almost ready to move out." She pretended to tear up. "My child, ready to leave the nest."

Adora flushed. "Come on, *Mom,*" she teased, "you know you'll be stuck with me for a couple more years until I figure out how this whole adult thing works."

Mara laughed. "Of course."

She stood, bent to press a kiss to Adora's forehead that never failed to warm her up from the core and headed for the door. Adora grabbed hold of her hand to stop her.

"Wait."

Mara turned and gave her a questioning look. When Adora glanced away nervously, she likely guessed what she was feeling. Mara's hand covered hers and gave it a soft squeeze.

"What's up?"

Adora let out a soft breath. "I just. A friend said something that made me remember some stuff, and the anxiety came back and I just, I want to say thank you." She glanced up at Mara, hoping that

she was being clear enough about how incredibly grateful she was. "I really mean it, Mara. Thank you."

Mara tugged her out of the chair and into a crushing hug. God, she was so strong. They were almost at the same height now, which Adora was grateful for because she had spent many years looking up to Mara, wanting to be just like her, so to be able to stand at her level felt amazing. But even still, she felt like that same little kid in Mara's arms. But the difference was, back then she had been alone, terrified and angry, but now she was just happy and somewhat well adjusted.

Mara pressed a kiss against her temple. "Adora, you're my daughter. I may not have given birth to you, and I'm sorry that I didn't find you sooner, but you're still my kid. I love you, never forget that. You're worth everything to me. You are never a burden. Understood?"

Adora let out a shaky breath. Her tense muscles relaxed and she buried her nose against Mara's shoulder, inhaling the familiar scent of sweat mixed in with Mara's usual body spray. It reminded Adora of all the good moments from her childhood since Mara had adopted her, and it relaxed every one of her anxieties.

One thing Adora was always grateful for was Mara's complete understanding and willingness to remind her that she wasn't a burden and that she wasn't unloved, especially in times when Adora needed it.

Adora had healed from her childhood traumas. She could genuinely say that she had moved on and was such a strong person because of it, but sometimes it was a little difficult. Adora was making sure that she didn't bottle her feelings up anymore, which meant that when she felt insecure, she let herself feel it.

Maintaining her mental health was hard work, but it was worth it.

Mara left to order some food for them and Adora settled down at her desk again. She tried to finish her homework, she honestly did. But

her eyes kept unfocusing and she kept thinking of Catra.

Catra's brown fur. The freckles across her nose and cheeks. Her one brown and one blue eye. The cute little wrinkle she got on her nose when she was clearly caught off guard. Her thick hair, damp and curled around her ears. Her *ears* .

Before Adora knew it, she had her cheek cupped in her palm and she was grinning like a moron. She only snapped out of it when Mara called her downstairs to eat and she realized she had been sitting there for an entire goddamn hour just, thinking gay thoughts.

"Damn," she muttered to herself after exhaling through her nose.

This just confirmed it. She was crushing on Catra, and crushing hard.

Catra couldn't remember the dream, but she was left with a lingering sensation of unease. Even as she slowly woke up and the cloudiness of slumber melted away, the details of the dream alluded her. Catra was glad that she couldn't remember . Most of her dreams were nightmares, and it had only been a year or so since her last night terror.

She would scream herself awake, but there was never anyone to comfort her. She wouldn't even comfort herself.

Before her foster monster decided to head upstairs to wake her, Catra got out of bed and tiredly dressed for school. She made sure that she was neat and proper, and even buttoned up the top button of her shirt. She combed her hair and tied everything up in a bland, boring ponytail at the back of her neck. She hated how she looked, but she knew Sharon wouldn't let her step foot out of the house if she didn't look like an upstanding citizen. Without shoes, of course.

Absolutely everyone knew that she wasn't, even Sharon. This was just a version of make-believe that they both played, one where

Sharon liked to imagine that she was a good, caring parent, and one where Catra pretended that she didn't hate everything about her life.

Sharon was downstairs drinking one of her diet shakes as she read the newspaper. Catra didn't say a word as she went to the pantry to grab a slice of bread to pop into the toaster.

"Good morning to you too, Catra."

She clenched her teeth, ears flattening. "Morning," she mumbled.

"Speak louder . I can't understand you when you mumble."

They had barely exchanged words and Catra's temper was already flaring. She slammed her bread into the toaster, tearing off an edge with her aggression. She angrily grabbed at the chunk of bread and went over to the dustbin.

"I said good morning," she repeated as calmly as she could. She forced her body to react. If Sharon glanced up and noticed her ears pressed down or her tail puffed up, she would get overly offended.

She looked up and saw that Sharon was staring at her. It was always unnerving, those eyes piercing right into her soul. It made Catra's skin crawl. Even more, seeing the nasty scar that ran across Sharon's face. She had put herself through tons of plastic surgery in pursuit of her ideal of beauty, but there were still the remnants of the scar. It was always a constant reminder, and Sharon absolutely loved to use it for pity points.

Those dark eyes blinked and glanced away, and Catra felt like she could breathe again. Her toast popped out too enthusiastically and flew directly onto the counter. Catra just went to grab it and butter it before she left.

"Exams are coming up," Sharon brought up. "I expect you have been studying?"

Catra took her time to evenly distribute the butter and watched as it slowly started to melt. "Y es, mother."Using the term made her teeth clench in anger, but the shame was better than the fear when Sharon grew angry.

"Good. T ry to stay up later at night. You need to score as high as possible. I wish you would use that brain of yours and surpass that Glimmer girl. It's disgraceful that Angela's child is succeeding where mine isnt."

I'm not your fucking child , Catra wanted to snarl. Memories were threatening to bash against her soul from the inside, but she forced herself to stay calm. She had too much butter on the toast and it would turn soggy if she didnt eat it soon.

"Y our hair looks too unruly,"Sharon continued. "Have you been using that special shampoo that I spent so much money acquiring?"

Catra knew that lying wasnt an option. "No."

Sharon sighed. "Do you think my money comes from nowhere?"

Catra went to sit down at the table even though she *really* didnt want to, and took a big bite of toast so that she didnt have to respond. Sharon was in a mood, which meant Catra couldnt get away without receiving some verbal abuse first.

"I swear , it's like nothing matters to you,"Sharon said as if to herself, but loudly. "I've put so much ef fort into raising you after the accident, and you treat me like Im a monster ."

Catra's entire body felt like it was filled with concrete and her veins ice. She hated when Sharon brought up the accident. It made her feel sick to her stomach, especially because of what came nek

"I lost so much because of you,"Sharon sighed. "The least you could do is try."

Catra wished the floor would open up and swallow her whole. She wished she could just flip a switch and not exist anymore. The memory of the accident fluttered behind her eyelids, and it sent a sharp spike of pain through her chest. She felt small and insignificant, and when Sharon just huffed and then left, the newspaper fluttering onto the table, tears pressed at her eyes.

Everyone at school thought she was this big, scary person. What would they all say if they saw how pathetic she really was? How easy it was to reduce her to nothing? Catra dug her claws into her forearm, but she stopped herself before it started to hurt.

One thing she refused to do was hurt herself physically. She would *not* give Sharon that power over her.

Catra managed to finish her toast without more incident, and since Sharon had just left without saying anything, she had to walk to school. That was completely fine with her. Before she went, she undid the top button of her shirt and untucked the shirt from her skirt. She untied her hair and happily ruffled it into the usual mess, then slipped her acoustic into its case and slung it over her shoulder beside her school bag. There was a new song she had started playing, and she was actually eager to show it to Scorpia.

Still feeling a pit of despair in her stomach, Catra made the long walk to school. She got there just in time, but not without receiving a lecture from someone on the council and then also her register teacher. No one seemed to care that she was actually like only a minute late. It was like these people looked for any tiny reason to shit on her.

Sometimes she deserved it. Catra gave more than enough shit. But sometimes she wished someone would just realize that her behaviour had a cause, and that she wasn't such a piece of shit like everyone assumed.

The day seemed to slip by as if nothing was real. Catra spent most of the time humming to herself, phantom fingering cords against her

desk. She had already studied ahead, so she wasnt in danger of being lost with the work. Being on top of her school work was a *must* .

There was still the emotional abuse, but at least Sharon had stopped hitting her. Catra always worried that it would start up again, that Sharon would drink far too much again, throw the empty bottle at her head, again. She held so much anger and spite, and she always directed it all right at Catra.

As if she hadnt just been a fucking child. As if all of it hadnt been entirely out of her control. It was so unfair, but that was just her life. Catra didnt want to end up in the system, so she kept her mouth shut about her situation and studied her ass off. The only thing she definitely couldnt do was behave well, and at least Sharon had given up trying to correct that about her. So long as Catra didnt speak to *her* like that, it was whatever.

After school let out, Catra snuck onto the roof of the building so that she could do all of her school work and also get some practice in before meeting up with Scorpia for club. She had about an hour of free time until then. Scorpia was busy at rugby practise.

Thinking of Scorpia and rugby made Catra think of Adora, and her cheeks warmed for absolutely no reason. Why had Adora even spoken to her? They were on entirely dif ferent levels. Catra didnt trust it at all, and she knew she would need to be on her toes.

It didnt take long to finish up her homework and few remaining assignments, so with the last bit of time Catra pulled her guitar close, grabbed her old, worn pick and started to play. She had just perfected one of her favourite songs. The sombre song echoed right through her soul, and Catra shut her eyes tightly as she let the sound pound into her, both soothing her and ripping her open.

Music was the best escape. When she played, when her fingers danced over the chords, there was just her steady heartbeat and the

notes. Thoughts and emotions fled, and Catra was allowed to feel weightless in the false sensation that things were alright.

She played and played, calloused fingers aching. No one was allowed on the roof, but no one knew that she came up here. Most people were too busy with after school activities and club, so even if they heard her, they usually didn't bother . In all her years coming up here, no one had ever come up to investigate. Maybe if they thought it was her, they would, but so far she was still getting away with it.

Catra looked at the time and noted she was already late for club, so she finished playing and stood, dusting off the back of her skirt. She stared out at the rugby field. There was no one there, so training must have finished up. The grass looked so green, almost gleaming. The sun was hot and Catra was already sweating, so she hurriedly packed her things away and crept down the stairs to the second floor.

She tried not to think of anything as she made her way to the club room, but then stopped abruptly when she saw someone taping a note to her door. The girl was on the council, which could only mean one thing.

"Excuse me?" Catra growled loudly , taking a menacing step towards her. Her tail had gone full bushy. "What do you think you're doing?"

Mermista flinched at getting caught, but she wasn't frightened. She let out a bored sigh. "I didn't volunteer to do this," she said in that same monotone voice that drove Catra up the fucking wall.

Catra stalked over and snatched the paper from Mermista's hand with a hiss. She hadn't been successful in just sticking it to the door like she had planned.

"An eviction?" Catra snarled, baring her teeth. "Are you serious?"

Mermista just stared at her. "Look, I really don't care. But rules are rules."

"Your rules can eat shit," she spat. She balled the paper up in her fist and hated the fact that she could feel tears building up behind her eyes. Her ears folded against her head. "You cant just"—

"Mermista?" Catra's ear flicked in the direction of the voice. It was Adora, approaching them from behind with a concerned look on her face. Catra shut up quickly, her face warm, her heart pounding. She was so, so angry, and steadily her heart was cracking. "What's going on?" Adora asked. The look she sent Catra was questioning.

"Just delivering a notice to vacate the club room in a week," Mermista told her. "Their club is disbanding."

Catra curled her lip. "We're *not* fucking disbanding."

Mermista sighed *again*. "Whatever, Catra. You know the rules. I just had to deliver the notice to you. I'm out." She threw up a peace sign and then left, but Adora still stood there.

Catra was quivering with anger. She clenched the paper even harder in her hand, then forced herself to relax and exhale. All the while, Adora was studying her. It was humiliating to be watched like that, especially since Catra was so damn close to crying.

"Why the hell are you still here?" she snapped. "Did the council make you go with her to make sure I didn't claw her eyes out?"

Adora frowned. "No. I just heard you're the band club president and I was curious to see what you guys do here. I didn't know what they were doing."

Catra snorted. "Sure."

She threw the door open, surprised to see that Scorpia wasn't in yet, and dumped her bags down on the table. There were band posters all around the room and snacks scattered on the table and even some chairs. Scorpia liked to snack a lot, and she could be messy when she was anxious.

Scorpia's bass guitar sat snugly in its stand near the couch, and staring at it made Catra feel sick. None of it mattered anymore, if they were really being disbanded. She collapsed on the couch and cradled her face in her hands.

Why did everything just fucking suck?

Catra's head shot up in surprise when the space beside her dipped, and she saw Adora looking around curiously.

"So, this is the band club?"

Catra narrowed her eyes. "Why are you still here?"

Adora blinked innocently at her. "I told you, I'm curious."

"W ell, it doesn't matter anymore. W e're being forced to disband."

"Why?"

Catra kicked at an empty chocolate wrapper on the floor. She really needed to ask Scorpia to start cleaning up after herself. "Clubs can only exist with three members or more, not less. W e used to have more, but they all left."

"So you just need a third member and then they'll leave you alone?"

Catra ran a hand through her hair. "What do you care? Aren't the council your buddies?"

She hadn't really looked at her before, but Adora seemed tired. She was still in her training uniform and she had smudges of dirt here and there and some grass burns. Her hair still looked damp, and her big hands looked a bit scraped up.

"Y eah, they're my friends. But, look," Adora shifted and turned, pressing their knees together. Adora's warm skin pressed against Catra's, and it made her heart shoot into her throat. She refused to move, though, because she didn't want to let Adora know that she

felt any sort of way about it. She wouldn't even show her if it made her uncomfortable. She kept a hiss clenched tightly between her teeth.

"I heard all the rumours," Adora started earnestly, "and I don't care about them. I think you're interesting, and I'd love to hear you play." She pointed at the guitar case on the table. "You play guitar?"

Catra stared at her. "Why are you doing this?"

Adora tilted her head, genuinely confused. "Because I want to?"

Catra let out a sigh. It didn't make sense. If she knew what everyone said about her, why was she even bothering? "Look, if this is some twisted game to you, I'm really not interested—"

Catra was interrupted by Adora suddenly grabbing her hand. The expression on her face was annoyed and a little angry.

"Catra, stop assuming for one goddamn moment, please."

Catra blinked in surprise at her. "Well at least you tacked on the please."

Adora's warm hand slid away. "You need a third member? Then alright, I'll join. Will that prove to you that I'm not just some popular jock with bad intentions?"

"You'll join?" Catra laughed. It was at first mocking, but then it made Adora even more annoyed which just made Catra laugh harder. Adora just glared at her as she got the giggles out, and when she was done, she wiped tears off her face. "We're a band club, Princess."

Adora's hands clasped together. "Yeah I know. I can play a few instruments."

"Wait, what?"

"See?" Adora grinned smugly. "I told you to stop assuming."

"Fucking bullshit."

Adora's blue eyes were swimming with determination. "I'll prove it. Are there any other instruments here?"

"In this room? Just guitars, but the choir has like every instrument ever."

Adora stood and forced Catra up with her. "Then come on."

Catra could only stumble along, too dumbfounded by Adora to even protest their linked hands. Adora knew where the choir room was, and she happily threw the door open without any regard. It slammed against the wall, making only Catra flinch, and then Adora dropped her hand and went over to the piano.

"No shit, you play piano?"

Adora settled down on the stool. She looked absolutely ridiculous in her dirty rugby uniform, with her hair in a messy ponytail and exhaustion on her face. But when her fingers started dancing over the keys, she transformed.

Catra's mouth popped open in surprise. Adora played an entire song with her eyes closed. Her whole body was into it, and she looked nothing like the gigantic warrior she did on the field. Here, she was soft and elegant. Her hands were creating entire worlds instead of knocking things aside, and something deep inside of Catra's chest unlocked.

When Adora was done, her eyes slid open slowly and she gave the saddest, softest smile. Catra's chest ached at the sight of it, especially when Adora gently caressed the top of the piano almost lovingly.

"It' s been a long time since I played," Adora confessed.

Catra felt like she was learning something about Adora that no one else knew, and she couldn't understand why. "What happened?" she found herself asking.

Adora rotated her shoulder as if it hurt. "My birth parents were big into music, and I grew up around them playing. When I started high school, playing piano just hurt too much." She glanced up and met Catra's eyes. "But I'm better now, and I think playing really helped."

She hopped off the stool and glanced about the room. Her eyes zeroed in on a nearby set of drums, and her vulnerable expression morphed into absolute glee. Catra just sat down on a nearby chair as Adora settled by the drums, and then she started to play.

With this, she was different too. Where earlier her music had been sweet and almost hesitant, with a touch of grief and sadness, this sound was excited and angry. There was a lot of pent up frustration in the way Adora beat the drums, and her face held a look of intense concentration. She tired herself out quickly, and when she was done she carefully moved everything back the way they'd been.

"There," she exclaimed, clearly proud of herself. "I can play more, but I'm too tired. Just not guitar, though. Oh hey, you should teach me!"

Catra stood. "Absolutely not."

Adora's face fell and she pouted. "Why not?"

"I'm not interested in teaching. I can tell you're annoying."

"Wow, you're so rude."

Catra shrugged. "So what? You're the one that seems to think I'm worth getting to know."

She shouldn't have said that. Adora's face flashed with something, but it was gone too quick for Catra to analyse. Instead of getting

serious again, Adora just let out a defeated sigh.

"What are you kids doing!?"

Adora's eyes went wide as the choir teacher barrelled into the room, his face so red that even the top of his bald head glowed scarlet. Adora moved before Catra did, and then they were bolting from the room and racing down the hallway. They only stopped when they made it to the band club again, and Catra slumped against the wall, sucking in deep breaths.

"So, guess Mr T ucker doesnt like people playing his instruments without permission, huh?" Adora gasped out.

Catra looked at her. "Y ou". She coughed. "Y oure unbelievable."

Adora winked. "Among many things."

Catra started to laugh. She was a little overwhelmed, but the adrenaline was still pounding through her body. Adora started laughing with her, and then they both slid down to the floor and giggled like idiots, as if anything was actually funny. Catra realized suddenly that Adora's hand was still in her own when the pad of Adora's thumb lightly caressed the tip of her claw. She snatched her hand away.

"Catra?" Scorpia stuck her head out of the club room, concerned. "What are you doing on the floor? Oh, hey captain!"

Adora gave her a little wave. "Hey Scorpia."

Catra stood and dusted her skirt off. She felt awkward, being found in such an easy moment where she had been laughing and sitting beside Adora. Worse, Adora was grinning at her like an idiot, like they were already friends. Catra's chest tightened.

"So, thanks for showing of f," she said to Adora. "W e need to practise."

Adora wobbled onto her feet. She looked *really* tired, and the annoying urge to reach out and help balance her made Catra frown. "Will you consider it?" Adora asked her in a small, hopeful voice.

Catra opened her mouth. She thought back to the different version of Adora she had been shown, and wondered which of them everyone else saw. It felt infuriatingly good, to have Adora so invested in her for whatever reason. Catra was used to being overlooked. No one ever cared about her.

She opened her mouth again, ready to give her a chance.

"Adora!"

Bow rushed to her side, gasping on breaths. He looked very winded and concerned, and Catra's face pulled in distrust when he glanced nervously at her.

"Oh, hey Bow . What's wrong?"

Bow let out a long breath and bent backwards, his spine cracking. "W e were worried about you. Mermista said she left you here, and we"—

He cut himself off and shot Catra a very nervous glance. He looked scared. Catra was reminded about all the rumours, many of which she had started herself. It soured her mood. Any delight she had received from her moments with Adora before were chased away by the cold spray of reality.

"Why was Mermista here?" Scorpia queried innocently .

Catra frowned deeply. Adora's eyes widened slightly at the change in her expression, and Catra hated that. "Whatever ," she grumbled, her go-to whenever she didn't know what to say . "Thanks for the of fer, Princess, but well figure it out."

Surprise flashed over Adora's face, she pulled Scorpia into the club room with her and then swung the door shut. Adora's disappointment was obvious, and it was the last thing Catra saw before the door slammed shut.

Scorpia was very confused, and Catra pressed her forehead against the cold wood of the door. She heard retreating footsteps and a quiet conversation, and she wondered what they were saying about her.

"Wildcat," Scorpia whispered, gently placing a hand on her shoulder. "Talk to me. What's wrong?"

Catra inhaled shakily. Scorpia's gentleness cracked her chest in half. It was usually very easy to shove her emotions down and not feel them, but with Scorpia it was hard. She was so earnest and caring, so all Catra could do was turn around and stare up at Scorpia's worried face.

"They're finally making us disband," she managed out between heavy, emotional breaths.

Scorpia's eyes widened, then narrowed. She was always smiling. Being positive and happy was basically Scorpia's personality, but she knew Catra best, and so Catra knew what she was thinking. Without this club, what else would Catra have to hold onto it? The depression would just get its claws deep in her again, and Catra didn't know if she could survive it. Not again.

Scorpia pulled her into a warm, tight hug. Catra hid her face against Scorpia's chest so that she could mask the silent tears that trailed against her cheeks, and she wondered why someone so nice cared about her at all.

"We'll find someone," Scorpia soothed in an eerily sombre tone, rubbing a hand along Catra's back. "How long do we have?"

"A week."

"More than enough time."

"No one will join, Scorpia. Everyone hates me. They're scared of me."

"That's not true."

Catra pulled away, scoffing. "Then you're just delusional." She went over to her guitar and pulled it out, angrily wiping at the tears on her face. She fucking hated crying like this, which she seemed to do so often. The only person she had ever cried in front of was her horrible foster mother, and Scorpia. And almost Adora.

Adora.

Catra's fingers tightened on the neck of her guitar. "We can try to find someone," she sighed. "But I don't know if we have a chance."

Scorpia gave her a bright, eager smile. Her sudden moodiness from earlier was gone, and the sight of her familiar shine made the tightness in Catra's chest ease.

"Hey, we'll find a way. Do you trust me?"

Catra thought about the music they had made together, all the videos they had recorded and Scorpia's unwavering support. She let herself smile. "Yeah, against all odds. I guess I do."

Scorpia winked. "Then believe me when I say we'll get new members before the week is up."

"How can you be so sure?"

"I can feel it in my bones."

Catra burst out laughing. "You're fucking weird sometimes."

Scorpia beamed at her. "I'll take that as a compliment, thank you!"

There was still tension in the air, but when they started playing together there was nothing but the music. Catra let her head empty of thoughts, let the emotions drain away. For just a short while, she was happy. Nothing was wrong.

Of course, it didn't last.

Adora frowned deeply as she walked with Bow to the council room so that she could grab her things. She was bone-tired from practise, Coach Huntara running them into the ground. They had a game coming up in a week, and Huntara was determined to have them absolutely demolish their opponents. With Catra on her mind so much, Adora found herself getting distracted often. She was usually quick and sharp enough to notice when someone would go for a tackle, but for the past couple of days her head was in the clouds.

She lost count of how many times she had been slammed into the ground. She ached, and she was sweaty, and she just wanted to go home and relax. It didn't help that she was a little upset that Catra had completely closed off again, just when she'd opened up a little.

Music had a way of doing that, Adora realized. Her earliest memories were of sitting beside her mother at the piano as she played. Adora always wanted to play with, and whenever she jammed at the keys with her tiny fingers, she'd made horrible noises, but her mother would praise her.

Other memories were of her father, them sitting on the back porch at night, a fire cooking meat nearby, a beer on the stair beside them. He would play one of his songs and Adora would watch the way his fingers flew over the chords, and she was always in awe.

Of course, she was still so young. The memories were murky, vague. But the music had stuck. So when Mara had adopted her, the first thing Adora requested was piano lessons. When she developed really bad anger problems, Mara had her learn the drums and that

really helped during a time where any tiny thing would set her off and she felt like she needed to break something.

Adora still had a temper, but she knew how to control herself. She hadnt blown up in a long time. She wasnt proud of her past, but she knew she couldnt blame herself. She was just a kid. W as still a kid.

"What were you doing?" Bow asked her casually , but Adora could tell he was really curious.

"I took Catra to the choir room and played piano for her ."

Bow's face brightened. "Y ou can play piano?"

"Y eah! I really wanted to impress her , and I think I did. But she's so stubborn."

"She is, and really scary ."

Adora shook her head. "Nah, she' s not scary at all."

Bow gave her a surprised look. "What, she doesnt intimidate you at all? Y ou know, claws and teeth and all?"

"Why would that scare me?"

He told her about how once when they were all really small, Glimmer had convinced their group of friends to invite Catra to play, but she had broken all their toys and punched Glimmer in the face. When Bow had tried to separate them, she'd bitten him so hard he had a scar for years until it eventually faded. He seemed sad as he told her, rubbing the skin at his forearm.

"After that," Bow continued, "Glimmer decided she was a lost cause. They hated each other and if they were paired for assignments it always ended in a brawl. Teachers learnt not to put them together. Not even in the same class."

Adora blew out a breath. "That was so long ago though."

"Yeah, but she still gets into fights. Are you sure you want to get close to her?"

He was studying her, but there was something else in his expression. Adora thought maybe it was a little bit of hope, and it certainly wasn't the judgement she'd gotten from the rest of the council when she expressed her interest in Catra and her club. She really wanted to tell him more, explain that she wanted to join, but something held her back.

Catra had a lot of walls up, but Adora wanted to climb over them. She had a week to weasel her way in and get Catra to let her join. A week was enough.

"Maybe she just needed someone like me in her life," she said, flexing her biceps. Bow snorted on laughter, and he missed the way her grin dropped off too quickly.

The exhaustion was creeping in again. Luckily when they got to the council room, everyone had left and it was just Glimmer waiting with their things. She sent Bow a look, but she didn't say anything. As they left school, they playfully bantered, but none of them brought Catra up again. The whole time, Adora could sense Glimmer's eyes on her.

Yeah. She'd keep her intention to join the band club to herself for the moment, at least until it was official.

Scorpia lived her life as positively as she could manage. Negative thoughts just weren't her thing, and if she sometimes felt a bad emotion, she took a little moment to meditate or listen to some music, and it allowed her to banish the bad and return the good.

The one thing that always served to make Scorpia angry was when someone hurt Catra. It was difficult to keep so outwardly positive when she could see the tears brimming in her friend's eyes, especially since she knew what Catra went through.

Catra was a really frustrating person, but Scorpia had already long accepted the fact that Catra reacted to the world that way due to her trauma, and that it would only take years of growing up and experiencing different things for her to mature as a person. Scorpia could always tell Catra she was being a bit of an ass, but she certainly wouldn't listen. Actually, if told, she would just make a point of being more of an ass, out of spite. She was a bastard cat, as Scorpia liked to think of her—fondly, of course.

So, Scorpia handled it from a different perspective. She offered Catra her unconditional love and acceptance. It wasn't always easy, and it was certainly something she had to work on, but Scorpia's love was nearly endless.

People were beautiful. Catra herself was such an amazing individual. Scorpia spent endless hours just sitting and puzzling over Catra's personality, trying to figure out what the best way to handle her would be. Ultimately, she realized that forcing Catra to recognize her was the only way. Otherwise Catra would just push her away and alienate her. She did that to everyone else, and they all just accepted it.

But Catra didn't want that. Scorpia knew that Catra just wanted a place to belong and to have people who cared for her. It wasn't easy for her to even acknowledge this, and Scorpia hoped that one day she would overcome her problems.

So, Scorpia invested a lot of her energy into making sure Catra was alright. She did this because she wanted to, because she loved Catra dearly.

So when people did things that made Catra's bottom lip quiver the way it did? Made her eyes water with tears? Made her ears flatten? Scorpia was livid.

The day after Catra told her they were disbanding, Scorpia marched over to the council room right after practise. She was still in her

uniform and still dirty, but she figured that would make her look intimidating.

When she was younger, she had hated how big she was. A lot of people thought she was intimidating and scary, and that meant she had struggled to make friends. Of course, she was nothing like her appearance. Yes, she looked like she cracked skulls as a hobby, but really? She loved to knit. Her bedroom was all pink frills and rainbows, and she was gay as heck.

But just like how people judged Catra too quickly, so did they judge her. Scorpia didn't even care anymore. She knew who she was, and that was all that mattered.

Scorpia made it to the council room and knocked once, sharply. She was still polite, even furious. She heard someone call from inside, so she pushed the door open and strode in. She straightened her back to appear as big as possible, then paused in front of the massive table.

Glimmer was at the head, going through some papers while Bow was napping in the seat beside her. Mermista had her feet kicked up on the table, her cellphone in her hand. She was playing a mobile game, and the cute noises nearly distracted Scorpia from her mission, but then Glimmer glanced up and her brows lifted.

"Scorpia? What are you doing here?"

Scorpia fixed Glimmer with her fiercest glare. The fact that it worked *too well* made Scorpia's heart throb with hurt, but she pushed that aside.

"I'm going to be completely honest here. I'm angry , and I need to talk to you."

Glimmer dropped the papers on the table and sat back in her seat. "Okay , what's wrong?"

Scorpia crossed her arms over her chest. By Glimmer's expression, she could tell that she'd already guessed why she was angry.

"Rescind the disbandment of the band club, please."

Glimmer let out a sigh. Bow stirred beside her, waking up. He sat up and lazily stretched his arms.

"Scorpia, I understand that it's your club as well, but unfortunately the rules—"

"I don't care about rules," Scorpia cut in, ignoring the little stab of guilt at being rude. "I'm asking you to please reconsider. We don't even have a budget. All we do is occupy one room. Please, don't close our club."

Bow finally seemed to notice her and his eyes widened. He glanced between them.

"No," Glimmer told her sternly. "I can't bend the rules. And you brought up a perfect point. Your club does *nothing.* If you want to just hang out and play around with guitars, you can easily do that at your homes. Clubs are required to participate in the club festival and the talent show. To do those, you need a budget. To have a budget, you need to fill out a form. The only form your club has ever filled in was the admission form with your members, all of whom have quit." She slammed her hand down on the table. "I have let your club go on for too long already. Get another member, or you're done. That's it."

Scorpia clenched her hands into fists. She was growing incredibly frustrated, not knowing how to properly explain why this was so important. She couldn't start telling them about Catra's childhood, so how did she tell them? Scorpia clenched her teeth hard, then she let the tension roll off of her body.

She squeezed her eyes tightly for a moment and waited for her emotions to settle, then she shook herself out of it and sighed.

"Fine," she finally said. "We'll get another member by the end of the week, and we'll go to the talent show and we'll do something for the festival. If there's anything else you need of us, please let me know and I'll run it by Catra." She allowed herself to smile, relieved to feel that it was genuine. "I'm sorry for just, uh, barging in here like that."

Glimmer waved her hand. "I understand. I'm sorry, too. I know it must suck, but I can't just look the other way."

Scorpia nodded. "Right. So, er, I'll be going. And I mean it, we're not disbanding."

"Sure, Scorpia."

She turned and left the room. Scorpia was walking so fast that she nearly missed her, and jumped in fright. Adora was leaning against the wall right next to the open doorway.

"Oh, captain!" she exclaimed, a hand pressed to her chest where her heart was thundering. She laughed. "I didn't expect you to be there."

Adora was giving her an odd expression. "You can just call me Adora, you know."

"Great! Adora it is, then. What are you doing here?"

"Glimmer gives me lifts home sometimes. I didn't want to interrupt when you were in there."

Scorpia flushed, realizing she had heard the whole thing. "Oh, sorry you had to hear that! I'm not normally so…"

Adora tilted her head. "You really care about Catra, don't you?"

Scorpia grew serious. "With my whole heart."

Adora's eyes widened. "Wait, so like, are you two?..

"No," Scorpia laughed in genuine amusement. "Do I love Catra? Of course. I'm not in love with her , though. I don't know , it just goes beyond that. Like, she's family. Especially considering everything she went through, I really relate"—

She clamped her mouth shut, realizing she'd accidentally shared some of Catra's personal life. Thankfully, Adora didn't mention it at all, or ask about it, like Scorpia was expecting.

"I'm glad that she has a friend that cares about her so much," Adora said instead. "She deserves that."

She clapped Scorpia on the shoulder then disappeared into the council room. Scorpia stood there, surprised.

Was it possible that Adora? She thought about how Adora had encouraged her to get Catra to go to the game, how Adora had spoken to her after the game, how she had found them laughing, holding hands. Something clicked, and Scorpia's entire body jolted. Her face beamed.

"Oh ho ho," she laughed mischievously to herself. "Do I sense something gay brewing?"

She headed back to her club room, eager to covertly ask Catra about Adora and see how she reacted.

As expected, Catra grew flustered and irritated, and when she thought Scorpia wasn't looking, she was smiled and her tail was swishing in the specific way that Scorpia knew she was feeling good.

Something was definitely going on.

Adora squinted at the blinding light. She lifted her hand in an attempt to shield her face, and considered how it was probably a dumb decision to look directly in the sun. But she really enjoyed just lying

down on the warm concrete of the roof, the sun bathing her usually tired body.

She hadn't slept so well the night before, especially since she was so worried about Catra's club. She still had six days to figure out how to convince Catra to let her join, or to at least help them find a third member. If their club wasn't disbanding, she'd have more time to woo Catra with her dumb, cheesy pick-up lines.

There was also a test coming up, and Adora had spent more time than usual trying to study because of how distracted she was. It was only Mara finding her still awake in the wee hours of the morning that she finally stopped and went to sleep, but then she struggled and drifted in and out. She had no idea how much sleep she actually got.

Adora started burning, so she sat up and scooted over to the nearby wall. It cast enough shadow that her top half was out of the sun, while her legs could still toast nicely. Her eyes felt really heavy, so she rested her head back and let them close. Without trying, Adora fell asleep.

She was woken with a start when the door around the corner slammed closed with a metallic clunk, and then she heard the sound of soft humming. Adora's heart was still racing in her chest, and she quietly peered around the corner.

It was Catra. Did she come to this spot often? She hadn't seen Adora snooping around the corner, and she had her headphones on. Her hair was as messy as it was every time Adora saw her, and her tie was half hanging from her skirt pocket. Adora liked that Catra refused to wear her uniform properly. It made her look really hot, especially with her shirt tucked out.

Adora was about to get up and dust her skirt off, but then Catra started to sing and she froze solid. It was soft at first, but since she thought she was alone, Catra grew in volume until she was singing softly to herself. She leaned against the railing of the roof and stared

out at the rugby field, where some were playing a mock game of netball. Adora settled back down against the wall to listen.

It felt wrong, invading Catra's personal space like this, but Adora didnt want to alert her that she was there, and she also wasnt selfless enough to leave. Catra's voice was beautiful.

" *I'm just a teenage dirtbag, baby,* "Catra sang.

Adora's lips quirked into an amused grin. Yeah, that was an apt description.

" *And why does she give a damn about me?* "

Adora wanted to know her. The tiny snippets she had werent enough. There was an insatiable hunger growing deep in her chest, and to sate it she needed to know who Catra was. She didnt even care if it never became romantic. So long as she could be Catra's friend, she would be happy. It was definitely in part due to her clear infatuation. Hell, Adora had been smitten from the second she saw Catra in the school hallway.

Adora wasnt really certain what her feelings were, and she was hesitant to use the big L quite yet. But she definitely cared, and she definitely had a massive crush.

For the rest of break, Catra continued to sing a handful of songs that ranged from classic rock to recent rap, and some of the lyrics made Adora's cheeks warm. It was amusing to hear the colourful words in Catra's beautiful voice, and then it kicked Adora right in the heart when Catra sang something sorrowful, and she could *feel* the real emotion behind it.

When the bell rang, Catra grumbled something rude under her breath and left. She never looked around the corner once, because why would she? Adora sat still, holding her breath, until she was absolutely sure Catra had disappeared to the floor below.

Her heart was throbbing in an aching, painful sort of way. When she stood, she felt weak. It wasn't just too much sun, or napping for a little too long in an uncomfortable position.

She felt vulnerable like this, and something about it made her feel uncomfortable.

Adora headed down the stairs to the second floor, grateful that Catra was no where to be seen. She was a little late arriving to class, but since it was Huntara's she didn't do more than grunt for Adora to get her ass to her seat. Adora hurriedly did so.

She took her books out, but she couldn't focus. Catra's singing was stuck in her head and Adora found herself humming quietly as she tapped her pencil against the notebook that she should have been jotting notes into.

When the bell rang again, Adora packed her things away with her head in the clouds. She nearly bumped into people on her way out, but they accepted her distracted apology with smiles. On her way to her next class she spotted Scorpia walking up ahead. Her breath quickened and she jogged to catch up to her.

"Scorpia!"

Scorpia turned and looked down at her, surprised. "Oh, Captain! I mean Adora, sorry."

Adora laughed. "That's okay."

"You okay?" Scorpia studied her face. "You look sunburnt."

Adora rubbed the back of her neck. She considered confessing her run-in with Catra, but ultimately decided that she wouldn't. "Actually, I wanted to talk to you about something."

They paused by the stairway and moved to the side to avoid the moving traffic. Scorpia was a bit of a goofy person, but so endlessly

positive. A lot of things flew right over her head, and Adora had always thought that she just didn't catch on to subtleties. Scorpia took a lot of things way too literally and at face value. But this time, her brow quirked ever so slightly and the look she gave Adora said that yeah, she *knew* .

"What about?" Scorpia asked her .

Adora flushed. "Catra."

Scorpia fake gasped. "You want to talk about Catra? I would not have guessed!"

Adora scowled at her. "I didn't know you could be this mean."

"Oh no," Scorpia laughed. "I'm a lot of things you don't know . So I'm right, aren't I? There's totally something between you two?"

"What? Did Catra say something?"

"No." Scorpia shrugged. "But I have eyes."

"Okay , well, I want to get to know Catra and I can't figure out how . She's really prickly , and she has all these walls up. You're close to her, right? How'd you do it?"

Scorpia glanced up and down the hallway. It was already empty, so they would probably miss their last class if they didn't leave right now. "Hey , do you want to maybe ditch last period and go down to the mall? We can talk about Catra over some delicious milkshakes, my treat."

Adora's eyes widened. She opened her mouth, then clicked it shut. Because she didn't want to say the very stupid thing right on her tongue, she just nodded.

Adora never took Scorpia as the ditching type ~~fu~~nny , considering Catra bunked like, half her classes (yes Adora watched her enough to notice).

Together, they snuck out of school and Scorpia led her to the student parking lot. There she brought them to a stop at a beautiful black motorcycle, and when Adora blinked stupidly at her, Scorpia flushed.

"You know what's really funny?" Scorpia told her. "I'm always told that I'm really scary looking because I'm so tall and big, right? And that I'm probably in a gang or something? Well, I got this bike because I was annoyed with the comments but I actually love it! It's a plus that Perfuma loves going on rides with me. Anyway, my point is that I think it's funny."

Adora accepted the helmet Scorpia handed to her. "I think if you like it, then hell yeah. I'm sorry for judging you like everyone else, Scorpia."

"That's okay. We're all guilty of that. I mean, I totally, definitely thought you were just a dumb jock when I first met you."

Adora gasped on mock offence. "What, not a hot, dumb jock?"

Scorpia laughed loudly. She kicked the bike to life and waited for Adora to hop on behind her. Once she had, Adora grabbed the handlebars just behind her, but Scorpia glanced over her shoulder.

"You can hold me," she said.

Adora flushed. She hesitated for just a moment, then relented and wrapped her arms around Scorpia's middle. Her face flushed harder when Scorpia laughed and she could feel her abs through her shirt.

Scorpia drove them out of school grounds ~~sign~~ noring the lone grounds keeper yelling at them to stop when he noticed them leaving ~~an~~ d before long they were sitting together at a café. Their milkshakes were delivered frighteningly fast, and Adora admired the way Scorpia had everyone falling over themselves to serve her. It was probably just how adorably nice she was.

Adora stared at Scorpia's chiselled face and the way she swept her ashen hair out of her face. Scorpia noticed her staring. She blushed.

"What?"

Adora curled her fingers around her glass. "You're actually like, a total badass."

Scorpia blushed even darker. Even the tips of her ears went red, and it was adorable. Adora got the sudden, intense urge to hug the hell out of Scorpia. How could anyone think she was scary and mean? Adora heard some of the nastier rumours about Scorpia, but like those about Catra, she didn't believe them. She was glad she wasn't the sort of person to take rumours as fact.

"Gosh, thanks," Scorpia sputtered. She rubbed a hand across her face, then sucked on her milkshake. "So, Catra?"

"Oh, right!" Adora nervously turned the glass around in her hands. "So, what can I do to get to know Catra?"

"Study." Scorpia rifled around in her school bag and produced a notebook that was covered in pink paper and adorable stickers of hearts, kittens and cupcakes.

Confused, Adora accepted the notebook and flipped it open. Her eyes went wide. "What is this?"

"I call it my Catrapedia."

"You—wait, her middle name is Applesauce?"

"She said that, but I have a sneaky suspicion that she was joking."

Adora snorted. "Probably joking."

She continued flipping through the book, astonished at the amount of detail in it. Scorpia was like, disturbingly attentive. It was neat, with categories and explanations. There were even quotes scattered

around with time stamps and dates. This book contained everything Scorpia knew about Catra so far.

"It's a bit creepy, I know," Scorpia admitted. "I know I can be too much sometimes. I think it's the abandonment issues that I have. I'm so afraid that my friends will leave me that I become compulsive with my need to know everything about them so I can do whatever is in my power to please them." She sat back, her eyes dimming some. "It's tiring, sometimes. I've gotten better with therapy, at least."

Adora closed the book. "Hell yeah to therapy." She offered her fist and grinned when Scorpia gently bumped their fists together. "This book is amazing." She trailed her finger along the edge of one of the stickers. "But I noticed it doesn't have like, any backstory."

Scorpia nodded. "I just use the book to help me remember convenient things, like what colour she likes or her favourite snacks, or what her specific body language could mean. I want Catra to feel like I actually listen to her, and I do. She'd probably freak out if she actually saw the book. But, putting her private life in there was never my intention." Scorpia wrinkled her nose. "That would cross too many lines."

"Yeah." Adora hated that she was a little disappointed.

Her fingers were trembling with anticipation. This book was definitely like, a cheat sheet. On some level, it felt wrong. But Adora's desire to learn more about Catra made sure that the guilt was just small enough that she could ignore it.

While they finished their milkshakes and Scorpia told her adorably flustered stories about her crush, Perfuma, Adora read through the book. She tried to absorb as much of it as she could, then she slid the book over the table and back to Scorpia, who looked at her in surprise.

"Thanks," Adora told her, smiling. "I won't need the book. I want to get to know Catra for real."

Scorpia beamed. "I like the sound of that."

They gathered their things and got ready to head back to school, because they still had practise. Adora was already buzzing with ideas, and she thought she knew what to do.

The next day, during break, Adora waited on the roof and sure enough, Catra appeared again. Her headphones on, but she wasn't humming. Adora had no choice but to tap her arm to get her attention, and as expected Catra startled in fright with a hiss.

"Shitfuck!" Catra yelled, whipping around and nearly tripping. Adora had to grab hold of her elbow to help steady her, but Catra quickly jerked out of her grasp. Her nostrils flared and she looked furious, but Adora couldn't help it. Her heart gave an unsteady thump.

Somehow, Catra was just so damn *cute* when angry, especially with her fur all puffed up. Adora gave her a goofy grin.

"Hey Catra," she drawled.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> So I evaluated things and decided to post, again, what Ive written so far. I fear the second chapter would have been way too long had I just continued writing and writing until the end. So, Im going to tentatively say this fic will be 5 chapters long. Chapters will probably range from 5-10k words. We never know, maybe I end up finishing it up in chapter 3 lmao. Im really hype to share this, because I really love this fic. I hope you enjoy! Please let me know if you do <3
>
> Warning for mentions of physical abuse and injury.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Are you stalking me now?"

Adora didnt take the blunt accusation as an insult or even as a joke. She looked infuriatingly amused, which made Catra just a tad bit more irritated. Her heart was slowly calming down from the fright, and worse yet, her goddamn elbow was still tingling from where Adora had held onto it. Her fur would take a little longer to settle down.

Catra would *not* let Adora's warm skin and charming smile reel her in. Her every instinct yelled that this was a trap. A lie. That if she dared to get any hope in, she would be ground into dust. Her feelings were fragile, as much as she hated to admit it. But Adora didnt know that, and she sure as hell didnt want her to.

"Im sorry for scaring you."

"You didnt scare me."Catra tilted her nose up, but they were both well aware she was lying. Her tail gave an irritated flick. "Why are you bothering me?"

Catra leaned against the railing. Wind ruffled her unruly hair, and her headphones hung around her neck. She always kept it there, or one end hastily shoved into her pocket. She needed quick, easy access to her music in those moments in class where she was so bored she could fall dead asleep, or her anxiety was so back she couldn't focus. She had hissed enough that her teachers knew not to ask her to take her headphones off. Often, it was the only thing keeping her together.

Sometimes, Catra felt like she was walking across a tightrope, and it was just a tiny whisper that would be the final push to send her plunging.

Adora joined her at the railing. Her scent was the same as last time earth, sweat and just her ordinary smell. She looked more well rested today than the last time Catra had seen her, which made Catra wonder if she got more sleep. Her momentary concern worried and irritated her, so she pulled her headset back on, but only covered one ear and skipped to one of her favourite songs. Her other ear she left open, not yet ready to sever this quiet moment with Adora.

"You have a really beautiful voice," Adora told her suddenly.

Catra refused to look at her. She kept leaning her back against the railing, kept staring at her phone's playlist like it was really interesting. But she could feel her cheeks warming, and she could also feel Adora's eyes on her. She swallowed thickly.

"Thanks," she mumbled, unsure how else to respond.

Adora let out a little sigh. "I'm sorry for invading like that. I was sleeping around the corner yesterday when you came up here, and I didn't want to interrupt your moment."

So you just sat there and listened to me? Catra's heart was racing unsteadily. The only other person that knew she could sing well was Scorpia, and she hadn't mentioned it to anyone else. It took a lot of

convincing on Scorpia's part to get Catra to finally sing for some of the songs they recorded themselves playing. Scorpia wanted them to upload their stuff, but Catra refused. She couldn't help that little voice of insecurity that told her she wasn't really that good, that people would find ways to mock her. God, especially if the idiots at this school found out.

Seems one idiot already did.

"It's whatever. Not like I'm actually that good or anything. Forget about it."

Adora moved closer to her, so Catra glanced up at her. Adora's expression was perplexed, then sorrowful. She reached out but stopped herself, her hand hanging between them. Catra stared at her hand, then back up to Adora's eyes.

"I wish I could show you how you look through my eyes. Your voice is incredibly beautiful, Catra. You shouldn't let anyone else make you feel like you're not good. You *are* , and that's just a fact."

"Why the hell are you so nice to me?"

Catra never intended to actually say it out loud. She was flustered and her instincts were raging at her to run away from this, whatever this was. Adora's expression made her fingers itch, like she would reach out and grab her hand. When Adora's lips parted a little in surprise, Catra stared at them. She felt a current of *something* travel underneath her skin, and she knew what it was, and she told herself to banish the very notion.

Eventually, clearly growing awkward with this exchange, Adora shrugged. A nasty voice in Catra's head said good, let her realize how pointless this was. Catra was ready to watch Adora turn and walk away. She would just put her headphones on and continue where she had left off.

But Adora didnt do that. She took another step closer , enough that Catra could feel her heat, could smell her scent more strongly , and it made Catra almost gulp.

"I like you," Adora admitted softly , like she didnt really want to~~not~~ yet.

Catra stared at her, blinked. She tipped her head back and laughed, careful to show the points of her sharp teeth. "You *like* me? What, are you twelve?"

Instead of being insulted, Adora's eyes nearly sparkled. "I like your laugh," she supplied. "And your eyes are really pretty . And your freckles are cute. And I really like your voice, too. Not just your singing voice, but your normal voice." She moved away from the railing, body angling towards Catra. Catra's body froze solid. "I like the wrinkle you get on your nose when you're surprised or caught off guard." She grinned wide. "Like right there. I like how wild your hair is, and that you seem to like it that way. I like how you dont wear your uniform correctly, even though it drives Glimmer crazy . I like the way you're always playing music in your head, even when you dont have your guitar. It's when you just strum the air, or your notebook."

Catra's entire face was warm and no doubt incredibly red~~luc~~kily her fur hid it. Adora opened her mouth to continue, because clearly she was on a roll, but Catra rushed forward and slapped a hand over her mouth. If she had to hear one more point she would combust on the spot, and it was really fucking embarrassing her. Because the worst thing was, she was so deeply touched that she wanted to cry.

Adora *watched* her. Adora must have been watching her for a while, to notice all these things. Catra so badly wanted to really believe that it was just curiosity, or maybe if she dared to really dream, that Adora truly actually *liked* her, but that voice at the back of her mind reminded her what Glimmer had done, how that had torn her heart in two.

Adora just stood there, staring softly at her until she pulled her hand away, embarrassing to have pressed it to her lips. They were really soft, and suddenly Catra was thinking about feeling them on her own, and she wondered what that would be like.

"So that' s it?" Catra finally said, her voice thick with emotion. "Y ou're just trying to sleep with me?"

Adora's soft expression morphed into mortification. She somehow nearly tripped over herself even though she took just another step forward, but she grabbed the railing to catch herself. Her cheeks went scarlet. "No!" She seemed horrified at the thought, which made Catra recoil from her. Like the thought was so disgusting to her.

"Oh, sorry ," she hurried, her voice bitter and hard. "How assuming of me."

She was done with this. Entirely done with Adora and her beautiful face and the soft look in her eyes. In the hope that someone actually really felt something for her, because of course that was ridiculous. Catra knew Adora would go back to the council, tell them how this whole conversation had gone, how Catra had misunderstood her intentions and thought she was somehow *interested.*

Catra shoved her headphones back up and turned to hurry away. In that tiny second that she looked at Adora's face, Adora's eyes widened in alarm. And then it all happened quickly.

Adora shouted her name, and then she reached out and grabbed Catra's hand, not seeming to care when Catra's claws pricked her. She was tugged to a stop, then pulled into Adora's arms. From Adora's flustered face, that wasn't her intent. Catra blushed again. Their faces were so close. She could feel Adora's breasts press against her arm where it was now crushed to her chest.

As quickly as she did it, Adora let her go, but she slid her hand up and curled her long fingers around Catra's wrist. "Please, don't go."

Catra watched the words on her lips. She put her music off. "What do you want from me, Adora?" The words came out shaky , desperate.

"I want to get to know you!" Adora nearly yelled. "I just—look, I have a huge fucking crush on you, Catra." Catra' s eyes widened to saucers. "And it started the first time I saw you in the hallway , my first day here. I've been trying to get to know you, but I didnt know how. I dont care about the rumours because I know they're probably not true. I want to get to know you for real. I really like you, Catra. Like, in a gay way. A romantic way. So please, dont go."

Catra tugged her arm free and laughed nervously. "How can you like me if you dont even know me?"

Adora rubbed at her flushed cheeks. "I like what I see now , and I want to see more. Please let me get to know you."

Catra stared at her with a hard expression. This was the first time anyone had expressed feelings like this to her . Even when she was really little, she had always been prickly. Always hissing and batting at any kid that thought to approach her. She was angry and sick of the world, even so young. She was never taught how to be soft, only how to bare her teeth or shield her heart.

Adora's face was just so open and vulnerable, and Catra wasnt that stubborn to convince herself that this was a trick, too. Catra herself could just as easily go around telling everyone that the popular Adora Gray confessed to her. Catra lifted her nose to scent the air. Adora smelled nervous, but there was no underlying bitterness of deceit.

Adora confessed to her. Fuck. Jesus.

"I—"

"Let me prove it to you!" Adora interrupted. "I came here because I wanted to talk to you about your club."

“Adora, I already”—

“I know you’re afraid of believing that I actually want to help. Let me take you out this weekend. We can talk about it. If after you still don’t want me to join, or anything to do with me, then I’ll leave you alone. I promise.”

Catra narrowed her eyes. Adora stared at her, big eyes pleading, her lip jutted out. Somehow, Catra’s wrist still tingled where Adora had touched her. She didn’t really know how to react.

“Fine,” she relented. “But I pick the place.”

“Of course! Whatever makes you comfortable.”

Adora’s overwhelming happiness made Catra’s heart flutter. She hated how she flushed again. “If you annoy me I’m going to leave.”

“That’s fine.”

The bell rang to rudely tell them break time was over, but neither of them moved. Adora was smiling stupidly and Catra was trying not to look at her, but also gravitating back because she was so beautiful with that smile, and it was a little unbelievable to think that someone this good and bright was interested in her at all.

Why was it always the really good people that cared about her the most? First Scorpia, now Adora. And Adora said she had a crush—

“We should go.”

Adora jolted. “Oh, damn. I’m late for Huntara’s class again.”

Despite the sudden stress in her voice, she didn’t make a move so Catra headed for the door. She stuffed one end of her headset in her skirt pocket and ignored the way it felt good to have Adora walk beside her. When they reached the door, Catra paused to stare at her. Adora grew nervous.

"What?"

Catra's eyes narrowed to slits and her tail lashed in the air behind them. "I'm not *cute.*"

Adora's eyes went wide, and then Catra tugged the door open and took the stairs two at a time to escape before Adora could say something sweet and make her fumble over her words, and when she dropped down in her seat her heart was still thundering and her cheeks hadnt cooled down at all.

Adora had a crush on her? Catra glanced out the window, fixed her gaze on two birds trying to fuck on a branch, and then bit down on her lip. Despite that, her happy smile pulled at her lips, and then she just stopped trying to resist it. No one bothered her the entire period.

If Adora was uncertain if she actually had a crush or not, she wasnt anymore. She never knew Catra could got so flustered, and she was so fucking adorable. Her ears had twitched like she was trying not to flatten them, and even her fur puffed up a little. She went from being all sharp edges to just, a flustered girl. It had taken everything in Adora's power not be even more of a flustered idiot and confess even more feelings.

She never meant to tell Catra. She wanted to just talk about joining the club~~ho~~nest, that was her intention. But Catra started pulling away again, and Adora didnt know what other words to use to make her stay. They had *worked*. Catra's reaction had been flustered. That was good, right? If she really wasnt mutually interested, she would have scoffed and walked off.

Catra was seriously so cute. Adora really worried that she was already in too deep. She was usually so smooth and put together when it came to a girl she liked, but Catra made her feel a little desperate and a little off balance.

It was unnerving in some way, but it also felt... good. Like she needed to stay on her toes. Needed to concentrate. She wanted to. She wanted to drink in everything she could about Catra. Adora wouldnt allow a single detail to slip through her fingers.

Over the week, Adora tried not to bother Catra again. She didnt want to come off stronger than what she already had. But she noticed Catra looking at her, sometimes. Whenever Adora caught her, she smirked at her and then Catra would just look away. Sometimes she smiled, and those times she thought she was sneaky with it—she wasnt.

Adora felt like she was floating on clouds. Evidently, she was nearly actually floating on clouds, because her friends noticed. Hell, even Mara noticed.

Bow asked her on Saturday morning. They were at school for her game, Bow in his usual crop top and Glimmer looking like she would rather be anywhere else.

"Soooo," he questioned, wiggling his brows. "You've been smiling a lot."

Adora immediately thought of Catra and smiled again before she could resist it. Bow just squealed in delight. He definitely had an idea of who it was making her smile, and by Glimmer's sudden silence, she did too.

"I'm excited to kick some ass," she said instead, ignoring Bow's pout to tell her everything.

She lifted her fist and waited for them to bump it with theirs. Glimmer's expression was very worried.

"Adora..."

Adora pulled her in for a hug. "I'm fine," she told her. "You dont need to worry about me so much, okay?"

I know , it's just..." She sighed, pulling away . "Can we talk about this sometime soon? About... her?"

Adora nodded. "Yeah, we can."

Glimmer exhaled in relief, and then Adora was on the field. She managed to push Catra out of her mind, and then it was just the grass underneath her feet and the bodies racing beside her. She was tackled a little more than usual, but overall she was performing wonderfully. Huntara was shouting encouragements to them, which just helped to boost Adora's confidence.

Towards the end of the game, Adora was racing across the field. She had been tackled pretty hard, and she was sure she had hurt her bad shoulder, but she pushed herself despite the pain. The rival team were on her ass, and it was taking every bit of concentration to see when they were going to go for her and when she needed to dodge. If she was taken down again, she might not be able to get up.

Just as Adora feared, she was tackled from the right. A cry of pain left her lips when her shoulder collided with the other girl's chest, and then she was on the ground, curled around the ball. Players converged on top of her, pushing against each other as she protected the ball. She spotted familiar cleats at the end of the ruck, and then released the ball back into play.

The ruck dissolved but Adora slowly got to her feet, wincing and holding her shoulder. She glanced up just in time to see Scorpia dive through the air and slam the ball down across the line, and then the referee whistled and the game ended. This time, Scorpia was the one being tugged into embraces and patted on the back, though no one tried to pick her up.

Adora shook her arm out, relieved to feel that it wasnt to bad. She tried to hide her injury, though, but she saw Coach Huntara giving her a hard look. She just grinned at her, then jogged over to her team to join in on the big hug.

After, Adora took a shower and changed into her jeans and rugby jacket. Her shoulder ached, and she probably needed to tell Mara about it. That could wait, though. Today was her date with Catra. Well, it was more like a meeting. But Adora really wanted it to be a date.

She had covertly slipped her number to Catra on a piece of paper, and she had been overjoyed to receive a message from her earlier that morning.

Catra
we can meet at the mall and go to the fright øne

Adora
Oh, Iv̈e been there!Their milkshakes are good

Catra
yeah
you have a game today right
ill meet you there after

Adora was still glowing with the knowledge that Catra had cared enough to know she had a game this Saturday. Had Catra asked someone? Oh, it was probably Scorpia. It was even possible that she just knew because Scorpia was playing, too. Adora decided she would just take this as a small victory and let it encourage her.

She met up with Glimmer and Bow at the council room, favouring her left shoulder. Glimmer immediately rushed to her side, frowning.

"Adora, we saw you go down hard. Did you get hurt?"

Bow looked like he wanted to touch her, but was too afraid. "Do we need to take you to the hospital?"

Adora shook her head. "I have a bad shoulder . Iv̈e just been overworking it, but Ill be fine."

"Bad shoulder?" Glimmer asked her. "Adora, you've been practising so hard this past week. Why didn't you let coach know?"

She wasn't being accusatory, just concerned. Adora's cheeks warmed. "Of all my issues ironed out, I guess I still have an innate need to please everyone. I didn't want to let coach down."

"You should go home and rest," Bow told her. "Tell Mara."

Adora used her left arm and tugged them both into a hug. They willingly let her, and she smooshed her cheek against Bow's. "Thank you for caring about me. I'll tell Mara later. Actually, could you guys drop me off at the mall? I have a date."

Date had been the wrong word. Bow gasped dramatically and Glimmer stiffened. Whatever her issues with Catra, they were deep seeded. Adora really wondered what exactly had happened for Glimmer to feel this much disdain for Catra.

Luckily, they didn't ask her for details, they just teased her relentlessly until she could finally hop out the car and let her cheeks cool off.

She found Catra at the Fright Zone, leaning against the wall and staring down at her phone. She looked... incredibly good. She had tight black jeans on, a band tee and a leather jacket that looked old but still good on her frame. Her hair looked like she had tried to brush it, then gave up. Adora stopped walking for just a moment so that she could take the sight of her in, but then Catra felt her eyes and glanced up, and their gazes met.

Adora gulped. Her heart gave an unsteady thump.

Catra's heart skipped a beat. Adora was there, in jeans and her rugby jacket. Her hair was still damp in its ponytail and her cheeks were flushed, and she looked as exhausted as Catra had expected. There was a bruise forming at her jaw, and without thinking Catra

went over to her and gently cupped her jaw to swipe a thumb over it. Adora's scent suddenly hit her, which was strange because Catra never really paid that much attention to it. But now, it was overwhelming her with the rich earthiness and underlying scent that was just *Adora* .

"They kicked your ass."

Adora's eyes had gone wide. She didn't pull away from her touch, and when Catra realized what she was doing she immediately moved away. Adora let out a nervous laugh. "Yeah, I wasn't on my best today. I'll do better next time."

Catra stared at her. "I don't think it's possible for you to do better." Adora stared at her questioningly. "I mean, you do so well already ."

She felt a flush of embarrassment, so before she could make a bigger fool of herself she turned and headed into the cafe. Adora was close at her back. Her scent almost burned in Catra's nose.

They sat down in an open booth across from each other, and when the waiter came over he greeted Adora like he remembered her. Catra readied to give her usual milkshake flavour, but then Adora ordered it for her before she could. She blinked, surprised, and Adora only noticed once the man had left.

"Sorry , that was the right milkshake, right?"

"Uh, yeah."

Adora grinned. "Good. I asked Scorpia."

Catra's chest tightened. Had Scorpia brought Adora here? Catra knew that out of everyone, Scorpia was the best person to approach if they wanted information on her. She flushed with the knowledge that Adora had actually asked Scorpia about her, had cared enough to find out what milkshake flavour she liked.

"So, you better make this good," Catra decided to stay to mask how flustered she felt.

"Right." Adora nervously played with the edge of the menu. When she glanced up, she caught Catra looking and she smirked. She didn't say anything about it, like she hadn't said anything about all the other times during class, or the few times in the hallway.

Catra found herself staring often. It wasn't even an effort anymore. Her mind would drift off, and then she was admiring Adora's jawline, or the shell for her hear, or the flutter of her lashes. When Adora was talking, she stared at her lips and wonder to herself how soft they really were.

Adora cleared her throat, and Catra decided to pretend like she hadn't just been staring at her lips again.

"So, why don't you want me to join your club to save it from disbandment?"

"Because we don't need *your* help."

Adora visibly winced when her tone was more accusatory than she'd intended. It wasn't even a lie, not really. Sure, she could stop being so damn stubborn and just let Adora join them. But Adora was on the council with *Glimmer*. It would be oh so easy for them to have set all this up. Catra didn't know Adora yet. She had no reason to trust her, or to believe that she was being sincere in all the things she had already said.

This is why no one cares for you, the snide voice of Sharon whispered at the back of her mind, *because of course you bring no value*.

Adora let out a long exhale. For all her bravado, Catra was suddenly afraid that she had actually done it this time, and that Adora would get up and leave. She seemed a little upset, but she glanced down at the menu, kept flicking at the edge of it, and then flipped it open.

Catra noted with concern when Adora winced again, but in pain this time.

"Okay , let's ignore the club thing for now. What do you want to eat?"

Catra shrugged. "Whatever is fine."

Adora took her time going over the menu, but when the waiter returned with their milkshakes she closed it and gave him their orders, one being Catra's regular. Catra was reminded that Adora had asked about her, and it made her chest clench tightly in guilt. Why was Adora even wasting time on her?

"So, what got you into music?"

Catra blinked the almost tears from her eyes. "What?"

Adora stared at her while she noisily slurped at her milkshake. Whatever upset she'd had earlier , she was clearly over it~~or~~ just very good at hiding it.

"I just.thought it was fun," she answered lamely , not ready to explain where her love from music had come from.

"I get that," Adora sighed. "Like I said, my parents were big into music. It's like, the only thing I remember of them."

"What happened to them?"

Adora didn't recoil from the question, and instead she seemed somehow happy because of it. "When I was really little, our house caught fire. They died protecting me, or so I was told. I barely remember anything about them. I have a pretty weird scar on my chest from the fire, but otherwise I made it out perfectly fine."

Catra stared at her, blinking. Adora was just.going to share all of that?

"I was put into the system after that," she continued. "I think the fire really traumatized me. I was terrified of fire for a long time. I developed a pretty nasty temper, so I was shuffled from foster homes a lot. Some of them were not exactly," she waved a hand around, grimacing around the memories, "wholesome. I had some pretty abusive foster parents, a few times. And then Mara found me when I turned twelve, and I've been with her since."

Catra's grip on her glass was almost painful, so she released it and curled her hands together on her lap. She stared at a drop of condensation as it leaked down into the smooth surface of the table. "Me too," she quietly mumbled.

Adora blinked at her. "You too, what?"

She sighed, then leaned her elbow onto the table with her cheek cradled in her palm. "I was abandoned at someone's doorstep as a baby. Grew up in the system, had only shitty foster homes. Adopted by Sharon Weaver when I was thirteen, still with the bitch now."

Adora leaned closer, her brows furrowed. "I heard about her. Is she ~~uh~~"…

Catra shrugged. "It's whatever. I'm planning on leaving as soon as I'm done with school."

Catra hadn't shared this with anyone before, no one but Scorpia. It made her chest constrict, made the anxiety bad. But then Adora's warm hand covered her own, and she could only sigh at how it chased her negative thoughts away.

"My one foster father threw me so hard I broke through the wall."

Catra stiffened. "What?"

Adora didn't seem upset or angry as she said it, just casually. "Yeah, it was wild. I was being a little shit, and he already never liked me. I

mouthed off one too many times, and then he just yeeted me right through the wall."

Catra wanted to laugh, but she didn't. "I bit my one foster sister ."

Adora did laugh. "That doesn't actually surprise me. Don't bite me, please."

"Oh, I'll only bite if you ask."

Adora laughed loudly at that, but Catra could feel her face warming again. It had just slipped out, but she couldn't help it.

Adora's hand disappeared, but their conversation continued. Adora told her more stories about her awful foster parents, about how she was once beat up so badly that her shoulder broke and she spent weeks at the hospital. How she broke her hand multiple times because she kept getting into fights and punching walls. How she figured out she was definitely gay when she crushed on a girl for the first time at fourteen.

Adora just kept talking and talking, telling Catra everything about her life like none of it was really private, and Catra found herself supplying some of her own stories here and there. When their food came, they barely paused from their conversation to eat, and Catra couldn't remember a time where she had ever felt so comfortable and safe and *listened to* . Adora laughed at her crude jokes and sarcastic remarks, and when Catra was being negative or self deprecating she just disagreed with her gently, didn't try to make her feel shit for feeling shit. Many times Catra caught herself mid-purr and had to stamp down on the instinct immediately. Her purring was always a dead giveaway to her emotions, and she had spent her entire teenagehood learning how to *not* purr. It was difficult now, with Adora.

By the time they were ready to leave, it was already dark out and Catra knew that Adora didn't have a bad bone in her body . They paused in the parking lot and stood there awkwardly for a time. Catra

wanted to cave in, to tell her she could give her admission form in, but she didn't know how. She hoped Adora would bring it up.

"This was really fun, Catra," Adora told her, smiling that charming, attractive smile. "Thank you for opening up to me."

Catra scuffed her claws on the ground. "It was literally nothing."

"It meant a lot to me."

She couldn't meet Adora's gaze. "Yeah, me too," she admitted quietly. "Thanks, I guess."

Adora beamed. A car parked in one of the nearby parking spaces, and disappointment flashed through Catra's body.

"Mara's here. You sure you don't want me to wait with you?"

Catra shook her head. "I'm fine, seriously. My ride is on the way. Plus, I have these." She fully extended her sharp claws for emphasis.

Adora seemed like she didn't believe her, but then her phone started to ring and she glanced over at the car. She hesitated, half of her moving to the car, the other half remaining still.

"Message me when you get home?"

Catra's heart filled with warmth at the hope in Adora's voice. "Yeah, sure."

And with that, Adora brushed their hands together and then hopped in the car, and left. Catra waited a couple more minutes, then she put her headphones on and started the walk home. Sharon wouldn't bother picking her up, and she didn't even know where Catra was. She would definitely be pissy about it when Catra got home, but she didn't care.

Maybe Sharon was wrong after all. Maybe, if she didn't let her own fear and paranoia get the best of her, she could go somewhere with Adora. Somewhere she'd never considered before.

Maybe she could be happy.

Catra
hey
i got home safe
happy?

Adora
Your safety makes me very happy!Thank you for letting me know
And thank you for today Catra. It really meant a lot to me

Catra
even tho i was an ass?

Adora
Yeah, even though you were a lil bit of an ass haha
I think I understand and I won't pressure you again
If you really don't want me in your club Ill respect that
I might have some contacts though if you'd like me to send them?

Catra
i
yeah sure

Adora
Sent a contact: Entrapta

Catra
thanks adora

Adora
You're welcome. I need to go, but Ill always be here if you need to message me. Goodnight!

Catra
night

Things on Monday were weird. The moment Catra made it to school, Adora greeted her in the hallway like it was nothing. She didnt linger , thankfully, but her cheerful greeting garnered some negative attention. Adora was the star pupil of the school. Even if she wasnt aware of it, a lot of the kids in this school idolized her . To have her fraternize with the *enemy* was inexcusable.

Maybe it was Adora's popularity that made some people bolder than usual. Catra had a reputation built up from years of a nasty attitude and carrying through with her colourful threats. She was trying her best to stay out of fights, though. It was no longer really necessary to start fights with every dudebro that wanted to challenge her, not anymore. People just left her alone like it was a regular thing.

After Adora's greeting, it was like the people of the school suddenly remembered who Catra was. She tried to ignore it~~the~~ shoulder collisions, the mumbled insults and the glares.

During break, she decided not to head to the cafeteria like she wanted to~~be~~cause Adora would be there, and she could stare at her. Instead, she went to one of her spots behind one of the school buildings. The potheads usually came here when they could get away with it, and there was the scent of weed in the air still, but it was mostly deserted. No one wanted to linger here for fear of being found by the council and being punished for smoking. Catra didnt actually care. People probably thought she smoked anyway. She didnt.

She took her lunch out and flicked through her playlist, foot tapping as she just vibed by herself. Of course, her thoughts were stuck on Adora, and she was distracted. So she didnt notice the group of guys until her lunchbox was suddenly kicked right of f her lap.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much to everyone for reading!

Im moving tomorrow and things have been kind of hectic but I still managed to smash some words out. I know exactly where I want this fic to go, and Im so excited to take you all there with me. Comments really, really mean the world to me. If you arent able to comment, dont worry <3 I appreciate every kudos, and if you could share this fic, that helps tons as well. Of course, comments are the best. Interaction is my life blood, and they give me so much juice to get working on the next chapter .

Also! Because Im just like, buzzing with excitement over it, Im busy working on a Celebrity AU and also a smutty AU that I am for now dubbing the "cum fic" lmao. If youd like to know more my tumblr is always open at danijaynel 👀

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

A new chapter yayyyyy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There was a reason Catra would get into as many fights as she had. Not only was she the tiniest kid in class at any given moment, but for a long time she had seemed meek and vulnerable despite her cat traits. The first few times some kids messed with her, she tried to ignore it, but then Sharon spent an entire afternoon lashing out at her because she dared to come home with blood on her chin and tears in her eyes.

useless, Sharon had snarled, her artificially sculpted face twisted in malice, her scar tugging like loose plastic at the edges. *You're a predator and you can't even defend yourself.*

After that day, Catra started fighting back. Ever since then, people were mostly too afraid to pick direct fights with her. She wasnt as little anymore, and she certainly wasnt weak.

So her initial reaction to her lunchbox crashing to the ground, scattering the last of her food, was surprise. Pure, unfiltered surprise. She twisted around slowly and there they were, three boys looming over her with grins, like they were so proud of themselves. She went almost eerily still as they leered at her, as her heartbeat picked up, pulsing quicker and quicker in her ears until it was all she could hear. Her fur started to bristle and her tail went still. Catra's claws came out fully and she pulled her lips back over her sharp fangs.

The rage took over so easily.

Catra saw red. Her adrenalin and fury spiked so hard that she was barely even aware of herself. She could feel her fists connecting with

flesh, could feel her own skin break and tear, could feel *something* wet~~pr~~obably blood~~an~~d then she was forcefully tugged back and away. She lashed out, hissing, elbow connecting with a nose, claws digging into someone's arm.

"Catra!"

She went rigid at Adora's fraught voice in her ear, and this allowed her eyes to clear. She was being held up in Adora's arms, the claws of her left hand sunken into Adora's left forearm. There were scratches up and down her arm. Catra was too afraid to turn around to look at her.

One boy was flat on his back, out cold. Another was cradling his bleeding mouth and the third was nowhere to be seen.

See? Catra thought to herself. *This is what you're getting yourself into, Adora. Don't you see it?*

"Can I put you down?" Adora asked her .

Catra didn't have the words in her throat. She felt hollowed out completely, but she managed a weak nod and then Adora gently set her down. Adora immediately put herself physically between Catra and the boys. At first she thought it was to protect *them* from *her* , but Adora placed a warm hand on her shoulder and her scent blanketed Catra, strength and protection, and it made a purr kick up in her chest.

"Get the fuck out of here," Adora growled at the concious boy . "The council will hear about this. The three of you will be expelled. Bullying is not accepted here."

Her voice was low, threatening. Catra glanced down to where Adora's hand rested on her shoulder, so soft and gentle, and at her other hand, balled into a fist so tight all the blood was drained from it and it was quivering violently. Like she wanted to lash out. To punch

something. Her shoulders were squared, her chin up. Somehow, Adora looked towering like this.

The boy helped his friend up. "But Adora, we were just"—

" **Leave,** "she growled, the word laced with so much anger and promise, that if they didnt leave right this second, Adora would physically make them.

Catra straightened and studied the side of Adora's face, the hard set of her jaw, the bits of hair that had fallen from her ponytail. She looked frazzled, and when she turned to face Catra after the boys left, Catra gasped.

"Adora"—

"It' s fine,"Adora cut in, waving her hand. She wiped it across her bloody chin and sniffed hard, wincing. Her white shirt was ruined with blood, as well as her pullover. The worst of it was the raised pink lines across her cheek, where Catra must have somehow scratched her.

Adora seemed like she didnt particularly care that Catra had probably broken her nose. Her hand from Catra's shoulder dropped, but Catra reached out and took it in her own.

"Come on, then,"she told her , no real power behind the words. Her purr was still going, too soft for Adora's dull senses to pick up.

Adora wordlessly followed her and Catra took her to the bathroom. She kept their hands tightly linked, afraid that if she let go, Adora would leave. Once at the bathroom, Catra made her sit down on the floor and then got toilet paper to wet and dab at her nose and chin. Adora watched her intently, her blue eyes shining more brightly than ever. It was unnerving to have her stare like that, so open and transfixed, and each time she turned away from the sink and accidentally glanced into those eyes, her heart skipped a beat.

They remained that way for a long while, silent as Catra worked. She got all of the blood off Adora's face and neck, but the shirt was ruined.

"Your shirt..."

Adora shrugged. "I can change. I have my rugby uniform. It's in my gym bag in the rugby room."

Adora got onto her feet. She experimentally pinched her nose, winced only slightly, and then inhaled.

"Are you okay?" Catra asked.

Adora smiled. "Perfect. Nothing broken. Thank you for cleaning me up."

Catra stared at her. Adora was an enigma to her still. Slowly, the puzzle pieces were being handed over to her, and she was putting them together. She'd had this idea of Adora when they first met, that she was the prized, golden child. That she came from a place of privilege and never had to work for a thing in her life.

Catra realized now how wrong she had been. That Adora was more like her than her preppy council friends. She wasn't certain exactly how to feel about that, because now her feelings were getting out of hand. What was simply physical attraction ~~un~~understandably ~~no~~w felt more profound.

The anxiety was warring inside of her, but she decided to shove it down. "Let's get you changed then," Catra said, relieved to feel more strength in her voice this time. "Before people start to think I handed your ass to you."

Adora blinked at her, then smiled slowly. "I'll just say I got these from a stray cat, then," she joked, pointing at the scratches on her arm.

Catra flushed, but Adora was looking at her, well, *adoringly* and the guilt wasn't as bad as usual. She rolled her eyes and playfully pushed Adora by the chest, then sucked in a breath when Adora caught her hand there, kept it. Adora was really warm.

"Catra," Adora started, face and voice suddenly severely serious. "Back there—"

Catra sighed. "How much did you see?"

"I didn't know it was you at first. And then you jumped on the one guy and I ran over. Catra, does this happen often?"

"Not so much anymore. Guess they were just bored this time and forgot to be scared of me."

Adora's eyes hardened. "Now they have me to be scared of too. I'll slap the shit out of anyone that tries that with you again."

Catra laughed. "Oh come on, Princess. That's the entire school. And how do you know I didn't really start the fight?"

"Because I know you wouldn't."

"How do you know that?"

Adora shrugged. "I just do."

Catra's palm was still pressed to Adora's chest, and she could feel how fast her heart was beating. *Stop being an idiot,* she told herself. *Let her in.*

She tugged her hand free, sighing. "Okay, fine."

"Fine?" Adora's brows furrowed. "What's fine?"

She started for the door, pausing to look over her shoulder and give Adora a look. "You can join my club."

She decided not to stay for whatever sort of response Adora would have. She turned quickly, afraid that seeing Adora smile one more time might break her apart, might make her do something like go over to her and *kiss* her.

She shoved her hands into her skirt pockets, fingers closing around her loose tie, and then grinned to herself at the enthusiastic yell echoing in the bathroom.

Adora was *furious* . She hadn't felt anger like this in a long time, and she didn't like how out of control it made her feel. Seeing Catra like that, so angry and aggressive, had triggered something deep in Adora's heart. That was not the lashing out of the school delinquent ~~b~~ut of a child that knew the hand of abuse, and who refused to let that hand touch them again. Adora knew it well.

After Catra so gently cleaned her face of blood~~w~~hich had been hell on Adora's self restraint, having Catra so near that she could count the freckles on her cheeks and study the different shades of her eyes~~a~~nd then finally let her join the club, Adora rushed to her bag so that she could replace her ruined white shirt with her rugby one. It wasn't allowed, but she had no choice. She figured she could get away with it.

Glimmer glanced questioningly at her when Adora barrelled into class, late and fra~~z~~ed. Luckily this seemed to be a regular thing for Huntara's class, so she just waved her hand and Adora went to sit down. Glimmer immediately leaned over to whisper.

"Adora, where were you?"

Adora scooted her chair in. "I, uh, met up with Catra."

Mentioning Catra was like dousing them both in gasoline and holding a lit match. Glimmer leaned away, frowning, and Adora was reminded that they still needed to have that talk. Huntara went through the days work with them, then left them to do their

worksheets on their own for the rest of the period. Adora set her pen down and turned in her seat.

"Okay ," she started. "Y ou wanted to talk to me about Catra. Shoot."

Glimmer finished the sentence she was writing then closed her book softly. "Bow told you the short version, right?"

"He did."

"It' s not as simple as that."

Adora put her hand over Glimmer's and gave it a squeeze. "Hey , I love you, you know that, right? Y ou can talk to me. Whatever this is between me and Catra, I... I want to know why you dont want it happening."

Glimmer tugged her hand free and crossed her arms over her chest. "It' s not that I dont want you guys to do whatever this is, it' s just, Im afraid that youll get hurt."

"I can handle being hurt, Glimmer ."

"I cant help it, okay? I care about you and Catra really hurt me, and it's difficult to look at her and not remember all those bad feelings. You dont have that. Y ou came here, fresh and new, and took one look at her and fell in love or something."

Adora's cheeks flushed. She wouldnt use the L word quite yet...

"So explain it to me. It happened a long time ago."

Glimmer nodded. "W e were friends in pre-school. *Really* close friends. She was always afraid of the other kids and she would hide on the playground, and they were afraid of her too. I felt bad for her, so I invited her to play with us. Most of the time she would ignore everyone else. We got super close, and maybe I had a little crush on her or whatever. We stayed friends up until grade 1, when one day she just suddenly changed. One day we were making promises that

we would run away together and go on adventures, and then she acted like I didn't even exist."

Glimmer's lip quivered.

Adora was surprised. She hadn't expected *this* to be the reason that they hated each other. It was because Glimmer cared, not because she didn't.

"I knew her home situation was bad," Glimmer continued. "I told her we could go to my mom together and get her taken away from Sharon. She seemed really excited about that, but then suddenly things were fine on her end and she didn't need my help. She lashed out and said really hurtful things to me, and then we got into a physical fight and after that, I never bothered again."

Adora leaned back in her chair, thoughtful. She felt like there was definitely something missing here. Something Catra was keeping to herself. But then, why her disdain for Glimmer?

"Thank you for telling me," Adora finally said. She pulled Glimmer into her arms and gave her a comforting squeeze. "I'm sorry to hear how she hurt you. I don't think it's all Catra's fault, though. Would you let me try and talk to her, get her to finally talk to you?"

Glimmer sniffed. "I don't think she even cares."

At that, Adora gave her a soft smile. "No, she does. She cares more than anyone."

Glimmer pulled away to stare at her in surprise, and then her mouth popped open. "*Oh*—"

"Oh what?"

"You're like... actually in love with her."

Adora's cheeks warmed. "Maybe don't say that so loud."

"Oh my god. Bow was right! Damnit, I owe him money now ."

"Wait, you bet on me?"

Glimmer laughed. "Oh please, we bet on everything. We even bet on how many times you'd eat dirt last game."

Adora gasped. "My own friends, betting on me like I'm just a piece of meat."

Glimmer giggled, all traces of sadness gone, and Adora allowed herself to relax. Glimmer finally noticed that she had her rugby shirt on underneath her pullover, and when she asked about the lines on Adora's arm, she just shrugged.

"I fought with a stray kitty ."

Glimmer snorted at her. "You can't go and befriend every frazzled thing you see, Adora."

Adora shoved her lightly by the shoulder. "Is that a challenge?"

Once school let out, Adora went to fully change and then went to the field for rugby practise. She was still pent up with a lot of energy, so it helped to run around and tackle people. Rugby was such an aggressive sport, which was perfect for her. Towards the end she was paired with Scorpia to do waist tackles, and she took the opportunity to talk to her.

"So Catra said I can join," she announced, flat on her back and gasping for breath.

Scorpia helped her up. "Whoa! Really? I'm so glad! Entrapta said she would like to join but she keeps forgetting to fill in the form. I was worried she would be too late and we would be closed."

I put my form on Glimmer ’s desk right after school. Shell see it when she gets in.”

Scorpia went in for another tackle, but Adora managed to hold her ground and not get thrown on her ass. “Y ou think shell be okay with you joining?

Adora wiped sweat from her brow. “Not her choice, anyway . We talked about Catra, and I think I understand a little of what happened between them.”

Scorpia nodded. They were just playfully grappling, not really getting into it so that they could talk. “Catra wouldnt talk to me about it at all.”

“Maybe shell talk to me.”

Scorpia gave her a careful look, then swept Adora right off her feet again. Adora managed to grab Scorpia by the shirt and pull her down too, and Huntara yelled at them to stop fucking around.

They both lay there, breathing hard. “Y ou really have it hard for her, huh?” Scorpia asked.

Adora blew some hair out her face. “How can I not?

I get it.”

“Scorpia, some guys were messing with her today .”

Scorpia shot up, her face filled with alarm. When her brows drew together, Adora could see that she was angry. “Who?” she asked, voice low and dangerous.

Adora sat up with her. “Ill get their names. She wasnt hurt, at least.”

Scorpia’s eyes flicked to the scratches on her arm and the faint ones still on her cheek. “What happened?

She explained it, and it pleased her to see how upset Scorpia got over it. She started threatening to find those guys herself, but Adora told her that they would be expelled anyway and she didn't need to be expelled with them.

"I'm going to find them," Scorpia grumbled to herself, her white brows creased in anger. "I'll make them wish they *never* tried to hurt Catra."

Adora looped her arm through Scorpia's, grinning. They got up and started heading to the changing room. "We should start a new club."

"What?"

"The I love Catra club."

They both realized what she'd said at roughly the same moment, but they had different reactions. Scorpia froze on the spot, pulling Adora to a stop, and gaped at her. Adora went bright red.

"I didn't mean"—

Despite her own muscle and height, she still had nothing on Scorpia and was scooped right off her feet. Scorpia started whooping in delight, and their teammates just shook their heads as they started leaving the field to shower and go home, or head to club. Adora felt especially embarrassed to be swung around like a doll.

"Scorpia!"

She was dropped down onto her feet, but Scorpia was still grinning broadly at her.

"Perfuma owes me fifty bucks."

Adora groaned. "Is everyone placing bets on me? What is this, a gambling school?"

Scorpia bellowed out a delighted laugh, then wrapped an arm around Adora's shoulders. They started walking to club together, and though her chest was tight and warm, and her heart felt too scittish, Adora was smiling.

Adora
See you at club, president :D

Catra
Ugh

Adora
Word got out that Iḿ in the band club now . Some of the rumours are whack

Catra
they always have been whack you just never noticed

Adora
Yeah I dont really care about them
So!
What are we doing in club today?
I asked Mara if she could bring my drum set in today and Glimmer said it was alright

Catra
we just do whatever

Adora
Sounds…
Exxiting

Catra
riveting

Adora
Hey

Catra
hey adora

Adora
Are you okay?

Catra was pointedly not looking at her phone again. It was after school now and she was waiting in their club room, sitting on the couch this time with her guitar cradled on her lap. Adora's concern made her stomach fill with butterflies, and Catra didn't like what that meant (she did like it, but she was too afraid to admit that).

This would be their first day as a full club again, and Catra wasn't really certain what they should do. They usually just did whatever felt good. When she'd first joined this club, the others had been really into the idea of recording covers to put online. Catra tried, but her nerves always got the best of her. Her rotten attitude had been the deciding factor for many people to leave and join another club. They usually managed to recruit a new person or two when grade 8s enrolled, but it didn't take long for them to realize that there was a *reason* they only had two members. Honestly, Catra was surprised Glimmer had left their club alone for so long.

Scorpia had told her that they needed to act like an actual club if they wanted to stay open. That meant performing at the talent show and then doing something for the end of year club festival.

The idea of performing in front of other people made Catra feel sick. She wasn't given the time to start agonizing over it, because the door burst open and Scorpia came in with Adora at her side. They were both laughing, but Adora's cheeks were bright red.

"President Catra!" Adora greeted her.

Catra crossed her arms on top of her guitar and stared at them. Scorpia went to dump her bag in their locker and then plopped down on the couch. Adora just stood in the doorway, staring at her with

that dopey expression on her face. There were those butterflies again.

"Shut up," Catra grumbled, but not unkindly. "Can you come in and close the door?"

Adora flushed darkly again and then turned to shut the door behind her. Catra was suddenly thrown with the remembrance that Adora said she had a crush on her. That Adora liked her. That Adora was looking at her like *that* because she had feelings for her. Catra's chest felt tight, so she focused on her guitar again.

"So, Mara should be here soon with my drums. Scorpia said she'll help me carry everything in. Between us and Mara, we should do it in one trip. What do we do as a club?"

Catra elected to ignore the question and pretend that her guitar needed tuning.

"Oh, we just mess around mostly!" Scorpia answered. "Sometimes we'll play a cover of something, but we mostly just play by ear. On rare occasions we make our own songs."

Adora nodded. She looked actually... excited, for this. Was she excited because she actually wanted to make music? Or were her intentions less than innocent? Catra's face burned at the thought, and she decided that there was no way Adora was here *just* to be close to her. If she let herself go down that rabbit hole, eventually she'd find herself stuck and alone in the dark.

Whatever this infatuation was, it would disappear. Give her enough time to actually get to know Catra and she would realize that maybe the rumours weren't entirely wrong and she would leave, like everyone else did.

"Catra?"

A soft touch on her arm tore her from her depressed musings. Scorpia was gone, and Adora was giving her an achingly tender look.

"We're just going to get my drums. Do you need anything?"

Catra was aware that Adora's last question was still unanswered, and would likely remain so. Still, Adora wasn't pushing it, even if she looked like she wanted to.

How are you so perfect? she wondered, nearly aloud. Catra quickly debated with herself~~h~~how she was going to handle this from now on. Adora was part of her club, and Catra had the sense that she was loyal down to the bone. She worked hard for things she cared about, which meant she would probably put just as much effort into band club.

How was Catra going to interact with her?

"I'm fine," she finally decided on. She let herself smirk suggestively, and felt pleased when Adora blushed as a result. "I'll just wait here while the butches carry the heavy stuff."

Adora blinked at her, clearly surprised. Her delighted grin~~d~~espite the clear embarrassment~~m~~ade Catra's heart burn. "I'm sure you're more butch than us, though. You look pretty strong." Adora shot back playfully. "What, you just want to stare at us, don't you?"

Catra pressed her cheek to the side of her guitar, still grinning like a cat. "A little eye candy doesn't hurt."

Adora snorted. She didn't say more, and Catra watched her ponytail swish as she hurried from the room to join Scorpia, wherever she had gone.

Their banter had been so easy. The flirting was... new, but Catra liked it. This was fine. She could toe this line, but always keep Adora

just far enough away. Scorpia was the only one she would ever allow to see into her private life. She didn't owe Adora that. Not her pain.

When they returned, sleeves rolled up, the bottom of their shirts knotted up at their chests to expose their abs, Catra was genuinely flustered. Scorpia seemed a little embarrassed, but Adora had the biggest shit eating grin.

Yeah, Catra could get used to this.

Chapter End Notes

> Wow, another chapter! I so badly want them to just be soft and fluffy but ALSO I am such a masochist as of late lmao. The angst? The yearning? Not feeling good enough? Being dumb? These all tick very specific boxes for me lolol. I went in super early at work today so I managed to finish this chapter. Honestly? Half the stuff happening I did not even plan. Sometimes I feel as though they're just doing things and I'm being possessed, forced to write down their gospel LMAO. Thank you so much for reading! I have started on chapter 4, and the whole Glitra drama will finally unfold (tbh I'm still figuring out exactly what happened cause the tension between them took ME by surprise). Also did anyone say... surprise date? Adora stealing Mara's car? Them kissing? I dunno you didn't hear me say it...
>
> Comments are always so lovely to get <3 but if you don't feel comfortable, just know that I really appreciate you taking time out of your life to just read my words. It means more than I can ever say. Now I need to go and continue planning the Celeb AU (my friend is helping me with all the finer details). If you have any comments/questions about this fic or any of my others, my tumblr is always open at danijaynel!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> A new chapter!Im always so happy to have something new to post/update. Wehre having loadshedding here in SA so Im literally sitting in the dark at work right now. Been using this time to write and thus!A new chapter . I hope everyone enjoys

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Okay , maybe youre just being a little bit dramatic about this?" Bow told Glimmer after school while they were finishing up the last things in the council office.

"How can you be so calm about this?" she shot back instead, not acknowledging that he was right. Bow was always right.

Bow spread his arms out on the table and let out a long, suffering sigh. This was an argument already had. "Because," he half-whined, "it' s been years since Catra hurt you. Maybe she's changed. Adora *really* likes her."

Glimmer threw her pen down on the unsigned club application form and turned to Bow, her partner in crime, her childhood love, her everything. "Bro."

"Glimmer"—

"No, Bow , listen. I care about Adora, okay?" She ran her fingers through her short pink hair. "This is stressing me out. Catra' s a mean person. She's going to do *something* to hurt or run Adora down, and Im afraid of that happening. Adora is loyal and kind and trusting, and she wears her heart right on her sleeve."

Bow gave her a deadpan look. "Okay , should I be worried about you being in love with Adora or...?

Glimmer rolled her eyes. She knew he was joking, but still. "I'm serious here."

"Me too." Bow reached out to take her hand. His warm touch was always a comfort, but the anxiety in her gut wouldn't loosen. She knew she was being ridiculous. She knew that there were so many other complicated feelings clouding her judgement, feelings she hadn't confronted all those years ago.

Why now? she wanted to ask. Why not—why not me?

"Glimmer ." Bow scooted his chair until it was pressed against hers, then guided her face into the crook of his neck. "We both know this isn't really about you just worrying about Adora. She's grown up and she's strong. We both know the horrible things she went through, and the work she put in to get better. Do you really have so little trust in Adora?"

"No, I do trust her , I just..."

He rubbed a soothing hand along her arm. "You're hurt still," he said. "You're upset because Catra is letting someone else in when she shut you out, and you still don't know why ."

"She's a delinquent. She skips so many classes, Bow. She's such a bad influence. She literally bites."

"Yes, and she also holds the second highest grade in this school."

Glimmer pulled away from him. "I'm starting to feel like you're not even on my side."

Bow just patted her arm. "Glimmer , I'm always on your side. Which means that when you're being unreasonable, I'm going to tell you. I think this might be good for them. She may scare me, but I would like for Catra to have someone like Adora."

Glimmer glowered at the desk. He was right. Again. It was so infuriating. Sometimes she would idly consider why Bow loved her at all. He was so sweet, caring and patient and she was, well, *her* . Amusing, considering how she judged Catra so harshly. If she was being completely honest with herself, it still stung. It stung a lot. Never having confronted these feelings were resulting in everything coming back. In her possessive feelings towards Adora, her bitterness at Catra. Even towards Scorpia, sometimes, and Scorpia was a damn sweetheart.

Glimmer let out a sigh. "Adora of fered to talk to Catra and see if we could finally get over this, whatever *this* is."

Bow beamed at her. "See! I believe that Adora will be able to get right under Catra's skin. You just need to keep an open mind. We don't know what happened during that time."

"She was horrible to me, Bow ."

"I know . But I've noticed that' s a trend with Catra. She chases people away. Scorpia only stayed because she's immune to it, I guess. And Adora seems to see something in her no one else does."

"What if this ends badly"?

Bow shrugged. "Then you'll have the satisfaction of telling everyone told you so'."

Glimmer rubbed at her throbbing temple. Not only did she have her personal issues, but Catra was also a headache in general. She routinely broke school rules, and whenever Glimmer tried to punish her *somehow* her mother would tell her not to, would remind her where they stood. Whatever Sharon had on her mother, it was big enough. And Catra didn't even know . She thought she was just slick enough to skirt around the rules. She wasn't.

She thought back to their days as friends, how reckless and impulsive Catra had been~~how~~ they both were~~an~~d all the fun

they'd had. The one time Catra slept over at her house, how she had been completely in awe of the mansion Glimmer lived in. It had been obvious, back then, that Catra wasn't treated well.

She was small. She was always frightened of loud noises and sudden movements, like a timid kitten. Glimmer had been overwhelmed with the need to help Catra belong. She felt the same way, singled out for her weight and her parentage. People were too scared to be her friend, until Catra.

Until that stupid promise on top of a promise, and then when something ripped them apart. She wondered where they would have been today, had Catra not shred their friendship apart. Had Catra not shoved everyone worthwhile out of her life.

Behind the anger and the hurt, there was still the concern. Was Catra alright? W as she coping? If she wasn't, what did she do? Did she hurt herself?

There were two wolves inside of Glimmer. One wanted to slap the hell out of Catra for all of the mean things she had said, how she had just turned stone cold without explanation. But the other wanted to lay down at Catra's feet, whimper and beg for an answer. Beg for that friendship back.

"I don't want to be right," she shot at Bow , frowning deeply. "I don't want my worst fears to come true."

"Then they won't. Come on, let's go get some burgers and hear more insane stories from Adora's childhood. She should be done with club." His eyes started to twinkle. "Maybe we can get some tea about Catra, too."

Glimmer just groaned. She was hungry, though. They left the council room together and made their way to Glimmer's car. Adora was already waiting there, tossing her rugby ball up into the air and catching it. She seemed to be doing it absentmindedly, and when she noticed them she missed the catch and the ball bounced away.

"Oh, shoot." Adora rushed after the ball to grab it.

"Soooo," Bow cooed, shoving his bag into Glimmer's car. "How'd your first day of club go?"

Adora didn't answer until they were all inside, then she slid forward in the middle. "It was great," she said. "Scorpia is so good on bass guitar. She's so cool, you know?"

Bow looked like he was nearly bursting with his need to ask the question. "And how was Catra?"

Adora blinked at him. She seemed to consider something, then her smile broadened and her eyes went soft, and Glimmer realized that Bow was right. Adora was *really* in love with Catra already. If Adora could love her, surely she wasn't really that bad? Surely Catra wasn't just the mean, distant person that hurt young Glimmer's trusting heart?

Glimmer started the car and headed out to the mall. Adora started telling them about her time at club, how she had carried the drum set in, how Catra had been flirting with her non-stop ("at least, I think she's flirting," Adora said, a crease between her brows.) She told them about how Scorpia challenged Catra to play one of her original songs, and how she had and how it was amazing, and then she just started to gush about Catra's singing voice and Glimmer caught Bow sneaking her looks.

Adora was so focused on gushing that she didn't notice when Bow mouthed a few words, but Glimmer caught them when she glanced briefly at him.

"Adora's in loooove," he'd said.

"Mara?

Mara pushed away from her desk, her fingers sliding from her hair, where she'd been bunching the brown locks up in her usual tick of frustration.

"What' s up, kiddo?"

Adora went to sit down on the nearby couch. She loved Mara's office. She had many wonderful memories of this room, of coming here after school when she was younger to do her homework while Mara did her adult stuff. It smelt like clean leather and *Mara* . Often, she would come here whenever she just needed to sit down and think, as was now.

Adora regarded her parent for a long moment. Mara merely quirked a brow at her and waited, confident that Adora would find the words for what she needed.

"I think I'm in love with someone."

Mara's eyes widened. She quickly left her desk to join Adora on the couch. "Really?"

Adora frowned deeply, nodding. Mara must have taken careful note of her expression, because she didn't jump into teasing, like she usually would have when it came to stuff like this (Adora would never forget the amount of gay jokes Mara had made when Adora flippantly remarked that she too, was gay, when she was like, thirteen).

Mara tucked a loose lock of hair behind her ear. "Okay , so talk to me. What's going on?"

Adora let out a sigh. "I don't think she feels the same way . She's really prickly, and I kind of already told her I have a crush on her? But I came on *really* strong, because I'm an idiot. But I... really like her. I think I might love her. I've never felt this way before. How do I know if it's really love? If this won't just fade over time? I don't want

to waste her time or hurt her. She's been through so much, and I just want to make her smile."

Mara's expression was almost achingly tender. "Adora," she started, voice soft. She took Adora's hand and gave it a squeeze. "Love is exactly what you described. You care about her, and you're thinking of things for her sake. I would argue that maybe you're just attracted to her, but I can tell from what you've said that it goes deeper than that. You've had little crushes before, but not this."

Adora felt herself flush. "It makes me feel weird."

Mara laughed. "Yeah, love will do that to you."

Adora told Mara the rest, everything she could since day one to now, her being in the same club. Mara listened intently, nodding and humming, and when Adora was finished she felt a little desperate and a little like she would cry.

"Adora." She looked up at Mara, her lower lip quivering. "You need to give Catra some time and space, okay? It sounds like she has a lot going on with herself. All you can do is be there for her. Be an ear, be support. Brighten her day. If she returns your feelings at all, then she won't be able to ignore them for long. I mean, come on, you're *you.*"

Adora blushed furiously. "Mom, *stop.*"

"Aren't you like, the lesbian jock hearthrob?"

"*Stooop*," Adora groaned, horrified, but Mara started laughing so hard she snorted at least three times. Adora glared at her. "You're horrible."

Mara wiped the tears from her face. "You're still so young, Adora. Just remember that. If she doesn't love you back, it'll suck, but you'll get over it."

Adora nodded. This was something she also knew, but it helped to hear it from someone as put together as Mara.

Adora just... she didn't want to do this wrong. She could get overeager, and she could be a lot. She had a tendency to fixate. She didn't want to drive Catra away, or make Catra think that the only reason they were interacting at all was just so that Adora could seduce her. While *those* thoughts were definitely on her mind, she genuinely just... wanted to know her. She was slowly putting Catra together.

"Okay. I'm just going to focus on being her friend. Thanks, Mara."

Mara ruffled her hair, ruining the neat poof she had spent so long getting right. "That's my girl."

Adora glared at her, but there was no heat behind it.

On Wednesday morning, Catra had to walk to school again. She didn't mind it so much, if she could just get a warning. Either Sharon would just disappear, or she would instigate an argument and use that as an excuse to drive off on her own. Catra really enjoyed being able to just put her headphones on and think about things on the walk over, but it usually meant she was some degree of late. Today, however, she was actually a little early.

And both Adora and Scorpia were waiting at the gate for her. She flushed when other students started staring, and tried to walk right past them like she hadn't seen them. They both flanked her and started walking alongside her. Catra stopped before the building entrance.

"What are you two doing?" she growled, tail fluffed in warning.

Adora and Scorpia exchanged a look, then nodded at each other.

"I feel responsible for what happened the other day ," Adora told her , frowning.

"And Adora won't let me go and find those guys that bullied you," Scorpia added cheerfully.

"So," they continued in union, grins broadening, "we will provide a united front."

It was so clear they had rehearsed this. Catra stared at them, deadpan. She covered her face with a hand. They were so *stupid* . Why was it making her tear up?

"I can handle myself," she decided to say . "I don't need bodyguards. I have these." She flashed her sharp claws, but neither of them seemed to care.

Adora crossed her arms over her chest. "I want people to see that I'm on your side, Catra. You're not as bad as people think. Please let me do this for you?"

Scorpia reached out and gently patted her shoulder. "Let us help you, Wildcat. Please?"

Catra's throat felt swollen with emotion. It was goddamn embarrassing, but she knew no matter how hard she argued with them, they would not relent. This was important to them. Somehow, *she* was important to them. Since they were in a club together now, she had to learn to get used to this.

Catra swallowed hard. "Fine," she growled. "Just give me a second."

They gave her puzzled looks while she rustled around in her bag, then she produced a pair of mildly scratched sunglasses, and put them on. She shouldered her bag again, then took a mighty breath.

"Alright, moron squad," she announced. "Take me to my class."

Their giggles were at her back, and people were staring as they walked through the hallway, Scorpia and Adora both big and tall, trying their best to project themselves as tough and strong, and then Catra, so small between them, with her fucking shades on like she was someone important.

She had to resist laughing the entire time.

Catra
hey adora

Adora
Hey Catra!I was just thinking about you!
I mean
Not ☠U
I dont just randomly think about you all day
Haha
The club
We have the talent show coming up

Catra
the talent show?ugh

Adora created a group chat >Club 3

Adora added Catra to the chat

Adora added Scorpia to the chat

Scorpia
Hey guys!3 3 3

Adora
Hey Scorps. We need to discuss the talent show

Catra
we are not doing the talent show

Adora
We have to

Scorpia
Yeah Wildcat, we sort of really need to or else Glimmer will try and disband us again

Catra
how about no

Adora
Catra come on

Scorpia
Well be a hit!W eŕe amaıng together . All these weeks of playing, it's like we were always meant to make music together

Catra
youŕe such a sap
iṁ not doing the stupid show

Adora
Catraaaaa

Catra has left the chat

Adora has added Catra to the chat

Adora
Wow that was rude

Catra has left the chat

Adora has added Catra to the chat

Adora has changed the group chat to >:P stay Catra

Catra
ugh fine whatever

ill stay in this stupid chat but im not doing the show

Adora has changed the group chat to >CatraIsTheBest

Scorpia has changed the group chat to >YouCanDoThisWildcat

Adora has changed the group chat to >CatraIsAmazing

Adora has changed the group chat to >CatraIsAmazing<3

Catra
can both of you stop

Adora
No

Scorpia
No

Catra has changed the group chat to >Iron Squad

In all honesty, Adora was expecting Catra to put up way more of a fight. She did refuse to even acknowledge the talent show until a week before, but luckily Scorpia and Adora had both made all the arrangements and had secretly snuck in some practise time. They were playing one of Catra's favourite covers, and the real challenge was getting her to agree to do it with them.

"No," Catra deadpanned, flicking through her social media on her phone. Her tail flicking on the couch beside her was a dead giveaway to her nerves. After so much time, Adora knew what most of her body language meant.

Adora scooted closer on the couch. "Catra, come on. We wont be allowed without all our members."

"Still a no."

"How about we make a bet?"

At that, Catra's ears straightened and her eyes flicked up from her phone to study Adora's face. "Okay , spill."

Adora had no idea what to say. The idea hit her suddenly and without warning. She had no idea where to go from here, and it was obvious when she just opened her mouth and it hung there. Catra lifted a brow at her.

"How about we bet a wish."

"A wish?"

"Y eah. If you absolutely hate the talent show, you can ask me for anything. Literally anything, and Ill agree to it."

Catra gave her a very devious look, one that made Adora's stomach flutter. She wondered what Catra was thinking about, to put that sort of glint in her eyes.

"And if I dont hate it?"

"If you have a good time,"Adora continued, "then I win, and I can ask you for anything."

Catra studied her for a long moment. Finally, she heaved out a sigh. "Fine,"she grumbled. Adora watched the nervous sway of her tail, the way her ears lowered just *so* , indicating that she was embarrassed. Adora wanted to ask her why she was getting flutestered. She decided not to.

So, with Catra finally giving in, they had a week to prepare for the talent show. Catra was actually very studious, and she was often the one barking at them to stop messing around and focus. She was also really nervous, and it got worse the closer it got to the talent show. On the day, they were waiting backstage while the last group did their thing. They were up nek

Catra was sitting on the ground, hugging her guitar to her chest. She looked like she was about to throw up. Adora, worried, went to crouch down at her side.

"I'm so nervous," Adora admitted softly.

Catra glanced up at her sharply. "*You* are nervous?"

"Yeah." Adora offered a little grin. "I feel nervous before each game too. I get a bit of stage fright. It's usually easy to ignore when I'm out there, but I usually feel like I'm going to pass out." She lifted her hand and showed how badly her fingers were shaking.

Catra's shoulders relaxed. "I didn't take you for the nervous type, Princess."

Adora shrugged. "Maybe you don't know me all that well yet." She winked, pleased when it made Catra's ears twitch and she glanced away.

Whatever had been going on in her head, it was clear she had pushed past it. They were called for their turn, and Adora reached out to take Catra's hand in her own. She gave it a comforting squeeze.

"You're amazing," she told her, meaning every word. "You will kill it out there, Catra. I know it."

Catra's eyes widened, then she huffed and pulled away. "Yeah, sure." Her eyes shifted back. "Thanks, Adora."

Adora's chest buzzed in happiness. They went out, and they played, and it was phenomenal. People were actually surprised to hear how good they were, and when Catra started singing with her powerful voice, Adora could see the awe in the crowd. All eyes were on Catra. Not Adora smashing out the drums, or Scorpia swaying on her bass, but on Catra. As Catra's fingers flew over the chords, as she sang into the mic and her hair stuck to the back of her neck from sweat.

When they were done, Catra's voice bounced around the hall, and then people were screaming. They were quickly ushered off the stage to give the next club their go, and Catra's eyes were wide and glowing.

"Adora," she said softly, reaching out blindly. Adora happily took her hand. Their fingers slotted together. "They ... they loved me."

Adora beamed at her. "See? I told you." She couldn't help but soften her expression, take a little step closer. "There's so much to love."

Catra stared up at her, frozen in place. Adora realized she had admitted too much again. Catra knew how she felt, but she hadn't ever brought it up. Adora figured she just forgot about it, because it clearly wasn't important to her. She definitely didn't feel the same way. Adora wanted to kiss her, even though her chest was suddenly tight with panic. But Catra's hand only tightened in hers, she didn't pull away in disgust, and all Adora could do was stand there in Catra's orbit.

"So, what do you want?" Catra asked her.

Adora swallowed. "What?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "You won, Princess. You get one wish." She finally slipped her hand away, their fingertips connecting for a second too long before they lost contact and Adora's hand hung loosely by her side. "You better make it good."

Scorpia bounded over to let them know that the judges had submitted their score. There was a prize pool for clubs, and they were now in the lead. She interrupted their moment, but Catra kept giving her that look, and Adora felt like she was hanging on a thread.

She knew what she wanted to wish for. To ask. She was afraid to. Afraid it would cross too many boundaries, make Catra too uncomfortable. But it was the deal. Later, after they got home and

Adora gushed to Mara, she collapsed on her bed and pulled her phone out.

Adora
Anything I want?

Catra
your rules, smartass

Adora
Go on a date with me

Adora grew nervous when she got the notification that her message had been read, but Catra wasnt responding. She remained online for a long while, then went offline. Adora set her phone aside and went to shower, and when she came back ten minutes later her heart skipped in her chest. Catra had responded.

Catra
just a date?ok. tell me when and where

Adora
Really?Y ou're not creeped out?

Catra
adora, if i was not cool with the idea id say no

Adora
:D

Catra
this isnt because i like you, alright?

Adora
:DDD

Catra had been so sure that once Adora spent more time with her, she would realize who she really was and that she wasn't worth all the drama, and she would leave. She had spent so long believing that she wasn't worth anything, that Adora's feelings puzzled her.

Catra knew her own feelings were deepening. She wasn't really certain if it was love, or if she was just enjoying the care and attention Adora was giving her. Could that really be called love? Actual love? The last thing Catra wanted to do was use her in any way, or take Adora for granted. She was prickly most times out of habit, because whenever she got affection from anyone else, it was always hidden over barbed wire. For years when Catra had been a little kid, Sharon had pretended to love her, only to turn and viciously laugh at her expense for having the audacity to think she could possibly be *loved*.

A week after the show, Adora was picking her up. Catra gave her some generic address, not her actual one, and waited nervously on the sidewalk. She had messaged Adora to let her know she was there, but hadn't checked her phone since. She was stubbornly refusing. If Adora decided to cancel on her, realized what a waste of time this really was, Catra would be crushed.

Adora did in fact show up. When she stopped where Catra was standing, the passenger window slid down and Adora's face appeared, grinning.

"How much do you charge for hugs?"

Catra blinked at her, processed the joke and then rolled her eyes. She stubbornly fought off her smile as she got in. "You're a dork," she admonished instead.

The car was... *really* nice. Catra didn't know Adora could even drive, or that she had a car. She remembered Adora telling them Glimmer gave her lifts home.

"Finally got a shiny new car?" she asked flippantly.

Adora cautiously checked the road before pulling away and putting the hazards off. "Nope," she answered, popping the p. "Mara doesn't know I took her car."

Catra turned bodily to face Adora. "You *stole* your mother's car?"

Adora gave her a cheeky grin. "Mara's away on some trip, and I didn't want to bother her. I have my license. She just... won't know about it. I wanted to do this properly. She suggested I pick you up with my bicycle."

Catra finally laughed at that, head tipped back, fangs exposed. She imagined sitting on the handlebars as Adora worked hard to peddle them to wherever it was she wanted to take them. While seeing Adora work hard would be entertaining, the thought was a little ridiculous.

"Rebellious," Catra finally said after her laughter subsided. "Noted."

Adora just gave her a very pleased grin.

Catra had no clue what this date would entail, and it made her nervous. She usually demanded every single detail, so that she could plan an escape appropriately should she need to. But, she trusted Adora. It was a strange thing to think, to feel, but she did. The idea of going to an unfamiliar place with Adora did not make her skin crawl.

Adora took them to a fast food place and went through the drive through. Catra hadn't eaten here before, and when Adora asked what she wanted she leaned over almost into Adora's lap to see the menu. From the corner of her eye, she watched the way Adora swallowed.

It was... a bit addicting, to see the ways she physically affected Adora. She wasn't overly subtle about it. Catra liked doing small things to throw her off, like suddenly drape over her, or brush a hand against hers, or put a hand on her shoulder, or whisper a joke in her

ear. Maybe that was being cruel of her, considering Adora's feelings, but she just couldn't resist. Adora went bright red and she turned into a bit of an idiot, and Catra was addicted to seeing her that way.

She would need to talk to Adora about this sometime soon, though, before she led Adora on, made her think that there could ever possibly be anything between them. She wasn't *that* cruel.

After they placed their orders, Adora took them down a dark, dirt road with no street lights. Catra nervously watched the bumpy road ahead of them, bathed in the bright headlights. She realized where Adora was taking her when the road beneath them turned from hard soul to grass, and then made the incline to a secluded, hidden parking lot.

This was the cliff, a popular party location for how out of the way it was, and the beautiful view of the city below. When they parked, Catra shifted in her seat.

"I didn't bring you here to murder you or anything," Adora assured her jokingly.

Catra eyed her. "You sure? No one would notice. You'd totally get away with it."

Adora just rolled her eyes. "Stay here." She hopped out the car and went around to the back to open the trunk. Catra did just that, stayed there and listened to the sounds as she took *something* out and then shut the boot. Catra couldn't see what she was doing. Adora threw something over the front of the car, then rounded to Catra's side and opened the door.

"My lady," she said, holding a hand out.

Catra took it and allowed Adora to pull her out. As soon as the door shut, a small light clicked on from the roof of the car, and Catra's breath got stuck in her throat.

A white cloth had been hung on a nearby tree, with a portable projector and laptop set up on top of the car. A blanket was covering the front bonnet, and there sat their food and drinks. Adora nervously watched her expression as Catra took the scene in. She could feel the tears rushing up at her, but she stubbornly refused to let them fall.

"Adora, what the *fuck*?"

Adora's expression crumbled. "You don't like it? I'm sorry, I—"

Catra grabbed the open edge of her rugby jacket. "I don't dislike it," she cut in before Adora could fall over herself to apologize. "I just, how did you *know?*"

Adora frowned at her. "We were talking about it, remember? Scorpia was asking for date ideas, you mentioned the cliff. I know you really love the old school drive through cinemas. Scorpia let me borrow her stuff, and this is why I needed the car, too."

Looking at Adora, hands shoved anxiously into her pockets, her blue eyes filled with worry as she waited for Catra to speak, it was made obvious. How hadn't Catra realized before? Why was she so dumb? For all her mocking of her clubmates, she was the biggest idiot out of all of them.

Catra's chest felt tight and hot, and her heart was pulsing with her sudden realization. Even if she'd never felt it before, this was it—love. She was in love with Adora. Adora, who actually listened to her, who actually cared, who pieced together flippant remarks she made and put together something so fucking thoughtful that she wanted to cry, because no one had ever done that before.

"Why?" she blurted out.

Adora exhaled. "Why what?"

Catra rubbed the back of her neck, glanced away. This was all so overwhelming. She kept waiting for the other shoe to drop, for something to go wrong, to prove this was just one of her wishful dreams.

"Why do you care so much, Adora? Why do this much for me?"

Adora blinked at her. "Did you forget?" She slowly stepped closer, reached out for Catra's hand but didn't take it until she nodded. Her skin was warm, her touch gentle. Her scent was suddenly overwhelming, but not in a bad way. "I love you, Catra."

Catra gasped, eyes flying wide. "What?"

Adora smiled sadly. "I love you. I'm *in* love with you. Not just a little crush. But I'm not saying this to you to get anything back. I just want you to understand that I'm doing all of this because I love *you*. I want you to have fun." She looked away, forlorn. "I know you don't feel the same way, and that's okay. I'm really not expecting anything from you."

Catra really didn't know how to correct her misunderstanding. She wasn't sure if the words were even capable of leaving her yet. Instead, she just gave Adora's hand a squeeze.

"I'm hungry," she said, not missing the relieved look on Adora's face. "What movie are we watching?"

Adora perked up. "One of your favourites!"

"Adora, have you been stalking me?"

Adora chuckled and shook her head. "Nah, I just watch you a lot. Wait, that does sound a bit like stalking."

She got everything set up, and then hopped up on the blanket and took their food out, and Catra started to agonize. She wanted to just ignore the things Adora had said, analyse them later, but she

couldnt. She was hyper aware of Adore beside her , of Adora's warmth, her laugh, the way her eyes smiled with her. Catra watched Adora more than the actual movie. She finished her food and set the trash aside, and still she couldnt look away .

Adora finally noticed. She turned to look at her, face bathed in the bright light from the projector. Her brows creased in question.

"Catra?

Catra's breath caught. She felt trapped in those eyes. She didnt think shed ever want to get out.

"Y ou love me?"she breathed.

Adora flushed darkly. "Yeah, I really do."

Catra swallowed thickly. Her heart was pounding, adrenalin shooting through her system. Her fingers started to shake, and Adora started to reach out for her, to ask what was wrong.

Catra kissed her. Adora froze against her . The soft little gasp she let out brought Catra back to reality, made her realize what she had just donewithout even *asking* . She gasped, pulling back. Adora's eyes fluttered open with a question in them, and a look of hope.

"Catra?"she asked. Catra looked away . "Y ou... kissed me."

"I'm aware,"Catra mumbled, blushing just as furiously as Adora now .

"Does that..."Adora rubbed at her blazing cheek. "Does that mean you like me?"

"No, Adora,"Catra snarked. She scooted closer until they were pressed together. "It was awful. W ould not recommend."Adora sucked in a breath beside her, face still shocked. "Y es, I like you, idiot."

Adora let out the breath she had been holding, like that single breath held all of the tension in her body. Her lips pulled into a broad, easy smile, and Catra blinked stupidly at her.

"You like me?"

"Unfortunately."

"You kissed me, Catra."

"Yeah, I know."

"Can I kiss you now?"

Catra stared at her, a brow lifted. When she started to smile, Adora leaned in and captured her lips, and Catra's stomach fluttered. They were both a little clumsy, clearly not experts on the whole kissing thing, but Adora's lips were soft and urgent. When their tongues touched briefly, Catra groaned softly. Adora shifted beside her, hand coming up to cup her cheek. The kiss deepened, but there was no real urgency.

This was just curious, delighted exploration. Catra wondered how soft Adora's hair was, so she reached up to slide her fingers through her locks. She snagged her finger on Adora's elastic and then cut it with her claw, letting her hair fall loose around her shoulders. She gently scratched the back of Adora's neck, earning a groan against her lips.

"Catra," Adora gasped into the kiss.

"Mm?"

Whatever Adora wanted to say next, it was lost in a yelp. She suddenly disappeared from Catra's lips, and then Catra blinked at the empty spot beside her. She crawled to the edge of the car, to Adora flat on her ass, looking just as bewildered.

"Did you just fucking fall off the car?"

Adora flushed darkly. "I did not."

"I literally saw that."

"No you didn't. Your eyes were closed."

Catra started to laugh. A deep, full laugh that rumbled right in her chest. Adora got to her feet, dusting grass off her jeans, scowling. But she seemed just as amused, even a little embarrassed. Adora joined her again, making sure to scoot to the middle this time.

"You're a brat," Adora told her.

Catra's laughter died down to snickering, then cut off. In its place started a soft, firm purr. She grabbed Adora's jacket and tugged her closer. "Yeah, but your brat." Her eyes widened, happiness fading away. "I mean, if you want..."

Adora gasped softly. "Catra, did you just ask me out?"

"No." She met her gaze. "Maybe."

Adora kissed her softly, fingertips trailing along her jaw, down her throat. "I'd be honoured to be girlfriends with you."

"Ugh, you sound twelve."

Adora chuckled. Catra couldn't resist, she kissed her again. They got lost in it, in the brush of lips and tongue, of their breaths and fingertips. "But you love it, right?" Adora froze, clearly realizing the specific *L* word she had used. Catra decided to cut in before she could correct herself.

"Yeah," she agreed. "I guess I do."

They never got around to finishing the movie, but that was alright. Catra fell asleep against Adora's chest, with those strong arms around her, and for once her dreams were peaceful. Her purr was

insistent, even once she was asleep, a contented rumbling in her chest.

Chapter End Notes

So, all of that happened lmao. I have been waiting to write the scene where Adora falls off the car lmao. We have one chapter left, and still a couple things to conclude. Like, what the heck was The Accident Sharon blames Catra for? What the heckening happened between Glimmer and Catra? Will Catra ever get to see Adora's scar? And who is Kyle? Thanks for reading, everyone! Comments are always welcome and loved.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

IMPORTANT!For those that have been reading this since I first posted it, I have gone back and edited the entire thing so Dirtbag is now the Furry Edition. Ive changed Catra from human to magicat, as she should have been lol. There arent huge changes, but it might be a nice re-read. Otherwise, just enjoy furry Catra in this chap.

Im very impatient and this fic just keeps getting longer . I have some cool news in my end note, so do take a second to read it when youre done!

Boy, these past two weeks have been really rough for writing. My anxiety has gotten really bad, but Im doing my best to deal with it. Im just glad that I still managed to get some writing in. I wish I could have smashed out the gigantic chapter that I wanted to for the final chap, but I just couldnt, and I dont want to wait forever. Ch6 will probably be the end, then lol. In the meantime I am working on the celeb AU, and once Dirtbag is done Im going to officially start with the orgasm fic. Thats the plan.

Hope you all enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra experienced things very differently to ordinary humans, and that was something Sharon often ignored. Because of that, she reacted to things differently. Catra's instincts were strong~~th~~ere since birth, to aid in her survival, in allowing her to flourish. Every since she had been a kitten, she had tried her hardest to ignore her instincts and act more human, but that was impossible.

Catra was not able to relax unless she was completely sure she was safe. She loved to hide in dark, closed spaces, like beneath her bed or in her cupboard. It blocked the world out, allowed her to focus on just the simplest act of breathing in calmly. The world was more vibrant for her—scents everywhere, noises always too loud.

With Adora, she was apparently comfortable enough to fall asleep in the dark, on top of a car, in her *arms*. When Catra woke up, she made a soft *mrrp* noise in her sleepiness and stretched her limbs, claws extending to their full length. She didn't realize she was gently kneading Adora's leg until she hissed softly in pain, and Catra shot up, ears pressed to her head.

"Whoa, you're okay," Adora laughed, a hand closing around her upper arm to keep her in place. "I just wasn't expecting the claws."

Catra felt herself flush. "I didn't mean to do that."

"It's okay." Adora smiled softly. "You were comfy, right?"

Catra refused to answer that, because she had been. At some point she must have slid down to rest her head in Adora's lap. By her ruffled hair, she could tell Adora had been stroking her fingers through it. Strangely, the thought didn't make her tail fluff up like it usually would. It made her chest bloom with incredible warmth.

"How long was I asleep?" Catra asked her.

Adora stretched her arms above her head, groaning. "Not too long. Movie ended a bit ago."

"Why didn't you wake me?"

Adora's pale cheeks darkened. "You have like, the cutest snore."

Catra's eyes narrowed to slits. "What did you just say?"

Adora was clearly fighting off a smile. "Your snore. It's really damn cute. I couldn't wake you even if I wanted to."

Catra tapped her sharp claws against the car below them, and even through the layer of the blanket, the noise was still jarring. Adora didn't seem frightened in the least, but she was starting to inch to the edge.

"*Cute?*" Catra growled, no real bite to it, but her teeth still bared. "Call me cute again, Adora. I dare you."

Adora put one foot down on the ground, her eyes wide. Catra could hear the frantic pounding of her heart, was overwhelmed by her scent, thickening with excitement now. There was no trace of fear or hesitance. Catra's hunting instincts started kicking in, making her ears point upwards, twitching at just the slightest sound. Adora's breath hitching, the fabric of her jacket moving, the metal clink of her jacket zipper. Catra's tail started swishing back and forth, and if she wasn't trying to hold herself back so much, she would have gotten into a crouch, ready to pounce. Somehow, her intent still showed. Adora put her other foot on the ground.

"You're cute," Adora told her, and then she was running.

Catra growled in mock annoyance and watched Adora disappear between the trees. She could still see perfectly fine, so she could still track Adora whenever she darted between the trees. She waited a few breaths, and then she pounced off the car on all fours and took chase.

When Catra was a kitten, she always wanted to play, but she was always reprimanded by the human adults whenever she would chase some of the other kids and accidentally scratch them. She was young, and she didn't understand why the other kids didn't play-fight back or pounce on her too. She learnt very quickly that her version of play was very different, and when she was physically punished she stopped trying to play completely. She thought toys were boring. She wanted to run and climb, to scratch with her claws and chew things with her teeth.

So chasing Adora through the darkness on all fours was fucking exhilarating. Catra's heart was pounding fiercely in her ears, and her entire body tingled with the adrenaline. Her claws sliced into the hard ground beneath her, and then she leapt up into the trees, chased Adora by swinging from branch to branch. Adora ran out of breath quickly and stopped, and Catra froze just above her, peering down. Adora didn't know where she was.

"Catra?" she called out, breathless. Catra could see the sweat beading on her forehead. She could hear the wisps of her tired breaths. "The idea was for you to chase me," she called out again. "Or am I being weird?"

Catra's grin stretched wide. She silently moved over to another branch until she was directly behind Adora.

"Hey Adora," she purred, tail flicking happily.

Adora gasped, whipping around to stare upwards. Catra's eyes must have been reflecting in the dark because of the moonlight. Before Adora could even open her mouth, Catra leapt from the branch and tackled her. To her credit, Adora caught her with surprising strength and made them roll so that they didn't get hurt. Adora still ended up on her back, her long hair splayed out below her.

"Hey Catra," Adora greeted her, flushing even darker. Her blush travelled down her neck.

Catra cupped her chin in her hand and smirked. She trailed a claw along Adora's chest and heard the way she swallowed. "So, do you have a thing for magicat's specifically or do you just get off on being hunted?"

Adora snorted. "More like I just have a thing for you specifically."

Catra blinked. "What, so what I am doesn't bother you?"

"Bother me?" Adora blinked, brows creasing together. "I've grown up with hybrids before. I also don't—I mean, do I think you're hot? Yes. Do I really want to rub your ears? Hell yes. Do I—" Adora squinted. "Where am I going with this?"

Catra found herself laughing. She got onto her feet and helped Adora up, and her laughter caught in her throat when Adora's fingers slipped between her own and she grinned happily.

"Did you have fun?"

Catra narrowed her eyes. "You're definitely a furry."

She dropped Adora's hand and started back to the car. Adora would be lost without Catra there to follow their scent. Adora made a choked noise behind her, clearly offended, but she didn't really refute it. Catra held her laughter in.

They were both grinning broadly while they packed up their things and got back into the car. Adora was openly very pleased with herself, and Catra supposed she should be, since this whole date had gone better than expected. Catra honestly hadn't said yes to this date thinking she would be confessed to, would accept that confession and then start *dating* Adora Gray.

They traded idle conversation back and forth as Adora drove them back into the city. Catra was still tired, her eyes heavy and her fingers twitching. After the amount of emotions she had been forced to process, she needed an outlet. She needed to grab one of her heavy-duty pillows and just knead the shit out of it. Scorpia liked to joke that she was *making biscuits*, and Catra would bite Scorpia's arm every single time she said it. Catra rarely did it at school, but sometimes the stress got too much and she just *had* to.

Catra almost didn't realize that she was purring. It was always such a giveaway to her emotions, and she had also learnt from a young age not to let herself purr, no matter how naturally it came to her. Now, it took something really intense for her purr to kick up, and

when they stopped at Catra's fake address, she was purring so loudly that Adora could hear it.

"Dont you dare," Catra growled the second Adora opened her mouth. She narrowed her eyes and flashed a bit of teeth, but that only seemed to make Adora want to say it *more*. Thankfully, she just let out a breath and shook her head.

"Y oure scary and intimidating. There, happy?"

Catra's purr grew louder. "Much."

They fell silent, Adora's eyes falling away to study the steering wheel. Catra's chest started tightening with the realization that once she climbed out of this car, it was her against the world again. She didnt want to return to reality . She didnt want to go home to Sharon.

"Can I..." Adora started, cleared her throat. Catra' s eyes flicked to her again, and they widened when she noted how flushed Adora was. "Could I feel your purr?"

Catra's hair immediately fluffed up in warning, but not because she felt threatened. It took a few seconds for her to process the request, for her to remind herself that Adora wasnt asking to be *weird*. Adora saw her bodily reaction, but she didnt say anything. She looked like she was a half second away from falling over herself to apologize. That wouldnt do.

"Push your seat back."

Adora's breath caught. "What?"

Catra rolled her eyes and moved forward to do it. She reached underneath the seat to pull at the handle there, then pushed the seat all the way back. Adora squeaked in surprise as Catra crawled onto her lap and then curled into a ball. She pulled Adora's arm around her waist and let her tail snake around her wrist.

"Catra?"

Just hearing the strangled tone of her voice made Catra's heart skip and her purr continue at full force. Adora's fingers were pressed to her lower back, and she let out a soft gasp. Her hand pressed flat, and then her arm tugged Catra closer.

"Whoa," Adora breathed.

Catra's ears twitched. She let her head rest against Adora's chest, right beneath her jaw, and just let her body express its natural contentedness. Her tail wrapped all the way around Adora's arm, looping multiple times until there was no length left. Adora's other hand came up, fingers sinking into her hair to gently scratch at her scalp.

Her purring intensified. Adora's heart was thundering.

"This feels..." Adora swallowed. "I dont know how to describe it."

Catra let out a shaky breath. She pulled Adora's arm from her waist, gently took her hand and pressed it to her chest by her collarbones. Adora gasped softly again.

"One day Im using you as a pillow."

Catra laughed. "If anyone else said that, I would take it as a threat."

To her credit, Adora didnt touch her anywhere else or move much. She was sitting still, back straight. Catra couldnt help herself and lifted her face to rub her cheek against the underside of Adora's jaw. Adora tilted her head, affording Catra more space. She continued purring happily, rubbing against Adora's jaw until she was satisfied. Adora seemed to calm down, relaxing into the seat, fingers gently carding through Catra's thick hair.

Adora must have done so absently, but she lifted her hand and her fingertips brushed against Catra's ear. Many things happened

simultaneously. Catra yelped loudly, springing away. Adora quickly grabbed her to stop her from falling over, and then they were pressed chest to chest again, Adora's eyes comically wide.

"I'm so sorry ."

Catra's face felt like it was burning. "It' s okay, just... My ears are sensitive."

Adora looked immensely guilty. Catra brushed her tail against her jaw. "I'm really sorry , Catra. I didn't mean to touch you without asking."

"It' s really okay, dummy."She rolled her eyes and climbed of f her lap. "Just, don't touch my ears again unless you're going to take responsibility."

She met Adora's confused eyes and waited for her to understand. When she did, she sputtered in embarrassment. Catra wanted to laugh at her, but she was too embarrassed herself. She was just glad that she had yelped and didn't moan.

Adora busied herself with pulling the seat forward again, and then they were once again faced with the reality that the date was over and they would need to part. Catra felt sad, but then also like an idiot, because she would see Adora at school. It wasn't like this would be their last moment together, ever. At least, she hoped it wasn't.

"I had a lot of fun tonight, Catra."

Catra smiled. "Y eah, me too. Thanks, Adora."

"Thanks for not murdering me."

Catra slowly opened the door and pushed it open. "I had to exercise a lot of restraint."She glared, eyes narrowed. "Y ou've got guts, calling me cute."

Adora's grin was mischievous. "Dont worry , Ill never tell anyone else how cute you are. That's for me only."

A thrill went down Catra's spine at the words, at the implied possessiveness. She forced her purr down, and instead leaned in to kiss Adora desperately on the lips. Adora groaned softly. As quickly as it started, Catra pulled away and slipped out the car.

"See you tomorrow?" Adora asked her , dazed and hopeful.

Catra rolled her eyes. "Where else would I be?" She lingered a few more seconds, unwilling to part with this moment, but then Adora's phone started to ring and her face blanched.

"Oh no," Adora gasped softly . "It' s Mara."

Catra stifled her laughter. "Oh well, it was nice having a girlfriend for a few hours."

"Catra, dont say~~don~~t be mean! She' s going to kill me."

Catra did laugh outright then. "F in the chat."

Adora gave her an offended huff, and then Catra shut the door and made her way up the driveway. Adora still stayed until Catra was out of sight, and then she left. Catra waited until she was absolutely sure Adora had driven off before she started down the road to her actual house.

Sharon was waiting for her, sitting stiffly on her bed. She silently watched as Catra climbed in through her open window, and Catra was so distracted and filled with everything *Adora* that she didnt notice Sharon was even in her room until a cold hand clutched at her chin and wrenched her face around. She had to swallow her involuntary hiss.

"Where were you?" Sharon asked her , voice hard and cold.

Catra swallowed. "Going for a walk."

Sharon's dark eyes narrowed. "If you do this again, you will return home to find your window bolted shut. Do you understand me?"

Translation: *I will make you sleep in the yard.*

Catra's anger started rising. She wordlessly nodded, and then Sharon dropped her chin and stalked from her room. Catra carefully closed her door, reigning herself in, not slamming it like she so desperately wanted to. When she heard Sharon's bedroom door click shut, she undressed and then crawled underneath her bed.

She rested her chin on her folded arms and curled herself into the tightest ball possible. The anxiety was beating harshly in her chest, but she could still smell Adora's scent on her, and it helped to calm her nerves. Still, the thoughts were swirling in her mind.

Not good enough.

Delinquent.

Good for nothing.

Worthless.

Disappointment.

You will hurt her. You will hurt her. You will hurt her.

Catra hissed at herself, dug her claws into the floor and focused on her ragged breathing until it evened out and she fell into a fitful sleep.

Adora
Hey Scorps, cant make it this morning, need to see coach about the upcoming game. Will you make sure Catra gets to class okay?

Scorpia
Sure thing Captain!<3

Adora hurriedly put her phone away when Huntara walked into her office and dropped down into her seat. She had been surprised when another student found her at the gate to tell her Coach wanted to see her urgently.

"Is everything alright, Coach?" Adora asked, nervously rubbing her fingers together.

Huntara sat back in her seat and exhaled. "I wanted to check in with you about your injury."

Adora unconsciously rolled her shoulder. "I'm fine."

Huntara's eyes narrowed. "You were hurt during the last game, Adora. You assured me you would not push yourself. You have a real future in this sport, if you wish to pursue it."

Adora flushed in shame. "I'm sorry, I understand."

"Your mother called with concerns. She feels you are being pushed too hard during practice."

"I'll take it easier, I promise."

"Adora." Huntara leaned forward and placed her elbows on the table. "If you need to sit out for practice or a game, please let me know. We need you out there, but not at the cost of your health."

Adora's fingers tightened around the fabric of her skirt. All these years, all this therapy, and she was still battling with the need to excel at everything she did. Mara was right, but it wasn't Huntara pushing her too hard. She was pushing herself. She didn't want to continue with rugby after school. With how much her shoulder was starting to hurt near constantly, she figured she didn't have much time playing the sport anyway.

She didn't know how to tell Huntara that, how to deal with her disappointment. She lifted her head and gave Huntara what she

hoped was a reassuring smile.

"I'll be careful, and if I can't handle it I'll tell you."

Huntara's narrowed eyes said that she was sceptical, but she relented with a nod and let her go. Adora eagerly bolted from her office and headed to their classrooms in the hope that she could see Catra before the bell rang.

Adora didn't end up finding Catra in time. She was bursting with the need to see her, and growing anxious that she seemed to be nowhere in sight. Through the day, Adora kept glancing about the room, out the window and down the hallway. She spotted Scorpia a few times, but not Catra.

Had something happened? Adora couldn't think of anything that had gone wrong. They'd ended the date with a kiss.

Was Catra regretting it? Did she decide to skip school so that she didn't have to face the mistake?

Adora's mind was swirling with anxiety as her feet went on autopilot and took her to the band club room. When she realized she was there, she already had a hand on the door handle. She hesitated only a second, then pushed the door open.

Catra was curled into a ball on top of their lockers. Her tail was tightly curled around her legs and her face was buried in her arms, her ears flat against her head. She seemed too tense to be asleep, but Adora still closed the door quietly and padded into the room.

"Catra?"

Catra almost unfurled. Her head lifted, ears pricking forward and her tail dropped down to lash lazily against the metal doors of the lockers. "Adora," she breathed, like a sigh of relief. It sent similar relief crashing through Adora.

"What's wrong?"

Catra's darkened eyes studied her. She looked pretty distraught, and Adora hated seeing her that way. Once she got to see Catra actually smile and laugh, she was addicted to the sight. Finally, Catra sighed and jumped down from her perch. She made adorable noises as she stretched her limbs.

"I didn't feel like class today," Catra told her. She fluffed out her skirt. "Decided to skip in here and nap."

Adora noticed the way her tail kept twitching, how her ears seemed a little too upright. Catra was anxious about something, and trying to hide it.

Adora still had her last two periods left, then practice after. She decided Catra was more important, so she shot Scorpia a quick message to tell Coach she needed to rest her shoulder and would go straight to club after school, then she plopped down on the couch and patted her lap. Catra blinked at her.

They stayed there for a short moment, Adora just waiting, smiling patiently as Catra studied her face. Catra let out a soft breath and then curled onto her lap. Adora happily wrapped her arms around her and cradled her gently.

"Do you want to talk about it?" Adora asked her. "I can tell something's wrong."

Catra started to purr. It was too soft for Adora to hear yet, but she could feel it. It was such a wonder, feeling the gentle vibrations that could really turn intense if Catra felt the need. Adora had, of course, googled about this too. Purring was a sign that the magicat was overwhelmed with positive feelings. Purring was also completely normal during physical intimacy of any kind. Adora's cheeks still warned, knowing Catra felt happy and safe enough around her to purr.

Catra took in a shuddering breath. "Foster bitch caught me sneaking back in last night," she started, her voice nearly a whisper . "Threatened me when I got back. The usual. It just... brought up some negative thoughts."

Adora tightened her arms around Catra and then turned them so that she could lay down on her back on the couch with Catra draped over her. Catra's purr grew audible, so Adora knew she appreciated the position. Adora gently trailed a hand down the length of her back.

"She sounds really awful. Im sorry for getting you in trouble."

"Not your fault, Adora. She finds any reason to be hard on me."

"How long have you been with her?"

"Since I was eight."

"And you didnt think to tell anyone?" Catra started to tense, so Adora gave her hip a gentle squeeze. "Im not judging or anything, I know what it's like. Many times I was too afraid of telling someone I was being abused. A lot of the adults never took me seriously and it always ended in me getting hurt even worse because I tried."

Catra relaxed against her . She scooted closer and nuzzled into Adora's throat, brushing her cheek against the underside of her jaw again. *Marking* her again. Adora's heart felt like it would beat right out of her chest.

"I considered it once," Catra admitted. "And it ended badly . And then I gave up on the thought."

Adora frowned. "Was it Glimmer?"

Catra made a strange noise in her throat and then bumped their cheeks. "Dont talk about Glimmer while were cuddling."

That was as good as a confirmation, but Adora didnt want to ruin the mood again. She sensed that Catra didnt talk about this stuff often,

and she needed to.

"Should we change the topic?"

"No, it's just..." Catra removed her face from Adora's throat and hid it against her chest. "She hates me, Adora. I know I'm a difficult person, but... Why did she foster me? Why does she still keep me? I waited so many years for her to just drop me off at the group home I was in before. But she just kept me. Even after the accident."

"The accident?"

Catra let out a sardonic laugh. "Right, you haven't seen her face." She shuddered. "When I was little, I didn't understand that I was different to all the human kids. I had claws and sharp teeth from birth, so I tended to accidentally hurt the other kids. I was punished a lot, just for being me. Well, Sharon got pissed once that I wasn't standing up for myself despite being a *dangerous predator*, so the next day I used my claws. Sharon got pissed that I hurt the kid, and then she tried to get me declawed."

Adora shot up, a gasp in her chest. Her eyes went wide with shock and even Catra looked at her questioningly. She gently cupped her face and stared down into her eyes. "That's... If I didn't hate her before, I really do now."

Catra's eyes softened and she pressed into her palm, her purr returned. Adora's throat went dry when Catra nuzzled into her palm, her fur impossibly soft. Adora had definitely been fantasizing about petting Catra all over.

"I put up a huge fight. Declawing a magicat is as good as death. I ended up mauling her face in my panic, and then she stumbled back and fell through our glass door and cut up even more of her face." Catra's ears folded flat. "She just claimed the glass cut her face, never mentioned that I clawed her. I think she was too scared of the backlash. For a little bit, she was scared of me too."

Adora fell back down and pulled Catra with her. Absently, she rubbed her hands along Catra's arms, ruffling her fur there. "Wow, she's such a dick."

"Oh my god, Adora Gray just said the word *dick*."

"I can say fuck too."

Catra laughed. Despite the heavy topic, she seemed almost lazy now, her body all but melted into Adora's. Her tail swished back and forth, then curled around Adora's hand. She hesitantly closed her fingers around it, stared as she stroked the thick hair.

"You really like my tail, huh?"

Adora swallowed. "I like a lot of things about you."

Catra's eyes darkened. "Kiss me, idiot."

Adora's eyes flicked to Catra's and she sucked in a deep breath. Without more prompting she dipped forward and drew Catra into a soft kiss. Catra's purr was in full force, vibrating right through both of them, but it was a comforting sensation and sound. Adora could definitely fall asleep to it. She didn't know where to put her hands, so she just cupped Catra's cheeks and brushed her thumbs against the very fine fur there.

"I could get used to this," Catra sighed against her mouth. She nipped at Adora's lower lip, making her groan softly. "Humans are so easy to turn on."

Adora sputtered. "I'm not—I mean, you're... wow, you're rude."

Catra laughed and tapped her nose. "Sensitive smell, remember?"

Adora flushed darkly. "Don't test me, I'll touch your ears."

"And?"

"And... your tail."

Catra snickered. "You sure you want to try that, Princess?"

Adora didn't want to test it, not really. Not because she wasn't ready for whatever doing *that* would cause, but because she was too afraid of doing something wrong and hurting Catra.

Turns out, she didn't even need to worry about it. Just as Catra kissed her again, the door burst open and Scorpia rushed in, face flushed and hair wet. She froze in the doorway.

"Close the door!" Catra hissed at her.

Scorpia's eyes went wide, and then she scrambled to close the door behind her. She was blushing furiously, which made Adora flush. Catra was still on top of her, tail fluffed in warning now, ears folded down like she was ready for a fight. Adora could feel the points of her claws very lightly digging into her chest, but she didn't mind them.

"So..." Scorpia began. She sheepishly scratched her cheek. "Should I leave you two alone or...?"

Catra groaned and just hid her face against Adora's throat again. She offered no explanation, no excuse. Adora patted her back and sent Scorpia a nervous smile.

"You don't have to go. We're just cuddling."

"And kissing," Catra mumbled, but too low for Scorpia to hear.

"I feel like a third wheel here," Scorpia joked. She didn't look upset, and in fact she seemed very pleased. She gave Adora a thumbs-up and then went to put her stuff away and grab her guitar. For the duration of club, Scorpia played on her own and Catra drifted in and out of sleep. Adora was just content to lay there, to stroke Catra's fur

wherever she could, to press a kiss to her hair or her temple and just make her feel as comfortable and safe as she could.

Adora had never felt so happy in her life before.

Chapter End Notes

I have made a twitter for my celeb AU where I will be posting all the extra info that I don't want to cram into the fic itself. Info such as all the details on the TV show they act in, and the movies Adora did. I've made a bunch of posters too!As I post the fic I will be making teaser posts on there too, and writing up fake headline/articles that go with the fic. Go check it out! @POPcelebAU

As always, thank you so much for reading

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> !it's finished!i was so tempted to just go to sleep cause Im so tired but I also just NEEDED to write this so here it is and aaah!I predicted that this final chapter would be 10k words and I was right?Holy heck. I havent edited the later half of it yet, Im way too tired. So Im going to sleep now lmao. Ill read and edit when I get a chance. So, enjoy the end of Dirtbag! (Also a note that I forgot almost everything about rugby and I dunno shit about injuries so just shhh and enjoy the gay)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra didnt need to wonder how Adora had convinced her to go to their school's stupid rugby match on a Friday afternoon.

All it took were those gorgeous blue eyes, those soft lips in a little pout and Adora stroking the tuft of fur at her elbow as she pleaded in the softest voice ever.

"Please come and watch my game?"

There was absolutely *no way* that Catra could even possibly conceive of the idea of saying no and making Adora's pleading face fall with disappointment. As boring as she knew the match would likely be, Catra said yes. She said yes because she loved Adora, and she actually wanted this new, bright thing between them to work out. For once, she was going to be kind to herself and others around her.

People mostly ignored her, but she still received the few curious glances shed gotten the last time she came to a match, when she had officially met Adora for the first time. Catra couldnt help but grin to herself at the thought, now knowing Adora had set it all up to meet her.

"Such a dork," she mumbled to herself. Her chest felt warm with affection.

It had only been a week since they started dating, and Catra honestly felt like she was living some sort of fantasy. Or she was having a very realistic, elaborate dream. They didn't tell anyone—besides Scorpia finding out by walking in on them—and they hadn't really talked about if they wanted others to know or not. Adora still glanced at her across the hallway or class with a stupidly affectionate look in her eyes, and whenever they passed by each other Catra would wrap her tail around her wrist just long enough to make her nearly trip from getting all flustered.

If people noticed, then they noticed. Whatever. Catra didn't care what others thought, but she did know that the gossip mill at this school would run wild with the news. Adora Gray dating *Catra*? Who would have thought Adora had such terrible taste?

Still, Catra grinned at the knowledge. *She* knew exactly what sort of noises Adora let out when their making out got a little *too* heavy. She could pick out Adora's scent from across the entire field. She could count on Adora looking at *her* and no one else. It was a strange feeling, and one she was still getting used to.

Adora *loved* her.

Catra settled at the top of the pavilion and fished her headphones out. It was warm out this time, not cloudy or raining, so she took her pullover off and hoped the game ended quickly. Honestly? Catra hated clothing. She was always forced to wear human-made clothes, because Sharon claimed clothes designed for magicats were too expensive and there was no physical store close by. They could just order online, but it was clearly too difficult for her. As soon as Catra was out of her house, she was going to throw all her clothes away and get new ones.

"Hey Catra!"

Her ears switched at the sudden shout of her name, and she glanced down the pavilion in surprise to see Bow waving happily at her. Glimmer was beside him, looking anywhere but up. To Catra's horror, Bow grabbed Glimmer's hand and then tugged her as he climbed the pavilion steps to where Catra was sitting. People parted like a wave as they went, and hushed whispers started up as people noticed who Bow was heading toward.

"Fancy seeing you here," Bow told her , grinning.

Catra's claws were out and her tail had gone bushy, but she tried to stamp down on her instincts. She knew Bow likely knew about her thing with Adora, whether Adora had outright told him or he just had eyes. Catra knew how smart he was, so there was no way he didnt know.

"Adora asked me to come," she decided to answer , awkward.

Bow's smile turned even brighter. Glimmer finally looked at her, blinking in surprise, but she said nothing. Catra narrowed her eyes at her and was seconds away from hissing, but Bow moved and plopped down beside her.

"Man, the entire school was buzzing in excitement for this match," he started, either doing his best to divert a fight or very oblivious to what had almost just happened. "If Adora wins this for us, well go to nationals."

Catra snorted before she could stop herself. "Of course Adora will win this." She flushed when she realized what she had said. "She put her all into this."

Bow lightly bumped their shoulders. "She sure did."

Catra's fur stuck up at the contact, but he moved away quickly and she forced herself to relax. If Adora was friends with him, then Bow had to be somewhat of a good person. Catra trusted Adora, and

Adora wouldn't associate with assholes. Glimmer glanced around Bow. Okay, except *one* asshole.

Thankfully, Bow didn't talk to her again. The match started and Catra's headphones hung silent around her neck. She was drawn into the game despite her claimed disinterest, and she watched in rapt awe as Adora bulldozed across the field and nearly demolished the other team.

Their home team was winning so absolutely that it was nearly embarrassing watching the other team desperately try to score points. They must have realized how futile it was, because towards the end one of their bigger players slammed Adora into the ground and the referee immediately signalled for the player to leave the field. The pavilion erupted in unhappy boos.

Adora should have gotten up quickly, but she didn't. Catra sucked in a sharp breath. Adora was curled into herself, cradling her shoulder. Catra stood, but Bow grabbed her wrist and stopped her. It was lucky that he did.

Scorpia went to Adora's side and helped her up. Thankfully she could stand, but even from such a distance Catra could see the pain on her face. Huntara was yelling something to the other school's coach, but Catra didn't bother to listen to her. All she could think about was Adora. Adora hurt. Adora in pain. *Adora.*

"Go to her," Bow finally said, releasing his grip. Catra never even realized he was still holding onto her.

The second Adora left the field, Catra leapt off the pavilion from the top stair. She landed in a practised crouch and hurried over, her face creased with worry. She could feel eyes following her, but she didn't care.

"Wildcat!" Scorpia called out, her own brow creased.

Adora glanced up and despite the pain in her eyes, she grinned broadly. "Hey Catra."

They paused when she got to them and Scorpia gently set her arm down so that Adora could reach out for her. Catra eagerly accepted her arm over her shoulder and drew her in until their sides were flush.

"Are you okay?"

Adora let out a breath. "I'm fine," she lied.

Catra glared at her. "You're not fine, Adora. It's your shoulder, right?"

Scorpia was frowning at them, and from the serious look on her face she knew what this was about. "I asked her not to play today," Scorpia told her. "She didn't want to listen."

Huntara rushed over to them, her face flushed darkly in anger. When she noted the amount of pain on Adora's face, she must have decided to schedule her screaming lecture for later. "Get your ass to the nurse *immediately*," Huntara growled. "And this is it, Adora. You're off the team."

Catra's eyes widened in shock, but Adora didn't seem very surprised. A look passed between her and Huntara, and then she huffed and stalked back to the field. They still had 5 minutes left of the match. They would definitely win anyway, thanks to Adora.

"You're such an idiot," Catra growled angrily. "You knew this was your last match, didn't you?"

They started walking again. Adora seemed to be trying to hide most of her pain, but her steps were faltering and her face was slicked with sweat. She smelt heavily like pain~~-~~scent Catra hated. It was sharp and bitter. But Adora's normal scent helped to dampen it, along with the usual smell of soil and cut grass. Adora was smudged

with grass stains and spots of dirt, and she definitely needed a shower.

"It'll be fine," Adora told her. "I just needed to carry us to nationals. I can retire happily now."

Catra growled softly. "At the cost of your shoulder, Adora."

"I'll be fine."

Catra had to force herself to keep her claws in. She was all sorts of worried and angry, at Adora and at this fucking school. If they knew she was hurt, why did they keep letting her play? Catra should have known. She should have done *something* to stop her playing this match.

Catra silently simmered in her anger as she helped Adora to the nurse. People quickly moved out of the way when they saw her expression and who she was escorting, and Catra was in no mood to care what the other students thought. Her only objective was getting Adora to the nurse.

Scorpia quickly opened the door for them when they got there, and the nurse rose from her chair with wide eyes.

"Oh dear, again?"

Catra's fur bristled. The nurse even knew? This was *that* common?

Adora let out a soft breath. Catra helped her get up on the bed but she didn't move away. She was angry with Adora, but she sure as hell wasn't going to punish her for this. She was suffering enough.

"I pushed myself too hard, I'm sorry."

The nurse let out a sigh and gave Adora a pitying look. "I will need to call your mother, Adora."

"I know. She needs to know."

"Let' s first have a look and see how serious it is, alright?"

Catra refused to move away even when the nurse cast her a pointed look. She only took a single step away, enough for the nurse to gently remove Adora's shirt, leaving her in her sports bra. Adora made a soft whine of pain in her chest, and Catra instinctively grabbed her hand and curled her tail around her leg in comfort. Adora's fingers intertwined with her own, and then she *squeezed* as she hissed in yet another bout of pain. The nurse was prodding at her skin, and then experimentally lifted her arm.

"Adora, you nearly tore the muscle," the nurse told her. "I see extensive bruising, and this isn't just from today. You'll need to keep this arm in a sling to prevent any unnecessary strain. No picking things up. No using this arm at all, do you understand?"

Catra leaned back to see for herself and let out a soft gasp. There were splotches of bruises along Adora's shoulder, some already yellowed and fading and new ones nearly black and purple. Adora tried to tug her hand free, clearly ashamed, but Catra kept her hand tightly.

"I understand," she told the nurse. She turned and Catra stepped forward in time for Adora to drop her forehead against her shoulder. She let out a soft breath. "I'm an idiot."

Catra absently cupped Adora's cheek and rubbed her thumb against her flushed skin. "The biggest idiot."

"The King of Idiotville," Adora added.

"A person that still has issues, maybe," Scorpia interjected. "But yeah, definitely an idiot."

They all laughed together. Catra was slowly relaxing. If Adora didn't need to go to the hospital, then it couldn't be too serious. The nurse gave her some pain meds to take, which she swallowed with a glass of water. She was instructed to go home and rest and absolutely not

use her arm or shoulder at all. Once again, Catra helped Adora walk. She slapped Adora's head with her tail.

"Idiot."

Adora bumped their hips. "Yeah, but you're in love with me, so." She stuck her tongue out.

Scorpia left them to let Huntara know what the nurse had said, and Catra took Adora to gather her things and then she carried Adora's bag for her—despite her protests. When Adora tried to tug the bag out of her grasp, Catra hissed at her. Adora stopped fighting her.

They went to the parking lot to wait for Mara, and Catra wrapped her tail around Adora's waist. Adora's breaths were still strained, and she had a mild grimace of pain on her face. The pills would take a bit to kick in. Catra wished she could take all of her pain away.

"Thank you," Adora told her softly.

Catra sighed and nuzzled into her. "I'm here for you, Adora."

"Please prevent me from being a big dumb idiot again."

"If you tell me when I'm being too much of a bitch. Deal?"

"Deal."

Adora pressed a kiss to her forehead and Catra's ears pricked forward. She started purring loudly, so that Adora could hear, and scooted even closer. She would crawl onto Adora's lap if she wasn't afraid of hurting her.

"You know, people are staring," Adora mumbled into her hair.

Catra bared her teeth. "Let them look."

Adora laughed softly. "No. Only *I* get to look."

Catra flushed darkly and thanked the fact that her skin wasn't visible under her fur. She just groaned and then rubbed her cheek against Adora's, effectively wiping the smug look right off her face.

"There," she purred happily, smirking. "Now they can look *and* smell."

Adora covered her red face with a hand. "You're a bastard cat."

"And don't forget it."

The pills started kicking in and Adora's eyes started drooping, so Catra kept an arm around her to keep her up. Adora was just about to fall asleep on her shoulder when a car pulled up by them and a very buff, very beautiful woman stepped out of the car. She hurried to their side, frowning in concern.

"Adora?"

Adora stirred and sat up. "It's my mom!" she exclaimed happily. "Mara, I'm so sorry."

Mara bent down to one knee and cupped Adora's face in her hands. She inspected her all over for any other injury, then let out a breath. She smelled like worry, and sweat, but over all of that she had a very welcoming scent. Catra's purr kicked up again, and though it wasn't audible yet, Adora felt it. She gave her a crooked grin.

"You're banished to your bed for the week," Mara told her. "And are you going to introduce me to your friend?"

Adora let out a snort between her laugh. "Mara, this is Catra." Her grin was so big and happy. She also looked like she was about to fall asleep mid-sentence. "My girlfriend."

Catra's cheeks warmed. She wanted to get up and run, but she didn't want to let go of Adora for fear that she would fall over and hurt herself some more. She also just wanted to stop running away as a rule.

“W ell,” Mara started, turning to give her a goofy grin that was very similar to the one Adora was giving her. “It’ s nice to meet you, Catra the girlfriend. Im Mara. Been raising this one here.”

Catra swallowed thickly. For a long second she couldnt even speak, choked up by her nerves. What if Mara didnt like her? What if she said something wrong? What if—

Mara’s eyes softened and Catra let out the breath she was keeping hostage. “It’ s nice to meet you.”

“Likewise. Adora wouldnt shut up about you for *weeks*. Thank you for taking care of her.”

Catra was unaccustomed to so much warmth being directed at her. It actually made her fur bristle and her claws come out, but not because she was upset. She was just very overwhelmed.

“Ouch,” Adora laughed softly .

Catra realized her claws were sticking into Adora’ s side, so she pulled her hand away. “Sorry .”

Adora hummed and brushed their noses. “Mm, s okay . Too much?”

Catra’s eyes fluttered closed. Adora’s scent was all around her now, combined with Mara’s. It was making her heart race. “Y eah.”

Adora pulled away from her and set a hand on Mara’s shoulder. “Mom, take me home. Catra needs some space.”

Catra let out a relieved breath, but her heart also clenched. As overwhelmed as she felt, part of her didnt want to be without Adora. She wanted to continue making sure she didnt hurt herself. Mara helped to support her weight, then sent Catra a very motherly look.

“Ill get her home safe, dont worry .”

Catra glanced away in embarrassment. "Thanks." She felt Adora's hand slip into hers. "Text me," she mumbled shyly. "If you need anything, or whatever."

Adora beamed at her. "I'll text you, I promise."

Adora leaned in to kiss her softly on the cheek, and then Catra watched Mara help her into the car. Her chest was still buzzing with warmth even long after they had left. Some students suddenly laughed nearby, startling Catra from her cloudy thoughts. She shoved her hands into her skirt pockets and then started her walk home.

Sharon was pissed that she was late getting home from school, but she was riding such a high that she didn't even care. Sharon wasn't pleased that she didn't tear up at the insults, and when she yelled at her to get to her room, Catra did so happily.

She spent the rest of the day texting Adora and writing a new song that was definitely not disgustingly lovey-dovey and about Adora.

Catra
hey adora. hows your shoulder holding up?

Adora
Hey Catra <3 <3 <3 It hurts like a bitch!

Catra
i wont lie, you swearing is kind of hot

Adora
Really? Shit! Fuck!

Catra
nvm im good

Adora
:(
I hate being cooped up in bed

Catra
yeah well you had to be a dummy and hurt yourself

Adora
Yeah. I feel really bad that I worried everyone. I should have known better. I should definitely tackle this issue with my therapist. She's going to be so pissed lmao

Catra
are you really ok though?

Adora
Yeah. Just tons of bruises, but Ill be fine

Catra
howd your shoulder get so fucked up anyway

Adora
It's always been a bit off after it was broken. I guess it got out that I have a bad shoulder, because the other team kept going for it

Catra
are you telling me that those horde fuckers were hurting you on purpose?

Adora
Yeah, I think so. We played a mock match two weeks ago and one of them slammed into my shoulder really hard and it felt like it was on purpose
But dont worry, Ill be fine. Im not going to play anymore anyway

Catra
if you do anything to hurt your shoulder again I am going to personally bite you

Adora
Is that a promise?;))

Catra
ew Adora
(yes)

Adora actually listened for once and her shoulder healed rather quickly. Between Mara threatening to chain her up and Catra threatening to actually bite her, Adora had no choice but to let people lift her things and open doors for her. It still made her uncomfortable to rely on others like that, but Catra soothed her worries by demanding kisses as payment.

And oh, did Adora pay her in full. They spent many afternoons in club just, kissing. Since Adora didnt need to practice anymore, she had nearly an entire hour with Catra before Scorpia joined them. They spent that time studying (the art of kissing). Sometimes they actually did study, and Catra helped her with some of her more difficult assignments. Adora was in awe at how smart Catra was, and saddened by her flippant attitude towards it.

"I'm not number one," Catra remarked, shrugging. She had just solved a really complicated maths equation that Adora was puzzled by.

Adora blinked at her. "You have the second highest grade," she told her. "That's... really not an easy thing to do."

"Still, not the best."

Adora then took the pen from Catra's hands, pulled her over onto her lap and cupped her cheeks gently. "Catra, repeat after me, okay?"

Catra blinked at her, confused. "Okay?"

"My worth is not dictated by my accomplishments."

While Adora couldnt see her blush, she could just sense it. Catra made an adorable noise in her chest and then she leaned into her palm, scowling. "My worth is not dictated by my accomplishments," Catra mumbled softly.

Adora beamed and kissed her soundly. "Good girl."

Catra groaned. "You're such a jackass."

Adora stuck her tongue out. She saw Catra try to bite it and pulled away just in time, laughing. Catra raked her sharp claws through her hair, purring loudly.

"I love you," Catra breathed, her eyes shining.

Adora could understand why she looked and sounded so in awe. She felt that way too. "Of course you do," she snickered. "I'm Adora Gray."

Catra's tail thumped her in the head, and then she was pushed flat on her back. Catra curled on top of her and growled when she tried to move.

"I want to nap."

Adora just let herself sink into the couch. "Of course. Dont let me stop you."

That's how Scorpia found them, but by then she was already used to the extreme amounts of physical contact.

Weeks and exams flew by , and things were going perfectly. Sure, there were times when Catra would come to school looking out of sorts, but Adora had already learnt how she could help. Many times, it was just her being there. Sometimes, it was listening. Catra opened up to her about Sharon, about the things she had done and still continued to do. The only topic they didnt touch on was

Glimmer, and Adora wondered if Catra was just afraid of rocking the balance they had.

"Ugh, I really don't want to go but I have to," Adora complained. She nuzzled into Catra's neck to try and bury her annoyance too.

Catra was on her lap, playing guitar. She huffed. "So don't go."

"It's in my honour."

"Again, just don't go."

Adora groaned. "The whole team is excited, Catra. They're throwing this big party in my name. They won nationals."

"So?"

Adora tightened her arms around Catra's waist. "I feel like I don't deserve it."

Catra continued strumming. "Remember what you made me say weeks ago?"

"Ugh, don't remind me."

"You're being a hypocrite."

"Yes but a sexy one."

Finally, Catra set her guitar down and twisted around on Adora's lap. Her tail curled around Adora's arm.

"Adora, if you don't want to go, then just tell them. But if you feel like you really need to, then I'm going with you."

The air left Adora's lungs. "You will?"

Catra snorted at her. "Duh. Do you really think I'd let you go to a rager on your own? Sure, it's not my scene. No one there will even

like me."

"Wrong. There will be *one* person there who likes you very much."

Catra rubbed their cheeks together. She never seemed to get enough of scent marking her, and Adora was totally alright with that. They had a few new hybrids enrol, and many of them sent Adora knowing looks. Catra started kneading her shoulders, but luckily her claws were sheathed. She did that a lot when she was happy, and Adora's chest always warmed when she did. Over the past few weeks, she had been showing more signs of being happy.

"You're such a dork," Catra laughed. There was a gentle rumbling in her chest.

Adora wiggled her brows. "Only the biggest."

So they went to the party together, and Adora couldn't seem to keep her hands off of Catra. She looked incredibly hot in her ripped jeans and leather jacket, and Adora could admit that she was *achingly* gay for her.

Mara dropped them off, not without reminding Catra to call her if anything went wrong. It amused Adora greatly that Mara only agreed to let her come if Catra attended with her, and even more that the two of them were basically on the same wavelength when it came to making sure she didn't hurt herself. She was happy that they liked each other so much, because she really hoped that Catra would be in her life for a long time.

She hadn't really mentioned that to Catra yet, too afraid that despite how fast things were moving with them already, that mentioning *forever* was moving too fast. She hoped that the conversation would happen on its own time, naturally, and she at least already how she felt.

It turned out that word of the party had spread, and it wasn't just the rugby team there. Adora spotted Scorpia inside by the kitchen, telling

Perfuma something. They were giggling and holding hands, and Adora smiled. She was overjoyed when Scorpia told them she finally asked Perfuma out, and then Adora and Catra laughed so hard they nearly passed out when Scorpia confessed that Perfuma had thought they were already dating for months.

Adora and Catra's relationship wasn't really secret anymore, but they still received the usual curious glances. Catra rarely interacted with anyone else, though there was a boy in her once class, Kyle, who had approached her. Adora still wanted to laugh thinking about it, how this scrawny human kid had asked the only magicat in town for advice on how to ask the only lizard boy out.

Catra had actually fretted for days on how to help him, before she decided it was just easier to let him talk to Adora, and she told him to just go to the guy and get to know him.

Catra tugged her to a stop in the living room, ears up and twitching, eyes darting about. "Do you want a drink?"

Adora watched a game of beer pong happening in the corner and nodded. "Yeah, sure. Nothing strong."

Catra nodded. "Yeah, I'm not dragging your drunk ass home."

The *one* time they drank together Adora had drank a bit too much. Catra never realized, because her natural tolerance was so high. That was when they figured out that Adora was a very goofy, very loud drunk, and Mara found out immediately when they got home because Adora had very loudly announced that they were sneaking in through her bedroom window. Mara made them promise that if they ever wanted to drink again, they should go to her so they could do it in her home. They also promised to drink responsibly should they ever do so at a party.

Mara was such a good mom.

Catra disappeared to get them their drinks and Adora gravitated towards the beer pong game. There were many people here who she didn't recognize at all.

"Adora!" Lonnie called from the corner of the living room. She unfolded herself from one of the other girls on their team and made her way over. Adora gave her a lopsided grin and accepted the one-armed hug. "You made it!"

The boys playing beer pong cheered loudly when one of the opponents took one more drink and then dipped out.

"Yeah, couldn't miss it," Adora laughed. "Congrats on winning, by the way!"

The music wasn't really all that loud, but the conversations were and Adora had to strain to hear when Lonnie responded.

"All in your honour, Captain!" she shouted happily. She lifted her drink in the air. "Hey everyone, cheers for Captain Adora!"

Adora only saw a handful of her teammates in the room, but everyone there immediately lifted their drinks and yelled in union. Adora's face flushed darkly, and then an arm curled around her waist and claws tapped her hip before she could tense at the invasion. Catra pressed up to whisper in her ear.

"Are you okay?"

"Fine," she mumbled, flushed. Her heart was just thundering right in her throat suddenly.

Lonnie was watching them curiously, a brow lifted. This was their first time being somewhere public together like this where a majority of their schoolmates could see them, and Catra was blatantly hanging on her.

"Hi," Lonnie greeted her. "Didn't expect you see you here."

Catra's tail swayed behind them, and though her ears twitched only slightly—and only Adora actually noticed—Catra just handed Adora's drink to her and then took a sip of her own.

"Came here for Adora."

At that, Lonnie smirked at them. The game of pong intensified as yet another person dipped out, and then they decided to do a team round. Someone shoved Kyle to the table, and his eyes darted around nervously until Rogelio, the lizard boy, joined his side. Kyle noticed them and grinned broadly.

"Catra!" he called out. "Play with us!"

Adora could see the excitement leaking into Catra's body, but she seemed unsure. Her ears kept swivelling when there were shouts or bangs in the house, and her tail was twitching almost anxiously. All eyes were on them, waiting to see if they would accept the challenge.

"I'm a good aim," Adora told her. "I'll throw if you drink."

Catra downed her entire drink and then set the plastic cup down on a nearby table. "Deal."

She bared her fangs in a smirk as people around them started to cheer. Kyle was an absolutely terrible shot, but Rogelio refused to let him drink because he would get tipsy if he even just inhaled alcoholic fumes. People yelled every time Adora landed a shot, and each time Catra had to take a drink they chorused "chug, chug, chug!" like this was some cliché teen drama movie. It was all so fun.

Catra wasn't even buzzed when they won, and many people started giving them high-fives and claps on the shoulder, even Catra. It was so nice to see people actually acknowledging her, and while Catra did seem a bit awkward and unsure how to accept the positive attention, she was also drinking it in. Before anyone knew it, Catra amassed a crowd while she showed off her claws, and then she

made Adora nearly choke to death when she accepted a dare and crawled along the goddamn ceiling. People lost their minds.

Adora tore her eyes away from Catra's smug expression when her phone vibrated in her pocket.

Bow
Hey Adora. Are you at the party? Glimmer wanted us to support you but we might be lost, could you go and stand in the yard so we can be sure we got the right place?

Adora
Hey Bow! Yeah of course. How far are you?

Bow
I think we're in the neighbourhood

Adora
Ok, on my way outside now

Bow
Thanks Adora

Catra was in the middle of a game of arm wrestling with one of the very muscular boys on the wrestling team when Adora went over to tap her on the shoulder.

"Heading outside to meet Bow and Glimmer , will you be fine here?"

Catra didn't even look at her , eyes shining with challenge. "Perfect," she purred.

Adora absently pressed a kiss to her temple and then made her way out, her chest buzzing. She could feel the alcohol warm in her veins, but she was only very lightly tipsy. She honestly didn't want to get smashed.

Coming to this party had been a good idea after all. Through the past few weeks, Adora had seen people's attitude towards Catra rapidly

change. Not only did it help that some people started liking her after the talent show, but since they met, Catra had been trying very hard to stop pushing people away. So if someone forgot a pen and she was close by, she would offer an extra one. If someone bumped into her in the hallway, she no longer hissed and spat at them in fury.

Adora was glowing with happiness and pride. It was cool outside, but it was at least much quieter. Most of the kids had been dropped off or walked, but there were a couple cars parked down the street. Adora would have been fine driving here, if she wasnt banned from even touching Mara's car until finals were over. It was a very light punishment for stealing the car for their first date, and that was entirely because Mara had found it funny and adorable.

"*Gay*,"Mara had snorted when Adora guiltily drudged through the garage door into the house.

A soft breeze washed over Adora' s face, bringing with it a tint of heat and the scent of fresh grass. She closed her eyes and tipped her head back to soak it in, so she didnt notice the group until someone suddenly slammed into her shoulder and she cried out in pain. She went down and landed *on top of* her fucked up shoulder.

"Oops!"one of the girls laughed down at her , grinning smugly. She was on the Horde's rugby team. "Didnt see you there."

Red, hot anger gripped Adora right by the throat. She made to shoot up, but when she braced herself pain hot through her upper body and she just collapsed, nearly writhing in pain. The group surrounding her laughed. Tears of pain and anger pressed at Adora's eyes but she just couldnt get herself up.

"Hey , asshole!"

"Y ou fuckers!"

Adora's eyes flew wide in surprise. She managed to crane her neck just in time to see a flurry of sharp claws and bright pink hair crash

into the group of bullies. Someone shrieked and then they tried to run, but Catra had one by the hair and Glimmer was wrestling with another on the ground. Warm hands clutched at Adora's shoulders and she startled.

"Just me," Bow told her calmly, watching the brawl with a frown. "Are you okay?"

The girl Catra was fighting managed to crawl out of her jacket and bolt out of the yard, so Catra helped Glimmer by grabbing the girl off of her. Glimmer had been trying, but she was losing. Catra held the girl up in her one hand, right off her feet.

"If you or your morons ever hurt my girlfriend again, I will claw your eyes out. Do. You. Understand?" Catra snarled at her.

The girl nodded. The moment Catra let her go, she dropped down and then took off like a streak of lightning. Catra turned and rushed to Adora's side.

"Adora, are you okay?"

Bow had settled her head in his lap and Catra came to her right, Glimmer to her left.

"I saw them approach, but I didn't know what they were going to do," Glimmer told her.

Adora let out a long, pained breath. "I think I need to call Mara and go to the E.R. My shoulder hurts bad."

Catra's eyes were filled with worry. Adora watched Glimmer glance at her.

"We'll be here until Mara can take you," Glimmer told her. "All three of us."

Adora shakily wiped at the tears in her eyes, wincing as the movement made more pain shoot through her. "Thanks guys."

Catra's tail was lashing violently behind her, and from the way her eyes were darting back and forth, Adora knew she likely wanted to head out and find those girls for round 2. She laughed softly.

"Dont fight anyone, okay?"

Catra's eyes lowered to meet hers. "You're really expecting me to let this go? They hurt you, Adora. For no reason."

"She's right," Glimmer agreed. Catra glanced at her in surprise. "But Im not getting into another physical fight. Im going to tell my mother and well figure out who they are and get them in trouble."

Catra snorted. "Why am I surprised?"

Glimmer didnt argue with her, and Catra didnt say anything else. They stayed there after Bow called Mara and waited, and when she arrived they helped Adora to her feet.

"Text me," Catra told her, giving her hand a squeeze.

Adora's gaze softened. "I will."

The door closed and Mara started asking her questions, and Adora just held onto her arm as the pain came in waves. Mara was furious, and Adora was in pain, and she just wished she could have stayed back there. The night had started so well.

Catra's claws were fully extended and she had no intention of hiding them. She was grinding her teeth together in an effort to resist the intense urge to follow the scent of those girls and fuck them up. Past Catra would not have hesitated, but Glimmer was here, and Catra knew that if she gave in to her baser instincts she would just get into trouble down the line. Besides, she had no doubt Glimmer would make sure those girls got what they deserved.

It was an uncomfortable thing, though, to trust Glimmer with something again. Catra had heard Adora's cry of pain and then the solid sound of a body hitting the ground, and she was up and out the house on all fours. She saw Glimmer launching across the yard before she even saw Adora.

After Mara drove off, the three of them stood there on the side of the road staring after them. Bow cleared his throat and started picking grass and rocks from Glimmer's hair. Catra became acutely aware who she was standing beside. Glimmer was so close that Catra could pick out the scent of her washing powder brand, and it was the same as she remembered.

Strangely, she didnt get the usual rush of anger and resentment, and the intense urge to turn and run far away. She was certainly weary, but she was well aware that Glimmer clearly cared about Adora, had actually punched someone for her. She could admit to herself now that maybe she had overreacted when they were kids, and maybe she should finally sit down with Glimmer and just *talk.*

Not right now, though. Catra was still angry, and she knew that a single wrong comment could have her fur standing up and a hiss clawing up her throat. She didnt want to unintentionally ruin things before they even had a chance to maybe patch it up.

Catra decided to turn and start heading home. Mara had dropped her off with Adora, but she could just walk home. She would get there pretty late, with the threat of Sharon getting pissed off again, but Catra really wasnt in the mood to care.

"Catra, wait." She paused at the sound of Glimmer's voice. "Did... do you have a ride home?"

When Catra turned to her, Glimmer was glancing elsewhere. She smelt like nerves and anxiety, and from the way she was clutching her fingers together Catra knew that she was trying to reach out, but not really sure how.

"Yeah," she finally answered, voice measured and calm despite the storm still raging in her chest. "But thanks, Glimmer."

She saw the surprise register on Glimmer's face, but she didn't stay to talk. She got home pretty late and Sharon was waiting up for her, again. Catra had snuck out again, because she wouldn't have been allowed to leave anyway. This time she came in through the front door and didn't even attempt to sneak in.

The lounge lamp clicked on loudly, revealing Sharon sitting on the couch with her hair up in a tightly wound bun and her deep scarlet gown wrapped around her body. She was sitting stiffly, hands clasped together in her lap. Her eyes were dark with fury and Catra could just smell the aggression rolling off of her.

Catra wasn't in the mood. Her anger had drained away on the walk over and she was just anxious to hear from Adora again, to know that she was okay. Her worry was overshadowing all of it, and she actually took that as a good thing. Past Catra would have been stuck on the anger for days, letting it leak into every word and action.

"Catra," Sharon started, voice clipped. "Where were you?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Out."

The only evidence that the annoyed response surprised her was the tiny inhale that Sharon couldn't seem to mask. She knew how easy it was for Catra to pick up on her emotions through her scent and body language, and she always tried to make it a point to project as little as possible. It was always a laughable attempt, because Catra could still always tell. Living with her for so many years had made Catra a pro at reading her at this point.

"You do *not* talk to me like this."

Catra ran her fingers through her thick, long hair. "Can we maybe do this tomorrow? I'm really tired and I don't have the energy for a lecture."

Sharon hissed as she shot up from the couch. Catra was so surprised by the suddenness that she backed up out of pure instinct, but that spurred Sharon on and gave her the courage to surge forward and crack her palm against her face.

Catra's head snapped to the side, her cheek stinging.

"You ungrateful, useless *delinquent*," Sharon growled in pure fury. "I have tolerated your disrespect for long enough."

Slowly, like red ink poured into a large body of water, the anger started swirling back in. Catra's tail fluffed up in warning as well as the fur along her arms and shoulders. Her lip curled back over her fangs, but she remained frozen in place.

Sharon hadn't hit her in a long time, and the throbbing pain was dredging back worse memories that were slowly starting to crack her tough exterior.

"I took you in," Sharon continued. "I clothe you. I feed you. I pay for your schooling, even after you mauled me! Even after you reduced me to *this*!" She grabbed Catra's chin, her nails digging into her skin. "Who else would have adopted you, Catra? A feral animal like you?"

Shame and guilt washed over her, nearly as strong as the anger. This time, her instincts to run were screaming louder in her head than those telling her to fight. She was afraid to fight. Afraid to be the monster Sharon always accused her of being. The tears welled up in her eyes and Catra simply didn't have the strength to keep them inside. Sharon just stared coldly, unflinching, as the tears made dark tracks across her cheeks.

Catra smacked her hand away with a hiss. "I'll make it easy for you, then." She clenched her hands into tight fists and relished the spike of pain as her claws dug into her palms. She left Sharon standing there by the front door and rushed into her bedroom. Her heart was thundering loudly in her ears, adrenaline throbbing through her.

Almost on autopilot, Catra shoved the only few things she actually cared about in a bag and then she left. Sharon watched her silently from her previous seat, now in the dark, as Catra sniffled and sucked in harsh breaths to stamp down on her sobs. The front door slammed very loudly behind her, but it was a satisfying sound.

The fact that Sharon didn't even attempt to stop her made pain pierce through Catra's heart. She knew it was ridiculous, considering they hated each other. But it just... was it really so bad of her to wish the woman that had taken her in and attempted to raise her actually cared? That she would be sad that she was leaving?

The sobs racked through her as she stalked down the street until she couldn't see the road in front of her anymore. She collapsed on the pavement and buried her face in her arms atop her knees, legs drawn to her chest.

Every negative thought and feeling washed over her like a wave. Everything she had repressed was suddenly right there, beating down against her like Sharon had chased after her to continue the assault. The sobs were awful and painful, and without even realizing it she was digging her claws into her hair and *pulling*. Locks of her mane fell away, and Catra just kept going, sobbing as she cut her hair off. As the weight fell away, so did the emotions pressing down on her until the sobs subsided and Catra could breathe again.

The first thing she thought about when the storm clouds cleared was Adora. Adora, who was so pure and kind and beautiful, who *loved* her. Mara, who loved her too despite only knowing her for a couple of weeks. Bow, who was so happy to be her friend despite how she had treated him. And Glimmer, who had only tried to get her out of a bad situation.

Catra was done letting Sharon influence her life and ruin things without even being there.

Her eyes ached. Her face was drenched in tears and her lungs burned. She dialled Adora's number anyway.

"Catra?" Adora greeted, voice sleepy. "I'm so sorry I didn't text you."

Catra took in a massive, shuddering breath. "Adora." She somehow managed to put every single bit of emotion into just that word, and Adora knew. Of course Adora knew, she cared enough to pay attention.

Adora went silent for a handful of seconds, then Catra heard the sound of her getting out of bed and her hurried footsteps. "Do you need me to come get you?"

Catra could feel a fresh wave of tears threatening to overwhelm her. "Please."

"Where are you?"

"I'm at the address I gave you before. It's not my actual address. I'm outside."

"Okay, stay there. Are you safe?"

"I have my claws."

"Stay on the line with me, okay? We're on our way."

Catra nodded even though Adora couldn't see her. She listened to Adora talking to Mara, then the sounds of them leaving and getting into the car. Adora kept talking to her, kept reassuring her and making her snort softly in amusement. When they made it to her, Catra barely waited for Adora to get out the car before she was crawling in with her. Adora grunted softly in pain, but she wrapped her good arm around her and held on tightly. Catra buried her face against Adora's chest and let her purr drown out the anxiety in her veins.

"I'm here," Adora soothed, rubbing her hand along her back. "You're okay. We'll take care of you, okay? Did she kick you out?" Catra shook her head. "You left?" She nodded.

Mara climbed back into the car after getting Catra's bag, and then they were driving. Catra didn't move an inch off Adora's lap, because she couldn't. She didn't realize she was crying again until Adora started pressing kisses all over her face and wiping her tears away with her thumb. Adora's love and care only made her cry harder.

Mara didn't make a comment, but Catra could smell her concern. When they got to their home, Catra forced herself to get up so that she could walk herself. Adora didn't have a sling on, but she wasn't using her arm much. She still reached out for Catra's hand, and then they ended up in her bed, curled around each other.

Adora's room smelt overwhelming like *Adora.* It put Catra to ease enough that she fell asleep and didn't have a single nightmare, and it helped that Adora held her like there was no chance she would ever let go.

Adora was vibrating with anger, but she forced herself to breathe evenly and to count backwards repeatedly until she was sure she had control over herself again. Sharon Weaver was sitting on her couch, nursing a cup of tea as Adora sat across from her, glaring as angrily as she could.

Catra was up in her room getting the last of her things. It had been a week since the call and since they picked a sobbing Catra up off the street. Mara was quick to immediately accept letting Catra in, regardless of all the logistics. They only have a couple of weeks left of high school, and then they needed to figure out what they were going to do after that. When Mara told Catra that she could stay, no matter what she decided to do after school, Catra cried all over again.

Catra spent a few days after that just crying on and off, not getting out of bed and hardly eating. Adora was booked off from school while her shoulder healed again, so Catra stayed home with her. Adora let Glimmer know what was going on, so Glimmer let her mom know and Catra wouldn't be affected by the absent days.

Now, Adora was carefully watching Sharon to make sure she didnt say or do *anything* to Catra again. She was sitting stiffly, her hands in tight fists atop her lap. Sharon looked almost nervous, but she was pretending that none of this mattered to her. She barely even said a word to them when Catra forced her way inside and just silently went to her room.

Adora had a lot she wanted to say to this woman. Everything Catra had said was replaying in her mind. All of the verbal and physical abuse, the coldness. But Adora was well aware that sharing her thoughts with this woman would get them nowhere. Someone like Sharon wholly believed that she was in the right, and nothing would change her mind. Adora did not want them to get into an argument, either.

Once Catra had her stuff packed up, Mara came in to help them carry everything out. The whole while Sharon sat there drinking her tea, and when they were done Adora was glad to get out of there and away from those piercing, dark eyes. Catra relaxed the second they hopped back into the car. Adora turned to her.

"Get everything?"

Catra gave her a smile. "Yeah."

Adora studied her for a moment until she was certain Catra really was okay. Her hair was cropped short now, a result of her accidentally sheering her hair off that night. She looked really good, and the new hairstyle gave her a different vibe. It was as if she had shed the old Catra. Adora just wished she hadnt had to lose parts of herself to get here.

Catra was given the empty bedroom beside Adora's that they'd only used to store random stuff. It was mostly a pretense, though, because from the first night Catra was determined to sleep in her bed. Mara wasnt an idiot, though. While she didnt make an issue out of it, she did call them both down for dinner after they got Catra fully settled in.

Adora lightly stretched her shoulder out as they walked side by side to join Mara on the couch. Catra had been quiet since they got home, but it seemed more contemplative than sad.

"Ladies," Mara greeted them with a bright smile. She pointed at the couch in front of her. "Please, sit."

Alarms started blearing in Adora's head. Mara only ever did something like this when she wanted to have a talk. Adora gulped, wondering what the issue could be. They hadn't done anything wrong, and Mara wasn't angry at *them* for the things that had recently happened. She shared a confused look with Catra, but she seemed just as lost.

Mara plopped down on the other couch and let out a loud breath. "Okay , girls. I feel like this is an important discussion we need to have." She swapped her gaze between them. "Catra, did you get all your stuff situated?"

"I did," Catra answered. "Thanks, Mara."

"You're welcome, sweetheart. I meant it when I said this home is yours now. We can start discussing your future plans when you feel comfortable to do so. That's not what this talk is going to be, though."

Adora nervously slipped her hand in Catra's. Catra gave it a squeeze. "What' s this about?"

Mara's lips pressed together in a firm line, and Adora realized that she was *uncomfortable*. Mara let out a soft sigh. "We're basically all adults here," she started. "But you're both still young, so I just wanted to say that... whatever you get up to, please remember to practice safe sex."

Adora's face immediately dusted over in scarlet at the same time that Catra's ears pressed flat to her head and she lashed her tail.

"Mom!" Adora yelled.

Mara rolled her eyes. "Come on, I'm not an idiot. You're young. You're in love. You're horny. I get it." Adora groaned deeply and hid her face in her hands. "I just want you to be careful, okay? Please promise me that."

Catra cleared her throat. "We haven't, um..."

Adora lifted her face to stare at her. Catra looked very flustered, and she was absolutely adorable. Still, Adora wished she could just sink between the couch cushions and never come out.

"You haven't?" Mara asked them, blinking in surprise.

"No," Adora confirmed. "We're in no rush, okay? Besides, my shoulder hurts."

Mara let out a snort of a laugh and Catra groaned in embarrassment. Adora's blush remained, but she was grinning at her stupid joke. Mara reached out for a high-five that Adora happily returned. Catra groaned again.

"Is this what I'm getting myself into?"

Adora pulled her closer and kissed the top of her head. "Yes, and you love us. We're your family now and you can't get rid of us."

"Ugh, is it too late to move in with Bow instead? Or Scorpia."

Adora and Mara both laughed. There remained only a few more jokes and then some serious advise, and then they were allowed to eat dinner and pretend like the conversation hadn't happened at all. The funny thing was, after that, Adora couldn't stop thinking about Catra like that.

When she kissed her softly that night, she was almost hesitant. Catra sensed it, but she just laughed softly and then rubbed their cheeks together.

"Dont worry , Princess," she purred right into her ear . "Y ou'll have me soon enough."

Adora's face burned so hotly that she worried she would start to glow. She did manage to sleep well that night, but not without having uncomfortably hot dreams.

When they finally returned to school, people were overly happy to see her. News of what had happened spread, and Adora found out that the girls from Horde High that had assaulted her were all expelled. Glimmer was waiting by the door to their classroom when they arrived, and she shared a meaningful glance with Catra.

"Adora," Glimmer breathed. "I'm glad to see you back. Y ou look good."

"Thanks."

"And you look good too, Catra," she added. "Could we... talk?"

Catra squared her shoulders. She was in a good mood, at least, so she nodded without giving a biting comment. Adora gave her hand a squeeze and her cheek a smooch, and then she watched as the two of them walked down the hallway. Bow appeared by her side.

"They'll be fine," he told her . "They're going to work it out."

Adora watched as they started to talk. "Y eah," she agreed. "I know it will."

Since the night of the party, Catra had been doing a lot of soul searching. She realized a lot of things now—things she had been too bitter and fearful to accept before. It made her uncomfortable and guilty.

"Catra, I"—

"Before you say anything," Catra interrupted. "I'm sorry."

Glimmer blinked at her. "Wait, you're sorry?"

"Yeah." She ran her fingers through her short hair. It was wonderful, actually, being without so much hair. Not only did she feel physically lighter, but it was as if she had torn off years worth of pain right from her scalp. She also looked hot as hell, which was a huge bonus.

"The reason I shut you out all those years ago is because your mother went to Sharon to talk to her about the abuse, and after that I got the worse beating of my life. I blamed you for it, and I convinced myself you did it on purpose. I was wrong, and I'm sorry. I treated you terribly after that. It's something I'm still working on. I just want you to know that I never actually hated you. All the time, I only ever hated myself."

They stopped walking and Catra froze when Glimmer hesitantly took her hand. She inhaled deeply to settle her nerves, then accepted the hold by intertwining their fingers.

"Catra, I didn't know. I'm so sorry."

"Like you said, you didn't know."

Glimmer's eyes were shimmering. "I just wanted to help you, and I know we made all those plans to rescue you. When you asked me not to tell, I was so confused. I got angry at you, thinking you were being ridiculous for not talking to the adults about it. I didn't expect my mom to actually interfere, and she didn't mean to either." She exhaled shakily. "I'm so, so sorry."

"Hey." Catra gave her hand a squeeze. "We were just dumb kids. I've been getting over my stupid issues, okay? So if you want, we could be friends again, or whatever."

Glimmer wiped a hand across her wet eyes. "Well, I have a feeling we're going to be in each other's lives for a long time." She let out a

soft, happy laugh. "How soon do you think you guys will get married?"

Catra tossed Glimmer's hand away like it bit her, hissing. It just made Glimmer laugh harder. "You're still annoying," she growled.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Oh, calm down, *Wildcat*."

Catra started smiling. "I want to live the rest of my life with her," she admitted. Glimmer seemed surprised by the honest admission, but Catra wasn't. They were still so young, and their future wasn't even decided yet, but she knew what she wanted, and it was Adora. She couldn't picture the rest of her life without Adora in it.

"Ugh, you guys are seriously disgusting," Glimmer complained. "Seriously, the whole school has been talking about it. You're not subtle at all."

Catra's cheeks warmed. "Shut up! You're just jealous."

"Am not. I'm dating the hottest boy in this school."

"Who is half naked at all times."

"Excuse me, he is *not* half naked. He just prefers breathable clothing!"

"You mean no clothing."

They turned and headed back to class, back to Adora and Bow still standing there waiting as they bickered back and forth. Adora and Bow first looked concerned when they heard the arguing, but then they rolled their eyes when they *heard* the argument. Adora reached out for her and Catra happily sank into her arms.

"Gross," Glimmer shot at them. Catra just stuck her tongue out.

If Catra was being completely honest with herself, she actually really didn't like rugby. She found most sports to be utterly boring. What was the point? You just sat there and stared at people running around until someone won. Adora, however, went feral when it came to rugby. Catra would never force her to miss a game just because she found it brain numbing, and she could admit that watching Adora get very riled up was entertaining.

"Goddamnit," Adora cried out, her eyes wide as she stared at their TV screen. "That was so close."

Catra was happily curled up on her lap, just idly watching Adora as Adora watched the screen. She couldn't resist reaching out to trace the line of Adora's jaw, and that brought Adora's attention to her. Adora glanced down, blinking.

"You good there, babe?"

Catra's purr kicked up in volume. She let a fang slide over her lip as she smirked. "Oh, I'm *good.* Having fun?"

Adora laughed softly. "Plenty. Are you sure you don't mind? I can always switch over to something else."

Catra shook her head and leaned up for a kiss. "You watch your dumb sports, Adora. I'm watching something even better."

"Oh?" Adora's brows creased. "And what's that?"

"You," she laughed. Adora flushed, but she was clearly delighted by the answer. Despite the loud chatter from the game as a player raced across the field, Adora dipped down to kiss her deeply, and Catra could only purr louder into her mouth. Adora sighed happily.

"I love you."

Catra caressed the top of Adora's cheek. "I love you too, Adora."

Adora brushed their noses together, and then she straightened and continued yelling at the screen.

Catra knew exactly why she was sitting there in front of a rugby game on a Friday afternoon. For the woman she was still so deeply in love with;the woman she was going to marry in just a couple of months.

But more specifically, for love.

Chapter End Notes

Good?It was good, right?Thank you so much for reading! Thank you to every kudos and every comment, and to those that read without commenting, thank you as well for your time!I appreciate every single one of you. This may be the end to this fic, but certainly not to my obsession with Catradora. You can follow me on both tumblr and twitter at danijaynel. I will be working on the celebAU and a few handful of oneshots I have in the works. If you want, my ask boxand pm are always open if you want to say hi or scream about this fic!I am absolutely ruined on Catradora lmao

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!